Mission: Crimson Rescue

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26553178.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Characters:
Scorpia, Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Adora, Lonnie, Huntara, Original Characters, Swiftwind

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Crimson Waste, Rescue Mission, Not Focused On Shipping, Super pal trio, Best friend roadtrip!, Catra is going through it, sorry but I am Hordak's number one hater, being a nerd boy doesn't excuse the uh. genocide and child soldiers., Entrapta needs a hug

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Part 31 of Let's Talk About It

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by Friendlylycanthrope

Summary

The morning after the events of the Portal, Catra and Scorpia depart to rescue Entrapta from the Crismon Waste, where Hordak banished her when he discovered she was a double agent.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

"Ooooh, the *poncho cape is back!"* Glimmer cooed in delight at her girlfriend. Catra looked over her shoulder from where she was preparing for her journey, and smiled as she rolled her eyes. It had been a while since she needed to don the same obscuring clothing that she had needed when she was on the run from the Horde.

"Come on, give it a twirl." Glimmer continued, her eyes sparkling.

"You know I'm trying to *not* get noticed, right?" Catra teased. "I'm going to a barren wasteland, not on the runway."

She threw her small bag over her shoulder and walked out of the kitchen, satisfied with the provisions she had packed. Glimmer, leaning against the doorway, lightly swatted Catra's perfect rear on her way out the door. Catra's cheeks turned an embarrassing red and she hurried her pace while Glimmer followed her out.

They both walked out to the main gate of the castle, where Adora and Bow were waiting for them. Her wrist was splinted, as well as at least half of her fingers. Smaller marks and bandages peppered her skin that was visible from Hordak's torture on her. She was in no shape to be out of bed with the damage she had gotten, but Catra still knew that she would offer to help.

“Are you sure that you don’t need help?” Adora asked anxiously, already prepping a hand over the gem of the Sword of Protection that was transformed around her good arm. “We don’t know what’s waiting for you out there, or how Entrapta is. You could need healing, and I have healing powers--”

“That you still don’t know how to use.” Catra pointed out. “I have the first aid kit Glim packed me, I’ll be fine. Besides, I won’t be alone. Scorpia will be here soon in the Scorp-jet to pick me up. We can handle ourselves.”

Glimmer put a firm hand on her shoulder.

“We know you will. But nobody has ever returned from the Crimson Wastes, so we need you to stay in constant touch to know that you’re okay, or if you do need anything.”

Bow took out a few small radios of his own invention, similar in design to his tracker pad.

“One for you and one for Scorpia. In case you get separated. Extend this dial to do long range so that you can reach us. And then one for Entrapta once you find her.”

“Thanks Bowseph. Although I’m sure the first thing she’ll do with it is take this thing apart.” Catra smiled, pocketing the three devices.

“Remember to stay hydrated, the desert is extremely hot.” Adora reminded her. “And stay out of the sun, or you’ll get a heat stroke, especially with your fur. Wear a hat so you don’t burn.”

Outside, the strong wind of an air jet picked up as Scorpia descended. Her jet, a small aircraft shaped like a sinister scorpion, was one they hadn’t seen since the getaway at Princess Prom. But with the Fright Zone abandoned, Scorpia was able to retrieve her family’s signature vehicle and bring it to her new home, along with more supplies for her growing population depending on her.

Six jets blasted the ground with hot air, drowning out any sound until it gently landed on its delicate insect like feet. The engines stilled to a loud whir from their thunderous roar, and a moment later the front windshield slid open for a familiar face.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia beamed. She climbed out of the cockpit, followed by Lonnie. “I’m so glad you’re okay!”

A rush of relief ran through Catra on seeing her. The last time they saw each other was inside the portal, where she had failed to save Scorpia from being taken by the void.

“I’m glad to see you too, Scorps.” Catra smiled, trying to keep it cool. “I will allow you to hug me for four to five seconds--”

“Forty five seconds?!” Scorpia beamed, already rushing in.

“No-- Four TO five!” Catra’s muffled voice came from Scorpia’s embrace, totally smothered in affection. But, she gave in and hugged back, unable to keep cool how happy she was to see her friend.

“Lonnie, didn’t expect to see you here.” Bow greeted the former soldier as she joined the group.

“Oh I’m just hitching a ride.” Lonnie explained politely. “I have a meeting with the Minister of Social Security to touch base on our operations.”

“You mean the Queen?”

“Angella may be Queen of Bright Moon, but not of our independent kingdom. We recognize Princess Scorpia. Anyway, thought I would catch a ride and it was on the way anyway.”

Scorpia finally released Catrafrom her grip, and the smaller girl didn’t shy away from the embrace like she would have years ago.

“You did it.” Scorpia said more quietly, full of pride. “You got the information out. You stopped the portal. I knew you could do it.”

At that, Catra's ears did turn down with a hint of reservation, both unsure of receiving the compliment from her friend and sad at what it had cost her.

"That's not the only promise I made in there." Catra said with new determination to change the subject. "Let's say our goodbyes and hit the road already so we can save Entrapta."

Catra turned over to her two girlfriends for their last farewell before her adventure.

"I'll be gone a few days minimum, hopefully not more than a few weeks. But radio me if you need anything." Catra said.

"Only if you promise to call us if you need anything." Glimmer agreed.

"If you need back up, we can be there within half a day." Adora confirmed, still anxious.

"I'll be okay. It's not like we're going into battle against an army, it's just a lifeless wasteland." She paused, looking like there was more she wanted to say before she left. "But… I will miss you guys."

Her girlfriends wrapped her up in a calming embrace.

“We’ll miss you too, Cat.” Adora said. “Just come back to us in one piece so we can celebrate the end of the war together, okay?

“There’s another reason I need you two to hold down the fort here.” Catra whispered darkly. They kept their huddle, but lifted their heads to make eye contact. “Hordak. He’s still a threat as long as he’s at large.”

“You think it’s possible he’ll make a move now, when he’s so weak?” Adora asked slowly. It didn’t seem likely.

“I don’t think the war will truly be over until we have him locked down.” Catra explained. Glimmer took her hand quietly.

“It’s okay, nothing will happen. Etheria is safe now. He’s just one man.” She tried to comfort.

“Still…” Catra seemed unsure. “Just keep your eyes open, okay?”

She pulled away from their embrace and they all looked each other over lovingly, hoping it wouldn’t be long until they could embrace again.

“Remember to stay in bed, Adora.” Catra smirked at her, knowing that the warrior would do everything to avoid her prescribed bed

rest during her recovery. Even just coming here was pushing it.

"Oh I plan on convincing her to stay put." Glimmer teased, wrapping an arm around the shoulders of the tallest of the three of them. The dark look in her eye implied that she had her ways of convincing, probably involving less clothes. Adora's cheeks reddened at the thought, and she bit her lip. Catra chuckled.

"Okay, don't have too much fun without me." She teased back at both of them.

Catra looked over her shoulder to where Scorpia was saying goodbye to Lonnie by the Scorp-Jet. She quirked an eyebrow curiously at the pair, noticing the closeness with which they stood together. It wasn't just Scorpia's lack of boundaries either, there was something in the way that Lonnie reached up to gently pat Scorpia's cheek fondly before they parted that told Catra all that she needed to know.

"Keep us updated as you go!" Glimmer waved.

"We'll miss you!" Adora added, leaning on her smallest girlfriend.

Scorpia and Catra climbed into the jet, waving one last time before their engines started up again and the ship was slowly pulling away into clear skies.

Despite the roar of the engines outside, the cockpit of the jet was shockingly calm, perfectly blocking out the sound of the thrusters to allow for conversation. Out the windshield, they were soon only accompanied by small whisps of clouds as they reached their cruising speed.

Catra popped her feet up on the dashboard while Scorpia drove them West, towards the Crimson Waste. She smirked in anticipation of what she was about to say.

"So, you and Lonnie, huh?" She said, trying to act casual as she inspected her nails. She didn't need to look over to feel Scorpia's reaction in the small space. She sucked in an enormous breath nervously, tried to hold it, then let it shudder out. Her face turned pink and she giggled nervously.

"Oh my gosh, is it that obvious? I can't help it, she's so cool! Oh man and I tell ya, she has been a *huge* help with Safety! Seriously she has been --"

"Crushing on you." Catra interrupted. It wasn't what Scorpia was going to say, but she wasn't about to correct her. Scorpia gasped.

"Wait do you think so? I wasn't sure!" Scorpia looked over to Catra hopefully. Catra gave her a comforting smile.

"From what *I* saw, it looked like she was interested. And that was only for like, two minutes. It is a little unexpected though. I didn't

know you had feelings for her! Why didn't you come to me!"

Scorpia shrugged.

"I don't know! I mean, is that weird? We had that whole *awkward situation* a few years ago, I wasn't sure, plus you're always talking about Boundaries,"

Catra scoffed light heartedly.

"Oh Scorps, that was years ago. That is so in the past. I'm honestly just glad that you were able to move on from that! Besides, I came to you about all this Glimmer and Adora stuff." They both laughed at that. Scorpia relaxed and leaned back into her seat, keeping her claws on the wheel as she sighed smittenly.

"Well what can I say." She explained. "I guess I just really like tiny butch women."

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When they arrived over an endless swathe of yellow sand under the hot sun, they started to look out for places to land.

Turned out, the Crimson Waste wasn't as barren and featureless as the average desert, but peppered with mountains and cliffs, canyons and towering bones that had stood quietly for centuries against sandstorms and sun. Catra briefly wished that she had a map so they wouldn't get lost, but no such thing existed. Few Etherians ventured into the desert, and those that did never came back. She would have to do her best to memorize the landmarks they passed.

She noticed that Scorpia was driving them around looking for a spot to land.

"Right here, there's a big clearing at the top of this canyon." Catra pointed out. But Scopira seemed unsure, and shook her head.

"It's out in the open. We should find more of a cover to conceal the jet while we search."

"Why would we do that?" Catra asked. "It's not like there's anyone around to steal it or anything. Nobody followed us here. No reason it would just fly away without us."

"I know, but always best to play it safe, right?" Scorpia defended with a shrug. "The horde always said, never leave an unattended vehicle in an unfamiliar area."

“We’ll be fine.” Catra waved her off. “Let’s not burn up all our fuel looking for a place to land. Just take us down already.”

“Alright.” Scorpia conceded to the reason of her old commander. After all, Catra was the brightest and cleverest strategist in all of Etheria.

She carefully maneuvered the Scorp-Jet to land on the smooth rocky surface at the top of the canyon. After shutting it down, they both climbed out and looked over the cliff at a beautiful landscape of red bluffs, bleached bones, and scatterings of dangerous cacti across the inhospitable landscape they needed to trek.

“Okay.” Catra said after a deep breath of hot, dry air. “We’re two expert trackers and former military officers. Entrapta is one excitable loud mechanic. And between us is a lifeless wasteland. Between the two of us, we should be able to find her in no time.”

“That’s the spirit!” Scorpia cheered from her side. “And then the Super Pal Trio will be reunited!”

They walked off into the heart of the desert at midday full of confidence that nothing would go wrong.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> I have not posted in so long because my mother passed away recently. I haven't really been able to do much, I'm just with my family... Hopefully I can start to get back to the things that make me feel happy again soon. I had half of this done before the news, so I finished polishing it up so I could get an update out. I promise, I will never drop this project completely. It might just take some time.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra scanned over the dusty landscape with her spyglass. The horizon stretched out before her, orange landscape blending with accents of purple rock and bone.

"Huh." She remarked curiously. It was strange, but it almost seemed like there was already a pre-existing path that cut through and around the hills and bluffs. The path was firm packed, as though from years of being walked on by generations of movement. It would be strange, since nobody ever came in or out of the Crimson Waste. But, she chalked it up to being an ancient highway of a lost civilization that used to dwell here, perhaps in the time of the first ones. Bow's dads would surely love to do an archaeological survey here.

"Do you see any signs of her?" Scorpia asked at her side. The old Catra would have made a mean reply about what signs of a missing mad scientist would actually look like. It wasn't like she

left a note to her coordinates. But she wasn't the old Catra any more.

"She would probably try to find shelter from the sun." Catra theorized out loud, still looking over the vast landscape. The wind picked up, spraying them with more sand and wrapping them in an inescapable warmth that had become a constant discomfort. At least for Catra. Scorpia was quite verbal about how her tough exoskeleton was loving this climate. Perhaps her Scorpion ancestors originated from this hostile environment, leaving behind these ancient highways she had been noticing.

"There." Catra handed over the telescope and pointed to a feature a few miles to the West. Scorpia observed it as Catra explained. "Looks like those giant bones make a sort of cave. It's the closest spot to the place where her skiff would have crashed."

They had already found the drop off point, where her skiff, set to remote driving only, would have crashed into the desert once it ran out of fuel. After a quick investigation, they determined that Entrapta must have still been unconscious when it went down, otherwise she could have rewired it to take her back. There wasn't too much sign of injury, on the bright side, and the trail was disappearing as the winds constantly rearranged the sands.

"Huh, that's odd. It looks like there's some sort of road just before it." Scorpia pointed out.

"I noticed it too." Catra said, eyeing the darker path of gravel that ran from north to south between them and their target. "It might

be from a long time ago though. I doubt it leads anywhere any more."

"Should we take the Jet?"

"No, we gotta save fuel for getting back out of the desert. It looks like we can make it if we walk within an hour."

"Got it!" Scorpia happily complied, as though Catra were still her commanding officer. Her loyalty knew no bounds to her friends, and she trusted Catra with her life more than she trusted it in her own claws. "But first! We gotta *fuel up* ourselves, eh Wildcat?"

"Is that a beach bag?"

Scorpia had a canvas bag slung over one shoulder that was so big it might as well have been a backpack. The decorative scorpion print on it was surely to make it look more personalized, but by someone with a steadier hand than Scorpia had. The robust metal canister of water which she pulled out of the bag that bore scratches and dents seemingly in the same shape as the pattern on her pincers, however, was much more her style.

"Yeah! Well no, it's just a bag. But I could bring it to the beach!" Scorpia happily blabbered while she held the water out to Catra. "Lonnie made it for me during one of the crafter's fair workshops! You remember, from that big to-do we had over at Safety a weeks ago--"

Catra smiled and raised an eyebrow, seeing the prized possession in a new light.

"So *Lonnie* made it for you, huh?" Catra teased playfully. SCorpia smiled as her ears turned red to match the soil around them as they walked towards the skeleton like structure in the distance.

"Haha yeah." Scorpia said dreamily. Catra rolled her eyes at how smitten Scorpia was, grinning with satisfaction. "She is so good at making things! I mean, way better than me anyway." Scorpia continued rambling. "Like we wanted everyone to be able to know how to make and fix stuff in their new homes, so we set up all kinds of workshops-- I sent you an invite! It must have gotten lost in the mail-- and we had these artisans come from all over, but wouldn't you know it I just could *not* manage anything with these big beefy claws! The pottery class was a nightmare; I still think I haven't washed all the gritty clay out from my claws and- HA you should have seen the instructor when I almost cut right through most of the tools he gave me! So then Lonnie kind of gave me some of the things *she* made, cause I mean, who wants to eat cereal out of a horde ration plate, am I right? And she keeps on coming over to check in and bring me things that I can't make myself even though I keep *trying* to pay her back-- that's why I've been sneaking some money into her empty shoes when she isn't looking--"

"Geez Scorps," Catra shook her head holding back a chuckle. "You're telling me that she is basically furnishing your house for you since you moved, and you still don't know if she likes you back or not?" To Catra, it was the most obvious thing in the world.

“What? I don’t know! What if she’s just being a super nice friend?”

“Did any of your other friends help you like that?” Catra asked. “Kyle? Rogelio?”

Scorpia gasped, pulling her pincers up to cover her mouth at her quiet understanding of the new epiphany.

“Oh my gosh *they didn’t* . Do they not like me? Maybe I should make them something…”

Catra laughed. She would have to hold Scorpion's claw and walk her through this whole thing.

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The best friend squad was halfway to Angella’s private office, escorting Lonnie there, when they met the Queen herself. She carried a stack of papers in one arm, and walked so briskly that she almost ran through the group of teens, interrupting their catching up.

“Oh, Miss Thunderstorm! I’m so sorry to keep you waiting,” Angella apologized immediately, putting on a polite smile. Lonnie just reassured her with a friendly smile in return.

“Oh no worries, Majesty.”

“Wait wait wait, hold up,” Glimmer interjected, motioning a time out with her hands as she came between them. “Is your last name seriously *Thunderstorm?”* She gawked at the former soldier. “How did you get such a cool name! And why didn’t I know about it!” She gushed. “That’s like, the most action hero name I’ve ever heard in my life!”

Lonnie crossed her arms, and gave a sneaky knowing look at Adora before answering Glimmer.

“Oh? I thought you would know by now, that all the Horde cadets get to choose their own last names when they’re kids.”

Adora went pale. She had feared and put off this day ever since she came to Bright Moon, and now Lonnie was blowing years of work.

“My full name is Lonnie Juice Thunderstorm.” She continued proudly. “Picked it when I was seven.”

“Wait, so Horde soldiers actually have last names?” Bow asked, his mind spinning. “But that means…”

The world moved in slow motion as all four of them turned to face Adora. Lonnie wore a shit-eating grin while Glimmer and Bow looked at her almost betrayed.

“Adora!” Bow gasped as he made the connection.

“Why don’t I know my *own girlfriend’s* full name!” Glimmer joined him.

“W-well you never asked!” Adora defended as her face reddened.

“I always just assumed you didn’t *have* a full name!” Glimmer said.

“Why wouldn’t you tell us your own name, Adora? If that even is your real name!” Bow lamented with over exaggerated theatrics. “I don’t even know who you are any more!”

“Oh,” Lonnie chimed in, her devious smile growing. “She never told you what she picked?”

The attention was off of Adora, but now she wished she could stop this train.

"Don't!" Adora warned her foster-sister, but Lonnie's eyes sparkled.

"That's cause her full name," Lonnie drew out, eating up all the eager attention she was getting from the best friends and finally getting back at Adora for every slight when they were young. "Is Adora Happysmile Rainbowfist!"

"Et tu, Lonnie? *Et Tu?* " Adora whined over the chorus of insufferable *AAWWW* s that broke out of Glimmer and Bow. Even Queen Angella had to clap a hand over her mouth to contain her fit of laughter, a small snort escaping her, while her daughter refused to hold back the onslaught of gleeful mirth. "I was like five!" Adora claimed in her embarrassment.

"How did we never know this!" Bow squealed.

"Honestly, we should have asked for your file!" Glimmer choked out between laughs, pointing to the files that her mother carried which held the information on horde defectors.

"Well, Adora and Catra defected separately." Lonnie pointed out, trying to recover herself. "We only have files on those that defected during the Immigration."

"Besides," Added Angella, helpfully joining in the fun. "I asked Catra about creating files for herself and Adora after the Immigration. And she threatened my life if I ever documented such things. And now I finally understand why!"

"She *What!"* General Abner's unmistakable voice echoed down the hall furiously, which only caused more laughter.

"Oh oh oh!" Bow said. "Wait, what is Catra's name!" He asked Adora. Adora held up her good hand in defeat.

"Oh it's more embarrassing than mine. But *I'm* not going to be the one that she has to be mad at later for telling."

The attention quickly swiveled back to Lonnie.

"Catra? Her full name *is* worse. That's why I waited two years longer to pick mine. We were dumb kids." She laughed. "It's *Catra Applesauce Meowmeow! "*

This time even Angella couldn't help but let out a laugh.

"Perhaps if I had known that, I wouldn't have been so intimidated by her when she came here. No matter, we have much to discuss,

Miss Lonnie.” Angella walked back down to her office, leaving the best friend squad to collect themselves.

“To think. We were always seeing her as this fearsome, imposing, capable leader shrouded by darkness before she defected.” Bow said in amusement. “She still is all those things. But remember when we found her in the woods? And she was all mysterious and deadly? Her middle name was *Applesauce!”*

“Hey, we were *five* ,” Adora pointed out again. “I mean, it’s not like the princesses are much better. Mermista the mermaid princess? Frosta the Ice princess? You’re an archer named Bow for crying out loud!” She was hardly offended, more bummed out if anything. But the amusement had still reached her, right when her full name was revealed.

“Come along, *Miss Rainbowfist,* ” Glimmer took Adora’s arm while overplaying the theatrics as though she were at a cordial ball and greeting a high diplomat. “I promised the great Lady Meowmeow that I would keep you off your feet whilst you recover. We must retire to the royal chambers poste haste.”

Adora rolled her eyes and chuckled. She would be hearing about this from the best friend squad for a while.

Chapter End Notes

If you didn't see the beginning notes: I haven't updated because my mother passed away recently. I will get back to writing eventually but I need some time with my family. Thanks for your patience.

Underground

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra decided she hated walking around in the desert. Actually, she just hated the desert.

She thought that she hated water. But this place? So much worse than Salineas. The sand got in all her fur, under her claws, in every little nook and cranny. The terrain was so loose and shifty at times, that it took athletic maneuvering just to stay upright, micro-correcting every step. In general, she preferred places where she could easily disappear if she needed to, somewhere to hide. But the desert was wide open, nowhere to hide, not even a morsel of shade from the heat of the daymoon.

Scorpia, however, seemed to be built for this kind of climate. Catra swallowed second-hand guilt wondering if this was the kind of place she could rule over as princess if the horde hadn't ruined her kingdom. The same army that she wielded against most of the world at a time.

But that was in the past. If she wanted to rescue Entrapta from this wasteland and get back to Bright Moon for the end of the war celebrations, she would need to get her head out of the past.

If Catra wasn’t so out of breath from the uphill trek, she would still be teasing Scorpia about her growing crush. They laughed and shoved until it became too exhausting to keep up in the heat.

The skeletal frame loomed before them on top of the dune, dusty purple against the harsh oranges of the landscape. A series of cracked and withered ribs reached up for the sky. It’s long, horned skull still hung open at the jaw, an echo of terror from another eon. And yet, signs of life persisted, clinging to this structure in the form of tarps and ropes that held the behemoth together for shelter.

“Hopefully we can at least find some clues in here.” Catra grumbled as she walked through the mouth of the beast towards a curtain that led to the secluded shade. “If she isn’t here, we could at least get a better lead.”

Catra pushed aside the tattered sheet and could instantly feel the temperature of the air drop a few degrees in the dark cover of the shade. But she could also feel the presence of several dozen or so other people instantly watching her and Scorpia, and she stiffened.

People of all different species fixed the pair with vicious glares. The interior was far from abandoned, but resembled a bar. Not just any bar, but the sort of sketchy, perilous place that nobody knew how to find unless they were on the run from the law, the kind that only crusty low-life thugs would hang out at in hopes of finding that ‘one last job.’ They could be found in any major city in Etheria. Even the Fright Zone had these types of uninhabitable zones, full of their own army’s bounty hunters.

Most of the people were not human or elf, a contrast compared to most of Etheria that Catra had seen where the opposite was true. Many were lizard-folk, the rest Catra hardly recognized. Some looked like her, others looked like something else entirely. All of them looked ready to fight her at the slightest provocation.

In the same half a second that it took Catra to absorb the shocking discovery, she came to the important decision that she needed to defend herself by blending in with them. Her ears picked up and her tail swung threateningly behind her as she unsheathed her claws, trying to look fierce. It wasn't difficult for her.

"Just follow my lead for now." She whispered over her shoulder to Scorpia.

They made their way into the establishment and most of the eyes on them went back to other matters. Catra hissed at one bug-eyed woman with one antenna who made a sour face at her, and she turned away. The more she looked, the more weapons she saw.

"But I thought that the Crimson Waste was an abandoned-- well, y'know, *wasteland* ." Scorpia whispered back to Catra. Nevertheless, she squared her shoulders and followed in trying to blend in, even though the awestruck curiosity on her face gave her away. Catra took a seat at the corner of the bar, where she could turn just slightly in order to see the large room they were in. Low, guarded conversation picked up again all around them. There were even people watching her from the ceiling rafters,

people who had ears like hers but looked like they could even give She-Ra a run for her money. She was more concerned with the indigo-scaled snake woman that carefully watched her with slitted pupils from over the rim of her glass while all the others slowly lost interest in the newcomers.

"Clearly our records were wrong. I don't think anybody in Etheria knows about this place--except for all the people here." Catra thought out loud while she drew her whittling knife. Best to let these people know she was armed too, not to mention carve out a piece to help her think. Just like Razz always said, When there's fear, carve it clear.

"I don't see Entrapta anywhere here…" Scorpia squinted around the room, and most people quickly looked away as her gaze drew near. She didn't even have to try like Catra did to look intimidating, her height and weight alone could conquer most folks in this place, not to mention her claws, tail, and armored plates along her body. Little did they know that it wasn't Scorpia they had to look out for, it was her shorter, skinnier companion with the pile of wood shavings.

"No, but maybe one of these people have seen her. If there's a place like this, there's bound to be more. Somebody must know something."

"What do you want." The woman behind the bar towered over Catra, her blue skin holding tattoos and piercings, her four horns scratched and battle-damaged. There was no 'what can I get for you' type of customer service at an outlaw's den like this.

“We’re looking for someone.” Catra chose her words carefully, making sure to show her black claws. The woman sniffed and crossed her arms. “An old friend.”

The woman squinted and grunted in disapproval, her lip curling to reveal yellowed tusks.

“I might know something, I might not.” She spat.

Catra didn’t bring any money with her to the waste, thinking she wouldn’t need it. Aside from that, it wasn’t something she normally carried with her since she got used to living in Bright Moon, where all her needs were taken care of. Her stomach turned sour just at the thought that she was becoming spoiled and cared for.

“Well? I got other customers,” The woman said impatiently as Catra mentally patted all her pockets. But before she could ask about making some sort of alternate arrangement, Scorpia dropped a few pieces of metal on the counter from her pincer, the prototype coinage of New Scorpiana; on one side showing its amount and on the other, a stylized symbol of her own curling scorpion tail.

The woman picked it up quizzically, unfamiliar with the currency, and examined it while Catra gave Scorpia a grateful look.

“Hmmm. Don’t recognize it, but it's genuine copper and silver.” She concluded, pocketing the coins between her breasts. “So, who is it you’re looking for anyway.” She said, leaning on the counter by her elbows, bringing their faces closer so they could lower their voices.

“A mad scientist.” Catra said.

“Engineer.” Scorpia corrected.

“Her name is Entrapta.” Catra continued as though uninterrupted.

The woman leaned back and glanced around the room, then swiped a thumb over her nose inconspicuously, acting casual.

“Oh her.” She said dryly. “Yeah, she died.” And she turned around to wipe her counters free of the drool of a passed out lizard. Catra froze, she couldn’t even breathe. That couldn’t be right. There was no way that could be true.

Were they too late?

They didn’t have a second to even share a panicked glance with each other, as a new threat appeared from across the bar. Seeing that they were left by the barkeep, the indigo snake woman tapped her friend’s shoulder as a signal, and they both surrounded Catra and Scorpia in a few steps. The woman kept

Catra in her seat with her talon-like fingers pushing on her shoulder, and her friend, A giant heavyset sea elf, did the same with Scorpia. Catra cursed.

"You look familiar..." The sea elf growled in a wet voice. There were tanks and tubes around his neck and chest filled with water, probably an accommodation that allowed his kind to exist at all out here in the hot, dry climate. It kept his skin moist and sticky, and he stank of rotting fish.

"Yess, Sso uncommon, to ssee folkss such asss yoursselfss here.." The snake woman chimed in, annunciating the S's in her speech. Catra realized it was because she was missing one fang, as only its twin poked out from her jaw alone.

"You must have us confused with someone else," Catra said in a low voice, a threat that they wanted to be left alone. But their grips on their shoulders tightened.

"I don't think so." The sea elf gurgled, the words tripping over his double chin, and each spine on his skin twitching. "I wouldn't forget the Force captain that ambushed my grotto." Catra didn't betray any sense of confusion in her expression, leveling him instead with a challenging glare. "Three generations, my family used that grotto passage for our black market dealings, never a whiff to the authorities of Salineas. Then five years ago, it was seized by the Horde out of nowhere. Decades of crime undone in a day, it did. I've known no peace since I was forced out of me own home. And I remember the split devil's eyes that helmed that lead ship."

Shit . Catra knew exactly what he was talking about. Back when she was working with Adora while she was inside the Horde, they tried to work together to gain enough ground that their superiors on both sides wouldn't grow suspicious of their reducing civilian fatalities. They tried to end the war by deescalating where they could, working together to make sure that no unnecessary lives were at risk, no essential supplies were lost, minimalized casualties. They had a steady line of victories under their belt that wouldn't involve decimating the other side, kept tabs on the movement of the others' armies all while their commanders were none the wiser, only letting their closest comrades know. And one of the plots that they had gotten away with was when Adora told Catra about the illegal trafficking of firearms, drugs, and slaves that had been untraceable in Salineas. It was a problem for the rebellion, and something the Horde could gain from if they seized their secret trade routes. That way Catra would win the favor of Hordak without trampling innocent villages. It took her a month to track them down based on what Adora had told her, and only a day to overtake their base by naval attack. Hordak was pleased with the secure location, the confiscated firearms, and captured criminals he could put to work in his armies.

Apparently, she still wasn't free from the sins of her past, and paying the price for it. But while they could threaten her life all they wanted, they had no business bringing Scorpia into this. Besides, if she had any hope of finding the truth about Entrapta, they had to move.

Catra desperately surveyed the room for a chance out. The bar woman clearly saw them in distress, but didn't seem to care. In fact it seemed to be the case with all of the ruffians that were close enough to notice them, nobody bat an eye at the threat of impending violence in the corner. Some even watched with bored curiosity, wondering what the result would be and perhaps placing bets.

“Hold up!” a new female voice cut in, gruffly taking the sea-elf’s arm, needle-like claws digging into his sticky blue skin. Catra caught a glance of white fur, stained orange with the dust of the desert, over the man’s shoulder. “No way you’re taking these two and turning them in for all that gold!”

Instantly, everyone in the tavern fell silent, the chattering halted and the quiet activities put on pause as everyone looked over to their corner. Catra’s heart raced. The sea-elf threw his arm to wrench it free of the woman’s grip.

“Nobody deserves it more than me! You lay off if you know what’s good for ya!” He threatened her. But already, the other patrons of the quiet bar were standing up, and surrounding the whole group of them, weapons ready, and eyeing the prize of the pair of them with greed. The sailor seemed to realize this two seconds after Catra, when they were fully surrounded. He reached backwards blindly for the bar until he felt a bottle, and smashed the bottom against the counter. He held the neck, pointing it at the advancing crowd of ruffians.

“Go ahead and try to take them! I ain’t scared!”

With that signal, it was almost like the permission was given and the whole building erupted into riot and noise, clashing violence and blades zinging through the air. Catra and Scorpia were fast to react from their decades of military experience, ducking to the ground just as a bleeding frog man went flying over the bar. Scorpia quickly used her hard carapace body to cover up Catra’s

smaller body, tripping the sea elf who intended to capture them as he stumbled backwards over them.

"Okay that didn't work," Scorpia had to speak in a raised voice over the clatter of the brawl. Someone tried to dart through the crowd straight to the pair as they hid, and Scorpia quickly lashed out her tail and paralyzed him as soon as he was within range. Catra quickly grabbed his dagger from his stiff fingers.

"We need to get out of here, fast!" Catra agreed. But everywhere she looked, their exits were blocked. As far as she could tell, the only main way in or out was the main door they had come through, and it was on the opposite side of the building from them. Catra stood to her full height to look around, quickly uppercutting and shoving aside a lizard person who came at her without even looking at their face as she scanned the walls.

"This way, quickly!" A female voice called out, the same one from before that announced to everyone the bounty on their heads. Catra looked over the bar, and saw a white magicat with short hair, a dark gray patch over one eye and a thick fluffy tail, extending her hand to her. One of her feet was already disappearing down a trap door that was concealed behind the bar. Catra held the knife to her threateningly while Scorpia covered her back.

"How can we trust you?" She demanded. It may have been a way out, but she was the one that put them all in danger in the first place.

“Come on, I’m not taking you by force which is better than everyone else here!” She insisted urgently. “Do you want to get out of here walking or hogtied?” Her annoyance with the delay was present in the way her tail lashed impatiently. Catra could hear the sting of Scorpia’s tail lashing once again at a would-be assailant as she quickly did the math.

If she turned out to be hostile, Scorpia and Catra could take her. They’ve faced far worse odds in the past.

Seeing her make up her mind, the woman dashed down the soil-carved stairs, and Catra followed after her, signalling to Scorpia to follow. The trap door shut behind them, and they continued down at least two stories of stairs in near total darkness until they hit the lower level, where it became a long passage.

The further they got from the secret entrance, the darker their surroundings became. But as soon as they reached the hallway at the end of the stairs that led them here, their guide took an unlit torch from the wall and lit it with her flint. The area around them suddenly flushed to a flickering orange life in the flame, including the visage of their guide.

The darkness was soothing after the intensity of the glaring sun, and being so far beneath the earth they noticed that the temperature was several degrees cooler, another incredible relief. It smelled as earthy as it felt, harder packed dirt beneath the loose and shifting sand being carved away seemingly over decades or longer. The ground was lumpy, worn down by the footprints of hundreds of others before them walking these same paths. If they listened closely, the echoes of their footsteps could

almost sound like the distant whispers of the ghosts who created this secret place.

As for their host or potential captor, she was a slight woman, a white magicat with her hair kept buzzed short. She had an occasional gray splotch of markings over her body, including one that covered less than half her face over her right eye. She was dressed lightly, and had ropes and belts that looked like they were meant for climbing or exploring caves, but enough to allow full movement and agility and keep her cool and unburdened in the desert sun.

"My name is Gemma. No need to introduce yourselves, I already know from what just happened. High General Catra, second in command of the Horde empire, and Force Captain Scorpia. Not every day that someone as high profile as you comes into the Crimson Waste."

"Well to be fair there, we didn't know there was anything or anyone out here at all." Scorpia said. Gemma turned to lead them down the long corridor, and the two followed her as they talked.

"Criminals, outlaws, bandits, anyone who is on the run from someone comes out here. It's the one hiding place that nobody wise would follow. But we still live here, if you can make it. So what would bring two horde officers to our home?"

"We were looking for our friend. She was banished here by Hordak not long ago." Catra answered curtly, her heart sank when she remembered the uninterested way that the bar woman had

told them the news. “But it might have been for nothing.” She said more quietly, with a dour face. “Also, the horde isn’t a thing anymore. We both defected ages ago, and just recently took down Hordak, the war is over and the army was disbanded.”

“Well, not a lot of news travels here easily. It’s kind of a dead zone.” Gemma shrugged. “Although, I do have news for you about your friend. The engineer?”

“You do?” Scorpia said eagerly.

“Yes, she is alive. But you need to collect her and leave the Waste as soon as possible.”

“Wait, what?” Catra grabbed her shoulder and forced her to stop and look at her.

“Is she alright?”

“A minute ago we were told she died. How can we trust you? You could just be leading us straight into a trap.”

“But if she isn’t lying,” Scorpia interjected at Catra’s side. “Then we can’t give up hope! I’m not going to forgive myself if I leave without checking every lead. We have to try!” She implored.

“Listen, there’s this code of thieves honor around here.” Gemma explained, putting up her free hand to show as though to show her unarmed innocence. “Not everyone lives very *honorably* out here in the Waste, but most still adhere to this out of self-preservation. The tradition is, that if some unknown stranger comes around asking for someone, you claim that they’re dead. Doesn’t matter if you don’t even know who it is they’re looking for or even if that person is your enemy. The first priority is to get bounty hunters, investigators, and cops *out* of the waste before they blow up the secret about this whole place and we risk out entire way of life. Obviously two horde officers-- or, I’m sorry, *former* officers-- coming and looking for a mad scientist would be terrible for everyone here in the Waste. Imagine what the horde would do if they knew about all these people, all these resources. They were trying to get you out of here as fast as possible.”

The logic made perfect sense. Catra’s tail twitched in annoyance to comply with that much. She was about to interrogate further, when suddenly the ground rumbled and dust fell from the ceiling. The three women quickly balanced themselves and looked around in worry at the cavern as it quaked, worried about becoming trapped. But, like an oncoming thunderstorm, it merely grumbled rather than roared, and seemed to pass harmlessly as the pebbled around them stopped shivering.

“What was that?” Scorpia asked, still looking around the darkened hall as though expecting it to return any moment.

“An earthquake. Luckily one of the smaller ones. They’ve been getting more common lately. Come on, we have to move before there’s another.” She took off down the hall again with Catra and Scorpia following.

“Where are you taking us?” Catra asked.

“This path leads to a town inside a canyon, it’s known as the Valley of the Lost. It’s where most folks live and work, like me. It’ll be easier to smuggle you around and out of the Waste in the crowds there.”

“Why are you helping us? You could turn us in for the bounty, why should we trust you to actually help instead of--”

“Taking you to a trap? I did consider it. But this is more important.” Gemma interrupted. “Because your friend, that mad scientist, has been turning the valley upside down. She’s uncontrollable, and shaking up every way of life here. No personal space, infiltrating and stealing from anyone once she decides she needs something, and pissing off every single gang leader there is. We’re on the verge of an all out turf war just for her *curiosity*. And what’s worse: as soon as she got here, the earthquakes started! And they’ve only been getting worse.”

“That does sound kind of familiar.” Catra smiled at the chaos her friend was able to cause.

“You just have to know how to handle her.” Scorpia agreed with equal fondness.

“Yeah, no thanks.” Gemma said irritably. “You need to take her *out* of the Waste so she can leave us alone. I’m trusting you to never let her back here once you are out of sight! Grab your friend and leave this place as fast as you can.”

“Well at least we both want the same thing.” Catra said. “But I don’t understand how Entrapta could be causing these tremors. Her thing is tech, she isn’t an elemental princess.”

“Princess Onyx could.” Scorpia added helpfully “The Earth-powered princess from the West. I’ve been studying all the princesses lately as part of becoming one. But she’s miles away, still in her kingdom according to the latest intel. It’s like you said, Entrapta isn’t even an elemental princess. She doesn’t even have a runestone. She doesn’t really have any powers aside from her hair, which she probably made herself.”

“It’s probably just a coincidence.” Catra shrugged off. “Just some witch hunt, totally unrelated.”

“Oh it’s her alright.” Gemma said with certainty. “She always shows up right at the center of them *right* before they start, then she collects all the data and disappears again.”

“We’ll see about that.” Catra mumbled. She did not appreciate the way that they talked about the Princess who held a major part in ending the war that they all hid from. She was no stranger to taking the blame for any little coincidence that bothered those around her. One figure in particular never failed to villainize her, even as a child.

They continued to walk down the dusty cavern in quiet, with only the hollow echoes of their feet.

"We're almost at the Valley of the Lost. I know a guy. He can help us find your friend." Gemma explained over her shoulder. Soon her torch lit an end to the tunnel, a cavern wall. A rusted metal ladder glowed lightly in the flame light, taking the tunnel straight up only about fifteen feet, still too dark to see.

"After you." Gemma smiled, waving them ahead of her to the ladder. But Catra didn't move, and so Scorpia didn't either. Their guide sighed and rolled their eyes, putting her torch in a holder on the wall similar to the one at the beginning of the tunnel which she had taken it from, before climbing up herself. Only then did the other two follow her up.

At the apex of their climb, Gemma struggled only for a moment to open the hatch above her. Unlike the one they descended through, this one was some sort of round metal rather than a square of wood, and it had a large cranking mechanism to lock it. As soon as it cracked open, bright desert light poured in strong and hot. The hinges squealed as the door opened, and Gemma climbed out. Catra followed first, then Scorpia.

Where they found themselves next was some sort of store room, with shelves lined with bottles and cartons of food. The oppressive heat was surrounding them once again, much to Catra's further dismay.

“What is this place?” Catra started quickly, eager to take her mind off the dry air. She followed Gemma to the only door out of their pantry closet. What lay beyond the door seemed to answer her question for her: They were in a bar, not much unlike the one that the tunnel connected to. Instead of tapestries hung over an ancient ribcage for shade, it was built out of clay in a round structure, and one wall seemed to be a cliff face that was carved out to make shelves behind the bar. There were more people mingling in this place, and they were more lively and talkative than the last bar they were at. Darts were thrown, bets were made, cards were dealt all around rather than suspicious glances from over the brim of a glass. Not to say it wasn’t dangerous, everyone here was still clearly an outlaw from the way they dressed and acted, the weapons they carried and the scars they bore.

Gemma seemed relaxed despite their surroundings, as though she were safe at her own home rather than laying in the belly of the beast, escorting fugitives with a bounty over them through a smuggler’s den, but Catra remained on edge as she counted all the threats around her, the ones she could take in a fight and those she would have to watch out for.

“The Crimson Waste is home to the largest natural canyon in Etheria.” Gemma explained. “And all inside it, is this makeshift town of bandits, built along the walls and bottom. That’s where we are now.”

“Doesn’t seem much better than that last place.” Catra grumbled, digging her nails her palms painfully, trying to find a grounding sensation in the whirlwind of a day they had had. “Worse, even. It’s crawling with criminal low-lifes. Any of them could recognize us and try to turn us in for that bounty.”

“Then maybe you should stop looking at them and letting them see your face like that.” Gemma chastised like she was explaining to a child. Catra growled and pulled the hood of her poncho up over her ears, hating how hot it would make her in the already devastating heat.

They made their way across the bar, a mainly open space floor plan aside from a few tables where diverse races of sharp-fanged criminals scowled over negotiations, cards, old tales that stretched the truth thinner than a spider’s web.

When they stepped out the door, the brilliant light almost blinded them, a far cry from the cool, dark tunnel that had led them here. When their eyes adjusted, they found an amazing sight.

Just as their guide had said, they were at the bottom of a monstrous canyon, some at least thousands of feet deep. But it was so wide that the light poured in at midday. The red cliffs surrounded them, twisting and turning paths rather than a straight path, in places it branched away into other paths, or deeper into the earth in tall caverns of orange sandstone. Just like the savannah above, more ancient bones protruded from the earth along with unusual rock formations.

Huts and tents, caravans and construction scaffolding, surrounded them in every direction, climbing up and clinging to the very walls around them. The place they had just left was one such clay dome building that was near the bottom of the chasm. In most places, the stones and bones were used in perfect harmony with their architecture; ribs used as ladders to the upper parts, rock

pillars used as support for larger structures. And all around, were the same people they had already seen. People with the faces of insects, frogs, lizards and snakes, people with tails and claws, elves and humans in rare sight, all with a wolfish snarl on their lips. There were no children, but many elders. Many missing eyes and fingers, lots of weapons on belts.

"Keep up!" Their guide yelled over her shoulder, raising her voice over the hubbub of the crowd. Scorpia and Catra rushed forward to not lose track of Gemma. Catra kept her gaze down, hiding her face and especially her distinctive eyes from anyone else that might recognize her.

"Where are we going?" Scorpia asked in a low voice, not unaware of the dangerous smugglers den they were in and the unsavory characters that were all around them.

"I know someone who can take you to your crazy friend. You can lay low there for a while, and for a pretty penny she may be able to reunite you with the scientist." Gemma explained as she walked. The course she took was winding, as the natural footpaths of the valley formed around the twists of the canyon. They seemed to be heading North, Catra noted, remembering that they had entered the desert from the South.

Just then, the low rumble in the ground started again, but stronger this time, getting closer. All around them, furniture shook and dust fell down from the cracks in the canyon and building walls while the ground rumbled beneath and around them. Everyone halted their conversations as their faces turned serious or anxious, hands steadying any fixtures around them to keep from falling. Their silence was filled with the grating of rocks until

it passed like thunder rolling over the sky, and after a cautious hesitation, normal activities resumed again, although with a more watchful and suspicious tone.

"Ugh, two in one hour? They're just getting worse." Gemma complained, eyes still on the walls with disapproval. Overheard snippets of conversation around them seemed to be on the same subject matter. Everyone was getting fed up with all the interruptions in their daily lives. Catra's fur prickled once again at the implication that Entrapta was somehow to blame.

"The sooner we can solve this the better." Catra growled. "We'll find Entrapta and be out of your hair and then we'll see if they get better."

Scorpia gasped all of a sudden and jumped, as though she had been pricked by a pin.

"Fiddlesticks!" She cursed.

"For the love of -- Just *say fuck* ," Catra groaned. But even she knew that such choice words as Fiddlesticks only ever came out of Scorpia when she was really on edge.

"Catra! Do you remember what you said when we parked here?" She forced through shut teeth, her face turning anxious. Catra's ears turned upwards, sensing her discomfort.

“What?”

“When we picked a place to land the J-E-T, remember?”

“Scorpia, everyone here knows how to spell.”

“We left in the open!” Scorpia suddenly burst out.

“What are you-- oh, shit.” Catra realized.

“It’s out in the open. We should find more of a cover to conceal the jet while we search.”

“Why would we do that? It’s not like there’s anyone around to steal it or anything. Nobody followed us here. No reason it would just fly away without us.”

“I know, but always best to play it safe, right? The horde always said, never leave an unattended vehicle in an unfamiliar area.”

“We’ll be fine. Let’s not burn up all our fuel looking for a place to land. Just take us down already.”

The hindsight was so painful it was like getting stabbed in the back. They couldn't have possibly known that the desert wasteland was full of people, not just that, but deadly criminal gangs.

"What's going on?" Gemma asked, a hint of concern.

"Our getaway ride. We left it out in the open." Catra whispered, turning her face away from all the other people on the street. Gemma leaned in with interest.

"What kind of vehicle are we talking about here?" She whispered.

"A jet?" Scorpia whispered a several pitches higher than her usual voice, as she squirmed in place like she had to use the bathroom. "What are the odds that it's still there do you think?"

Their guide's eyes widened as she leaned back, relaxed once more, and giving more confidence in her answer.

"It's been stolen; a hundred percent." She guaranteed. "Would stake my life on it. Something like that doesn't go unnoticed in this type of neighborhood. It'll probably be taken apart and sold for pieces. Probably not too far from this valley."

Scorpia’s soul temporarily floated out of her body in distraught shock before she snapped back to herself in a cold sweat of panic.

“That was a family heirloom!” She almost cried with no voice. “It’s the most intact piece of my family’s old kingdom that was still left. It was the only thing that Hordak let my family keep for joining the horde!”

“Scorpia hey, look at me.” Catra was quick to throw a life saver to Scorpia before she drowned, a bit too familiar with panic attacks of her own, or of her girlfriends’. “Hey, we can still make an action plan, okay?” Scorpia looked into Catra’s eyes desperately, trying not to let herself get carried away.

“How are we going to get out of this desert without it? It’ll take days to hike out, all I have is a beach bag with sunscreen!”

“Okay, you know what? We’ll just change plans. We gotta split up.” Catra strategized. “If you leave now you still might be able to track it down before they do too much damage, yeah? And I will find Entrapta and then we can meet up with the walkies Bow gave us. It’ll be faster that way.”

“What if I can’t find it? It could be anywhere by now!”

“If you can’t find it, then you need to focus on getting us some other way out of here. It’ll still be faster than staying together for

both things. Maybe there's an old skiff or something we could, you know, *borrow* back from them."

"Wait wait wait, you can't just split up." Gemma interrupted, concerned. "The whole reason I'm helping you in the first place is so you can get your little gang back together and get out. I'm really sticking my neck out for you folks, you're trying to make my job harder by having me track you all down all over again?"

"Thanks for the concern, but we know what we're doing." Catra retorted. "This isn't our first time in dangerous territory. Either way, we *will* need a way to get out of the desert eventually." She didn't hold back the sour taste in her voice, she didn't have any loyalty to Gemma and little reason to trust her. Her tone helped her to blend in around the den of thieves, and nobody batted an eye at the dangerous looking trio.

"If I backtrack the way we came, I can be there in half an hour if I hurry." Scorpia calculated. She had no idea where her bearings were, how far or what direction the underground tunnel had gone from their original spot. Finding it above land would be a bust.

"Radio me updates when you have something, or if you get in trouble."

"Same to you, Wildcat, Over." Scorpia saluted. Then she ducked around the crowd back to where they came from.

Catra had to admit that deep down, she was worried about what Gemma had said. Maybe they shouldn't have split up, given all the circumstances they found themselves in which they never could have planned for. But that was one of the few things that the Horde did well for them: train them for constant action, change, to come up with new plans on the fly.

She looked back at Gemma expecting her to lead the way. But the other magicat seemed annoyed, grumbling under her breath while her narrow eyes followed Scorpia. Her tail lashed behind her, the longer fluff swaying in the warm air mesmerizingly. But her ears pointed forward, trying not to give away her true disposition. Catra was too familiar, it was like looking in a mirror. It was so rare that Catra ever saw anyone like her. In both the Horde and greater Etheria that was part of the alliance, she had only ever seen probably two other people like her. She didn't even know what they were called. But in the Waste, it was like two or more of her kind were always visible just from where she stood, and it made her feel small. The world was getting bigger.

"I'm not letting you out of my sight." Gemma said, snapping Catra out of her thoughts. She shook her head, wishing she had a piece of wood to whittle to keep her mind clear. "It's been hard enough on all the people of the valley just dealing with that scientist. Now I've got you two splitting in all directions-- what's next?" She continued walking down the path, forcing Catra to follow her down the street again.

She could tell that the woman was still irked, and one part of her enjoyed that since hey, Catra didn't like her much either. She had talked poorly of Entrapta, and still hadn't given her much reason to trust her other than not turning her in for a bounty yet. On the other hand, she needed Gemma to be on her side, she was the

only lead they had to getting Entrapta back and safely out of the Waste.

"Where are we going?" Catra complained as they walked together. Gemma seemed to be taking them on a path up the side of the canyon, closer to the top rim of the valley. By now it was only a few hours after midday, and the sun was going down but the heat was not. Catra wished she could take off her hood, or just throw away the whole poncho.

"To my friend in the Upper Rim. It's on the edge of the valley. There's folks there that can find anybody."

"So why haven't you asked this friend to track down Entrapta before?" Catra challenged. "It doesn't seem like anybody here would mind getting their hands dirty if they wanted to take out the new thorn in their side."

"Some have tried.. But she's too slippery. I'm counting on the fact that you can actually handle her better than them."

The more they walked, the higher on the wall the path went, at a very slow incline. They passed many buildings and people, sellers and thugs along the way and Catra tried to remember landmarks that would help her find her way if she needed to. They passed mainly in silence, apparently both knowing what they each thought of the other. The oppressive heat surrounded Catra and found her even in the shade, without so much of a light breeze of comfort. Her fur stuck to her skin in an unpleasant sticky way, and her mouth was dry from the walking.

About twenty minutes later, Catra could just start seeing over the rim of the valley to the rest of the sandy desert beyond. Large rock faces still stood out to obscure the schism in the orange earth, nearly concealing it but leaving gaps. Even up here, tents and huts were built less densely than at the bottom where bandits and goons were still milling about.

"We'll be there soon." Gemma let Catra know. Then she stopped in her tracks suddenly with alarm, her dark ashy ears pointing upwards. Catra's own ears swiveled around like radars in response, trying to detect what sign of trouble Gemma may have caught on to.

It was a second later that she heard the ground rumble far off, starting in the valley, a few miles from the direction they had come from. She gasped as she turned around just in time to feel the ground vibrate slightly as it started, and it rapidly became more ferocious. This one was worse than the other two she had felt previously, within seconds she was barely able to keep her footing as the ledge they were on crumbled away. She swung her tail for balance as she quickly leapt backwards looking for more solid footing before the two mile sheer drop claimed her.

Catra felt a clawed hand grab at her poncho in the back and yank her back as Gemma snatched her up. She half dragged the two of them further along the ledge where a pillar formed an archway overhead, connecting the side of the cliff to the far side of their precipice. They both instinctively huddled together, heads down and arms covering their heads as rocks and sand poured in from the desert above them. Boulders collided with their covering thunderously, raining down debris as the world tore itself apart.

Catra’s ears pinned as flat as they could against her skull to block the deafening noise, she could hear people in the distance screaming in fear.

She took a chance and opened her eyes even as the chaos continued around them. Sheer slabs of the cliff face were crumbling away and sliding down into the valley, turning to dust as it tumbled down the winding path. She felt the earth shatter beneath her seat, almost jostling her off the edge all on its own as the ground continued to shake.

She couldn’t see what was coming from over the archway where they cowered. She couldn’t have heard it coming over the thunderous cacophony around them. She had no way of knowing that they were not safe under their structure, that this pillar that had lasted eons and centuries could be undone in seconds of chaos when the earth was furious enough. All she saw was the cracks in the walls, before so much dust and sand fell all around her that it completely obscured everything and she couldn’t even see her own hands, lost in a torrent like a waterfall that muffled their cries for help as they joined the chorus of mayhem around them.

Catra struggled. She lost sight of Gemma, of the ground beneath her in the shifting landscape that tried to swallow her. She couldn’t open her eyes against the sand that covered her face, filled her mouth, weighed down her limbs as the ground fell away from under her. Catra couldn't tell if she was falling with the sand off the cliff or not.

Catra struggled as long as she could, but she wasn’t stronger than all of Etheria trying to bury her alive, and when the stones

tumbled closer with each quake, the sand turned red and the world went black.

Chapter End Notes

Aaaaa sorry I'm sorry that I haven't been writing. Been dealing with grief. But I am still writing. Sorry. Probably lost a lot of readers during my hiatus there. So, thanks for sticking around, if you're reading this. Comment you thoughts. Hearing positive reviews waters my crops and feeds my family. Next will be an update to the beast you made me, so I'm alternating between updating that fic and this series. Big plans ahead, if only I could get myself to write it.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Scorpia has the best day of her life! Catra has the worst day of her life.

Chapter Notes

Aaaaa sorry its so late, hopefully the longer length of the chapter will make up for it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It hadn't been long since Catra had left with Scorpia, but Adora was already restless with worry. She was still on edge ever since they all got out of the portal reality, and was always too anxious to sit still whenever she was laid up with injuries. That plus being without Catra, who she loved so much it hurt, right when she needed her comfort the most? She was a wreck.

Aside from the fact that it was extremely difficult to pull on a jacket when five of her fingers were splinted and one arm in a sling. Hordak's torture had been thorough.

"Do you need--"

“Nope, I got it!” Adora quickly reassured Glimmer. Glimmer sighed and rolled her eyes.

Of course, she understood completely why Catra had to go. Entrapta had been banished to a lethally uninhabitable remote corner of the globe, and they couldn’t leave her behind, not again. But that didn’t make her absence any easier.

Adora was soon dressed, and turned towards Glimmer, for approval.

“You know you should be resting.” Glimmer pointed out not for the first time. She stood up from the bed and handed Adora the crutch that she placed under one arm to help her walk.

“I know, but there’s things to do.” Adora rubbed her neck guiltily.

“I know.” Glimmer gently pecked her cheek with a soft kiss. “Which is why I’m coming too, to help you.”

Adora smiled gratefully, then turned for the door. But Glimmer grabbed her shoulder.

“That doesn’t mean that you should be walking around though. We’ll go the easy way.” She insisted, then materialized them both in a shower of glitter and sparkles.

When Adora opened her eyes again, she was looking over grassy green pastures with a familiar white barn in the corner. One deep inhale of the fresh air, thick with the aroma of blooming spring flowers, was already making her feel better and more level-headed. The morning moon was still rising, and the day was fresh.

Together, the two princesses walked over to the barn door. Not seeing anyone in the field, they assumed Swiftwind and his new friends must be inside. Adora knocked on the door, to be polite at Swiftwind's residence.

"Swifty? It's Adora!" She called in. She had always been Swiftwind's main caretaker, making sure he had fresh hay and oats and apples, but ever since the arrival of Duchess and then Duke, she was trying to overextend herself into taking care of them too, especially since all the normal stable caretakers had been fired by Swiftwind when he had originally liberated all of the horses.

Swiftwind eventually pushed open the top half of the dutch-style door, revealing his head as he smacked his lips sleepily.

"Hey Adora." He said around a yawn, giving her a once over. "Man I knew Hordak was rough on you, but you look like thirteen miles of bad road." He assessed. The last time they had seen each other, she was She-Ra when they were escaping the Fright Zone.

“So I guess you don’t want these sugarcubes in my pocket that I brought..?” Adora raised her eyebrow teasingly with a smile, patting her pocket. Swiftwind’s ears went up with interest.

“Okay fine, you’ve appealed to my sweet tooth.” Swift Wind said proudly. He pushed his way through the bottom door, letting it swing behind him.

Adora smiled and held out a palm full of sugar cubes to her trusted steed, which he happily nibbled.

“Alright, let’s get started so we can get you back in bed, Adora.” Glimmer said as she unreeled some hose from the side of the barn.

“Body or wings first today, buddy?” Adora asked her friend. It was part of her morning routine on most days now, to groom Swift Wind. He was a special kind of animal with unique needs, needing both the grooming of a horse and the preening of a bird with his wings. Today, Glimmer would get to be a part of that as she assisted Adora so she wouldn’t strain herself.

“Horse coat, please.” Swift Wind answered. He lifted his wings up higher to allow access to his short white coat. He lowered his head and munched on the grass and hay around the barn while Adora and Glimmer set to work brushing him. As more time passed, Swift Wind became more anxious, tapping his hooves more and snorting and flicking his tail.

“What’s wrong with you?” Glimmer asked, patting his neck. “You’re more fidgety than I’ve ever seen you.”

“I can’t help it,” Swift Wind claimed. “Adora is anxious, so now I am.”

On the opposite side of him, Adora groaned at being called out.

“Stupid psychic bond.” She cursed out under her breath.

“Are you worried about Catra?” Glimmer asked, rounding the horse’s head to comfort her.

“Of course I am!” Adora admitted defensively. “I know it’s important, but I just feel weird having her so far away after everything that just happened with the portal.” Swift Wind nodded his agreement.

“That reality was crazy stuff.” He added with a shake of his head.

“I understand.” Glimmer said softly, planting a soft peck on Adora’s cheek. She had to lean up to reach. “But she’ll be back before you know it. She may even be on her way back right now.”

“I know, I know.” Adora closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Between her injuries and Catra being gone she could really use a distraction, part of why she insisted on coming to Swift Wind. Best to change the subject.

“How have things been going with Duke?” Adora asked. She had been anxious to make friends with the new residents, especially the little foal. But his mother was protective and wary of people, making it difficult.

“He’s a spitfire.” Swift wind smiled, looking back at the barn where he rested. “He jumps around to try and get me to play a lot, even if he wears me out. But worth it. He and Duchess are out in the pasture on the other side of the hill right now.”

“Aawww,” Glimmer said, her eyes growing in size “Swift wind, I didn’t know you could be so mature and paternal!” She cooed teasingly. “It’s like you’re his step dad!” Swift wind flicked his tail so it brushed over Glimmer’s face annoyingly.

“No, shut up.” She mumbled. Glimmer and Adora laughed.

They continued pushing the brush over his white coat to free it of debris in places he couldn’t normally reach himself.

“If I’m honest, Adora,” Swift Wind said after some thought. “And I am always an honest steed-- I think I do like having Duchess and

Duke here. More than just as roommates.” His ears flicked back and forth with uncertainty as he pawed at the grass with his hoof.

“That’s really sweet, Swifty. So why do you seem down about that?”

“I don’t know.” Her horse groaned. “She’s just so nervous all the time! I wish I could get through to her somehow. And then maybe she could notice me.”

“That’s it!” Glimmer clapped her hands, making a tiny puff of sparkles in her excitement. “We should try to get her to take notice of you, Swifty! Then maybe we can help you join her family, and we can distract Adora from being an anxious ball of nerves all at the same time!”

“Well, I have been wanting to get to know Duchess and Duke better.” Adora pondered. “But is it okay to interfere with our friend’s love life like that?” Swift Wind just shrugged as much as a horse could shrug.

“If it helps you guys feel better, sure. I’ve barely spent any time with you guys lately except for flying us out of imminent danger.”

At the mention of their near escape, Adora winced again at the memory of how they barely made it out of Hordak’s lair. Which of course made her miss Catra more. She sighed in defeat.

“All right, let’s try to set up some horses, I guess.” She agreed with a hesitant smile. “I’m sure Catra would pass on this even if she was here anyway.”

“Catra is in a hot, sunny place.” Glimmer laughed. “Her favorite climate of all time. Plus she’s with Scorpia to get Entrapta, her best friends. I’m sure that whatever she’s up to now, she’s having an amazing time.” Glimmer reassured.

*****

The dust was still settling. Boulders slid slowly down each other as they settled into place. As they scraped against each other softly, one orange slab of stone pushed upwards, struggling. It heaved for a moment, like the earth was breathing. In one final push, it flipped over like a turning page, Catra struggling for air beneath it. She coughed up the dust and sand that swirled in the air lazily, a harsh contrast to the violent changes only moments ago that had churned up the earth in the first place.

Catra wobbled on her hands and knees, dirt and clay clod densely into her hair that fell around her face. The dust dried the blood around her skin, broken open by the landslide moments ago. But she didn't waste much time, already starting to cough out names as she struggled to inhale clean air.

"Scorpia?" She sputtered almost right away, looking around at the rugged landscape she found herself in. "Scorpia! Can you hear me!"

She had no idea how far away Scorpia was when the avalanche happened. She could be miles away. Or worse, she could be trapped in that underground tunnel that they had taken with Gemma to get into this canyon.

"Gemma!" She called out next. It echoed around her on the monstrous walls that rose up around them.

Catra could remember walking almost to the top of the lip of the canyon when the earthquake started. It seemed like she was still in the canyon, back down at the bottom from sliding down with the collapsing wall. The whole valley was unrecognizable, large slopes of boulders showing the destructive path they had taken down the walls of the cliff. The whole canyon seemed shallower and wider now, since the walls fell inward and filled the bottom of the chasm. The sun beamed down hot on her back as she scanned the settling dust for any figures. By the time she and Gemma had climbed up and out of the valley before the earthquake, there were hardly any buildings or people around, but she still searched for any survivors.

“Gemma!” Catra called out louder, searching for her guide.

A pained grunt finally sounded out weakly in response. Catra’s ears instantly swiveled towards the source, and she started climbing the boulders that blocked the path until she found Gemma, face down on the ground and bleeding. Her body emerged halfway out from a pile of building sand, her hips disappearing as more flowed forward like an hourglass to slowly bury her. Without hesitation, Catra began scooping away the debris with her hands.

“Nnnggh, Catra?” Gemma’s head started to become more clear, and she grunted and groaned in discomfort as she realized her current situation.

“Don’t worry, I’ll get you out of here.” Catra said without stopping or looking at the other magicat. Stones shifted above them, but she continued to dig out the other woman.

“But you don’t--” Gemma tried to protest, but coughed up more dirt and sand as she struggled to push herself up. “Your friend, the scientist.” Gemma shook her head to let the sand fall out of her short fur and ears. “She always shows up right when the earthquakes happen, I told you that.” Gemma sounded annoyed, confused. Why didn’t she get it? “We were right at the apex of it. Aren’t you going to go find her? This could be as close as you get!”

By now, Catra had loosened the sand pile greatly that was trapping Gemma, and was almost at her knees, almost free. She

could already tell that her tail looked broken.

"I'm not just going to leave you here, not like this." Catra insisted. Gemma chuckled weakly.

"Then you're being stupid."

"Well maybe you're being crazy. I know that this isn't how things work out here, but where I come from, people help each other. You're already helping me find Entrapta, why is it so hard to believe that I can help you? Come on, can you stand?" Catra took Gemma's hands in hers and pulled her body forward out of the rubble until she was free. Once she was, Gemma shakily stood up with her hands on her knees breathing heavily.

A weight lifted off of Catra's chest to know that she and her guide were okay, for now at least. Even if she didn't like Gemma, she was happy now that they were both okay. They were out of danger from the earthquake, something that couldn't be said for others that may have been caught in its path, but there were still more dangers ahead.

While Gemma surveyed the new landscape they found themselves in, probably completely different compared to the timeless and ancient stones that she was used to in her home, Catra reached for the radio to call for help.

What she pulled out was no longer a radio. It had been pancaked in her pocket, explaining an especially harsh bruise and dent in her side. Its casing was smashed, the wires poking out the sides, and whatever was left was already full of sand. Catra's anxiety worsened and she desperately shook out the device to inspect it. Perhaps it was just the casing, maybe none of the wires had actually been cut?

"Wild Cat to Stinger, do you copy. Wild Cat to Stinger." The machine hissed slightly with weak static, but it faded quickly. Catra quickly maneuvered the dial in an attempt to get any signal. "Wild Cat, over. Wild Cat to Bright Moon, do you copy? Wild Cat to Bright Moon?" But the sizzle of static died out completely, and the radio became unresponsive and useless. Catra threw the device at the ground in frustration, her hands both clawing through her scalp at her stress. She had no idea if Scorpia was okay. She couldn't reach out to Bright Moon for help. She still had no idea where Entrapta was. They had no ride out of the desert. And now they had to climb out of this devastated canyon. Things could not have been worse.

****

"Okay Swift Wind, the key to getting the attention of a girl is simple." Glimmer instructed. They had moved from the barnyard to the open fields just beyond Bright Moon castle. Swift Wind stood erect at his commander's orders, though confused at how well it would translate from a princess to a magical horse.

“You need to romance her! Girls love people who are sensitive, and attentive to detail.” Adora blushed and snorted, reminded of the early days of when Glimmer and Adora got together.

“When I first got with Adora,” Glimmer went on to explain, “I took her out to see the fireflies. It was super personal and beautiful.” She looked over to her side at Adora with a sparkle in her eye. Adora rubbed her neck bashfully.

“Yeah, that was pretty effective.” She confessed, suddenly too flustered to make eye contact with either of them.

“So bugs are romantic.” Swift Wind concluded.

“What? No.” Glimmer quickly sobered up and refocused. “I think you’re missing the point.”

“Yeah see, they were bugs that lit up at night.” Adora explained. “Glimmer wanted to show me in order to sort of show me the stars.”

“So it was romantic because they lit up?” Swift Wind clarified.

“Well, dimly lit areas do create a sense of intimacy that can be romantic.” Glimmer thought with a hand to her chin. “But that

wasn't really the *only* factor that made it a romantic gesture. It has to be thoughtful, something that you know she would appreciate."

"So, do you know what she would like?" Adora asked.

"Hmmmmm...." Swift wind brought a wing to his chin as though it were a hand so he could look more thoughtful. "HMMMM...." He raked his brain for details. "OH! She likes to eat flowers more than grass!"

"That's great! Flowers can be really romantic!" Glimmer encouraged. Then she realized something. "Wait, is *that* what happened to all the rose bushes outside the castle?!" Lately Angella had been trying to casually interrogate anyone that she thought might be picking all her prize roses that lined the Western walls of her castle. They were much adored by the Queen, and she was greatly confused at how they had all been disappearing so fast without a trace. It was the source of a bit of gossip amongst the castle staff.

"Come on Glimmer, it's in the name of romance!" Adora defended. She too had only just learned this, but wanted a chance to tease Glimmer about her romantic ideas anyway.

"Okay, I have an idea!" Swift Wind triumphantly interrupted, his head held high.

They had to gather more supplies than they thought for this romantic gesture to work, but by noon Swift Wind was ready to make his intentions with Duchess clear. It was easier to work once the girls stopped teasing Swifty about his crush, and the work and advice came in earnest.

He looked over everything set in place, nudging a few last minute things around. Glimmer helped set everything up, giving him the same confidence that Bow had given her before she got the nerve to ask Adora out. Adora was to return any second now leading Duchess to some hay for lunch; as soon as they came around the corner Swifty would surprise her with all the romance his dramatic heart could muster.

“Do you think she’ll like it?” Swift wind nervously muttered, still fixing things up.

“Of course she will.” Glimmer reassured. “You put a lot of effort into this, she’s bound to notice that. Girls love when people pay attention to stuff like this. It’s sensitive.”

“But what if she doesn’t?”

“What are you talking about?”

“I’m just worried-- she might think it’s going too far, and what if she wants to move out?”

“Move out? Like, from the barn?” Glimmer leaned her elbows on the table to look at Swift Wind over the other side with a quizzical look. “I don’t think she will. I mean, where else would she go?”

Swift wind observed their handy work together for one final inspection. Everything was beautiful. He tried to remember Glimmer’s words of confidence and waited patiently for Adora to return with the mare of his affections, hoping he was doing the right thing.

His ears flickered toward the barn. He could hear hoof steps coming from around the other side of it.

“They’re coming!” He quickly whispered, getting into position. “You know the signal?”

“On it!” Glimmer rushed to her assignment, waiting for the signal from Swift Wind to commence.

A moment later, Adora appeared, leading Duchess along with just a handful of hay as she walked alongside her. She didn’t enjoy wearing any kind of lead or harness, and Adora doubted she would be able to motivate such a massive beast to move unless she had the proper incentive of food anyway.

"Oh look. What is that!" Adora said, acting surprised but sounding completely rehearsed and flat. Her acting skills had not improved at all.

Duchess paused and cocked her head at the display. Swift Wind was there waiting for them, with a table full of buckets of colorful flowers from all over Bright Moon. It smelled so delightfully aromatic on the breeze. Duchess stepped closer hesitantly, sniffing the display of tasty treats.

"Duchess, I gathered these all up for you." Swift Wind said as he rehearsed. "Help yourself!"

With the last words, Glimmer's command was given, and she used her magic to ignite a small fuse. Sparks flew up the line and flared up until they burst in an array of colorful sparks, dancing harmlessly over the flowers. The soft glow of sparklers illuminated the meal in a dazzling dance of colors, the sparklers cleverly obscured with the flower stems.

Low light: check.

Flowers: check.

Hard work: double check.

Something she would appreciate: *not* check.

As soon as the sparklers ignited over the flowers, Duchess's eyes flew wide open and she let out a shrill, startled neigh. She backed

up and bucked up on her hind legs, kicking and screaming in fear of the sudden shocking surprise, despite it being harmless.

"Woah, easy girl!" Adora tried to calm her, but this time it was no use. Duchess bucked her head in fear of the bright moving lights, neighing in panic until she eventually found an opening back the way they came, and ran off back to the pasture, leaving Swift Wind crestfallen.

The three stood there for a moment while the sparklers grew dimmer near the end of their fuse, unsure how to respond. Swift wind eventually sucked in a breath through his teeth nervously.

"I guess she is still skittish of a lot, huh?" He concluded.

"Yeah, I totally forgot about that." Glimmer agreed. "I guess using pyrotechnics wasn't the best idea for a horse afraid of her own shadow, huh."

****

Scorpia had been halfway through the tunnels when the first light tremors started. She quickened her pace and the rumbles started again, not stopping and growing in caliber until she could hardly

stand anymore. She was terrified that the tunnel was coming down around her and reached for the walky that Bow had given them, but the earthquake grew enough that chunks of the tunnel folded and crumbled down, shaking the ground even more. Desperate, she ran forward towards the exit, ducking and dodging as earth fell around her and blocked her path, until one eventually hit her and took her out, knocking her out for an unknown amount of time.

She would eventually awake later in an unfamiliar place. It was still the underground tunnels, that much was certain by the darkness and the smell of damp earth that could only be found far beneath the surface of the desert. Her vision swam with even darker spots as her head cleared from the heavy blow, and her ears rang loudly.

She pushed herself up and was relieved to find that the caves were still mostly intact, just shaken up. In fact, she wondered if there was an offshoot from the main tunnel line the last time that she had come through here. But she could distinctly remember that the whole time, the secret passageway was only ever one long straight line, with no other paths branching off.

And yet, here she was, at the cross section of at least three different passages.

One looked like it was the original one she had taken, the one she needed to take to continue. It was older than the rest, built by hand, and much taller than the other two. The other two tunnels looked like they were more fresh, not quite as hard-packed down earth over centuries of use, but perhaps only decades instead.

They were shorter, but she was still able to stand in front of it without hunching over.

"Huh. That's weird." Scopria mused as she ran a claw over the walls.

It seemed as though the earthquake had done more than damage just the tunnel she was in, but other cavern systems as well, breaking down the walls between multiple secret passageways until it made a network.

She knew that she had to continue back down the way she was originally going. It was the most assured way to get back to the Scorp Jet, and Catra was counting on her to get them a way out of the desert. But still, the curiosity of a secret passageway within a secret passageway was hard to resist.

"Right, focus Scorpia!" She told herself, shaking her head. "Gotta focus on the mission! Catra is counting on you! Unless this would take me there even faster... no, No! Bad princess! Focus!" She turned around, facing away from the mysterious network she had discovered, and put her pincers on either side of her head as though she could squeeze the distraction from her memory. "I need to find a way out of here." She resolved. "Unless this way is actually safer..." She turned around to the tunnel again and looked inside the dark depths. She couldn't see very far, but thought that she saw something glinting down at the end of the tunnel.

"Huh?" Scorpia tilted her head. "Hey, is someone down there? Legally you have to tell me-- otherwise it's Entrapta!" She meant

to say entrapment, but she was also very much hoping it could be a sign of her friend.

There was no answer.

“Well, if there’s nobody there... Then I guess it’s a bit safer, right?” Scorpia reasoned to herself. She took a hesitant few steps inside the tunnel.

It grew slightly darker, she strained to see as she gingerly went forward. She came to a sharp turn, and waited cautiously to listen for any signs of danger. She could swear, there was almost the sound of light footsteps nearby.

She leaned against the wall as she inched around, trying to peer around the corner.

Scorpia leaned out further, hearing nothing. The sounds stopped. Were they gone?

She stepped out more fully, at the exact same time that somebody else did the same movement on the opposite side of her, equally cautious, and they both suddenly faced each other.

“AAAAAH!”

" *AAAAAAH!"* They both yelped in surprise at the same time, jumping back half a step each.

The next thing Scorpia knew, there was a sharp, black object flying towards her, and she instinctively flexed out her own tail's stinger in panic to subdue whoever was trying to suddenly attack her. She felt the stinger make contact at the same moment that she felt a pin prick of pain in her own shoulder, and just like that she was unconscious again.

****

Catra scanned over the waste of boulders around them. She and Gemma were alone, but not for long, she found out. A loud and rushed cackle echoed over the crevices that they were searching, a familiar sounding cackle of a scientist on the move.

"Entrapta?" Catra stood up and tried to locate the sound of her friend, the first sign she had had since the portal that she was okay. The laughter in the distance over the top of the edge of the bowl they were stuck in started to fade, moving onto other areas.

"Entrapta!" Catra called out. If she hurried, she could scramble up the side of the cliff again and find her. The whole reason she was

here. Entrapta, she was *alive* , Gemma was telling the truth, she was here.

But her cries for her friend went unnoticed, echoing in every direction around them and back to her fruitlessly. Entrapta faded from her grasp. Catra's shoulders sagged and her tail dropped. Another lost chance.

"Well aren't you going to go after her?" Gemma said somewhere behind her, confused. She was still recovering from the landslide, her feet were numb from being buried from the waist down. She needed to splint her tail, not to mention checking over her own climbing equipment in order to get out.

"Just like I told you, she always shows up for every tremor, and derives some great joy out of it, laughing away at our misery." Gemma grumbled. "You seriously aren't going to go after her? Isn't that like why you're here?" She asked again in disbelief. "You could go after her right now, accomplish what you came here for."

"What, and leave you here like this?" Catra turned back to her guide, helping her to her feet once again. "Come on soldier, let's get out of here."

Gemma grunted in discomfort as she accepted Catra's help and let her arm around the other magicat's shoulders for support. She still shook her head in disbelief.

“It’s still hard to believe that we didn’t see her closer.” She mused. “With how close we were to the center of it, she’s always right on top of the action with those earthquakes, and that was one of the biggest ones in a while. You really aren’t going to go after her? When you’re this close?”

“I already told you, not with you like this. Let’s get some help. Maybe we can still find your contact for help.”

A certain look of anxiety, maybe guilt, crossed over Gemma’s face, Catra thought it was perhaps the same look that went over Adora’s face when they were in the horde and she knew she was being a burden.

“Listen, I know that you probably don’t want any help getting out of here, but maybe I do, alright?” Catra tried to reason with her logically to convince her that they needed each other. “I still have no idea where anything is around here, even less so now that everything is all landslide-ed. Let’s both get out of here, okay?”

They climbed together out of their predicament. Gemma recovered more of her mobility the more practice she got climbing again, but her balance was still greatly thrown off by her broken tail.

When they got to the lip of the canyon once again, they were finally able to see the full scope of the devastation from the earthquake.

Catra wished she could show a sign of relief that it wasn't as bad as she thought it had been, but that didn't make the destruction any better.

Fortunately, it hadn't devastated the entire canyon as she feared. From the looks of the upturned earth and deep indentations where the ground fell in, it looked almost like the earthquake ran on a course over the terrain. The path of upset earth ran alongside the canyon, parallel for most of the stretch, that is until it verged near the end of the valley, right where they were. It hit the valley on the same side as the cliff they had spent so long climbing, and continued across to the other side before it apparently stopped.

Down in the base of the valley, things were shaken up but still standing. Buildings were leaning over slightly and the roads were much more uneven, but not totally buried like some of the outlying homes that were out as far as Catra and Gemma had gotten.

People were probably hurt, or killed. Somehow, Catra felt responsible. If Entrapta really did have something to do with this, then maybe those thugs that wanted her head were right, she was just a horde force captain who caused misery for others just by coming here.

"You're worried about your friend, aren't you?" Gemma stated, also looking over the Valley of the Lost, though her look was one that held more familiarity and less cold calculations than Catra's.

“Of course I am.” Catra sighed. “But I have no way of contacting her, I don’t even know where she is. I would have to search the entire desert on foot.” Catra’s heart broke just thinking about having to choose between searching for her two closest friends, but the choice had already been made for her. “We have to keep going after Entrapta. Maybe she can fix my radio so I can contact Scorpia, or have some other way of tracking her down.”

“It’s not much farther now.” Gemma informed her, turning her back on the valley and Catra, continuing up the rim of the cliff as they had once before when the earthquake hit. Catra reluctantly followed her, hopefully towards help and not, as Catra feared, turning away from a friend.

******

Scorpia could remember when her venom developed around puberty. She did a lot of experimenting on her own, since there was literally nobody else around in the Horde to tell her how those things worked. There was nobody like her at all.

Trial and error led her to discover her full capabilities. She could still remember the feeling of the first time she stung herself to see if she was immune to her own venom (she was not) as though she were feeling it right now. The memory of her numb claws and

feet, the warm feeling on her back like she was in a pool of water. From there, she learned more about how to use her powers.

Her venom only caused paralysis and sleep, but didn't kill or wound.

She had six shots a day before she ran out of juice in her tail. If she used them all up, her body could only make about two or three more shots per day after that until it refilled, but never passed five total.

And, no matter what she tried, she was not immune to the effects of her own venom, unfortunately.

The memory of using her stinger as a pubescent young teen swept through her body the same way it filled her mind. She could still recall the ache from the pinprick of her stinger, such a small mark it didn't bleed, throbbing in her back as she came back to consciousness.

But for some reason, in this memory, it was in her shoulder. Huh, weird.

Her head was swimming and when she tried to inhale, she realized that this was no flashback. She got hit by some sort of dart.

“She’s waking up!”

“Yeah, we can all see that, *Daryll!* ” Someone snapped in the darkness of her vision. She struggled to bring her mental awareness up to speed, it sounded like the voices were underwater, or perhaps she was underwater and they were on the shore, calling out to her. She tried to float their way.

“Wait does that mean that-- yeah! Guys, Orkin is waking up too!” Another voice joined in.

Scorpia got the sense that she was lying up against a wall made of stone and dirt, for it was cool and firm but uneven. Soon more of her senses began to return to her as the effects of the venom wore off. Her head pounded as she opened her eyes to dim light. She started to recall where she was, and the earthquake. This tunnel was still blurry in her vision, but she could tell that she was someplace different now. Not only that, but there was a crowd of large people around her, at least three standing over her.

Beside her, another person groaned. She looked over and blinked a few times. Laying up against the wall besides her, was a man.

A scorpion man.

Actually, all the people above her were scorpions as well.

She snapped to full alertness in her shock. Never before had she seen another one of her own species in all of Etheria. She even thought at times that she might be the last of her kind.

The man beside her had a black tail and claws, his armor looked rough like sandpaper, and had more small hairs poking out of it than her own smooth, shiny armor. His black hair was in a high ponytail, and he had a small amount of facial hair to match, his mustache drooping down around his lips to make a square around his mouth.

As for the ones standing over her, there were three adults. One was older, with a push-broom dirty blonde mustache obscuring his mouth while his thin orange pincers, almost translucent in the light of the torches, pinched together nervously in front of him. Beside him was a young woman with long black hair tied up into a messy nest that fell around her like a mane, her carapace was brown and similar in texture to the man that lay next to Scorpia. She ornamented her body with piercings and jewelry, but her doubtful scowl as she looked at Scorpia could rival Mermista with levels of apathy and distrust. The final was a young bald man, looking skeptical but curious with his brown, smooth pincers on his hips, apparently not seeing as much of a threat from Scorpia.

"Orkin, hey, wake up!" One of the people before her, the young woman said with a raspy voice, tapping on the man that sat beside Scorpia.

"Neuuugghh, what happened." He groaned, blinking his eyes open.

“I think you two both stung each other and passed out here.” The husky older man replied nervously. “We found you both lying face down on the ground.”

Orkin looked over to his right, and his eyes widened when he saw Scorpia.

“Did you sting me?! Not cool bro!” He asked, offended. His tail readied behind him again, at the ready to strike. Scorpia’s tail raised in unison, ready to defend her from another sting with a harsh sting of her own. But in her mind, she was still reeling, her head was spinning with delight and wonder and curiosity. Or, that could have been the residual venom in her system.

“Wait hold on, I’m going to ignore, temporarily, the fact that you also stung *me* , because, again, hold on, what the heck?!” She stood up, and the man, Orkin, followed as well. “I mean, look at you! Is this real? No, it has to be real. Wait! Unless I’m dreaming. Oh no, am I dead?! Are you all the departed souls of my lost kingdom? No, wait, still alive. *Man* that sting packed a punch.” She reassured, rubbing the sore spot in the front of her shoulder near her chest where she had been stung.

“We aren’t dead!” Orkin groaned, relaxing slightly as he realized that Scorpia was no threat. “And you aren’t either. I mean, I think. I’ve never seen a ghost before.” He shrugged.

“Oh my god Orkin, she isn’t a ghost. Everyone knows you can’t sting a ghost!” The bald man rolled his eyes.

“Wait, so you never saw another Scorpioni before?” The skinny woman asked, her tone almost offended, but perhaps more disbelieving.

“I don’t think she’s part of the clan, boss--”

“Shut *up* , Daryll!” The woman cut off the older nervous fellow with annoyance.

“Wha, you guys even have your own Kyle too?!” Scorpia squealed in delight, her feet alternating hopping in place in her excitement. “Wait, there’s a clan? Are there *more?* ”

“Well duh!” Orkin said proudly. “We got a whole danged secret society livin’ underground in this tunnel network! And I’m their leader, Orkin. But you can call me Orkin.” The wind left his sails very rapidly as he realized he had trapped himself in the middle of the sentence, leaving the end to fall flat. He looked down at the ground in thought for a moment, then quickly ignored it and moved on.

Scorpia could tell that he didn’t seem to be the brightest person she had ever met, but she knew for a fact from personal experience that that wasn’t what made the grit of a leader. It was all about charisma, just like herself as force captain and then princess of Safety. She knew she wasn’t the brightest either, and yet everyone seemed to have endless patience for her, and that came from an innate sense of trust in character.

Did she trust these characters?

"Listen, we've been takin' in strays from all over that once belonged to the best kingdom ever. Up top!" He quickly high fived-- high…. Pincered?--- the bald man. "Even if the kingdom fell to some stupid robot vampire lookin ass freak, we still got our countrymen to look out for, am I right? Come on, you can join us!" He immediately offered, seeming to encourage the others with him into agreement as they nodded with welcoming smiles, apparently roused by their leader after he had really talked up their people and kingdom.

Scorpia's eyes sparkled as she gasped, pincers up near her face.

All her years of wonder would have leapt in the air in delight. The hours and days she spent learning on her own how to use her powers, the nights spent daydreaming about what her family and country were like, the tears she shed at the abuse at the hands of the horde while she had convinced herself that it was worth it, she realized that the answers *did* exist. Perhaps Catra was okay with suppressing that childlike curiosity about her origins, knowing that curiosity would only lead to a sense of betrayal and heartache. She knew that Catra was familiar with not wanting to know for fear of making a terrible situation much worse, and for a while, Scorpia really had tried to feel the same way. Why wonder about what could have been when it made her current life in the horde look even more miserable?

But for Scorpia, she was different. She was ostracized by her peers from so early on, making friends was hard, and she had

nobody else to turn to. She had a big heart and an open mind and not much else to preoccupy herself with other than to hold on to the child-like sense of fantasy. She had imagined her parents, her kingdom, her culture and heritage. And truly, it had hurt her. But what set Scorpia apart was that when she was hurt, she only found more room in her big heart to grow more love. She wanted to give the world all the kindness she had been robbed of, and the more she was hurting the more she wanted that ideal fantasy where her people could have survived. She believed that maybe, there could be others like her out there in the world.

If her younger self were here, she would have exploded with glee, abandoning all that the horde had promised her in a heartbeat to find who she was.

But she wasn't that little girl any more. And she was no longer with the horde.

"I would love to." She smiled broadly. "I would, honest! But, I'm already on a super important mission." She admitted, remembering her real family. Catra and Entrapta were counting on her. The Scorpions before her all seemed crestfallen, disappointed at her answer. They looked down, but Orkin looked a bit more desperate, wondering what he could possibly say to get her to change her mind.

"Well hey look like, power to you and all. For sure." He said, brushing off his disappointment. "But come on, its so rare that we get to meet a new Scorpion! At least come check out our sweet pad, and maybe we can help you with your mission."

“Really? You would do that for me?”

“Well sure!” His charismatic joy was back in his brightness again. “Come on, let’s get going! Before that crazy purple lady shows up. No, not you Daryll! Someone’s gotta repair that wall before someone finds us out!”

“Okay, how should I--”

“I dunno, figure it out, man!” And the rest of them turned to leave Daryll to figure that out. Scorpia felt bad for him, but also it reminded her of Kyle. If it weren't for the stinger on the end of his tail, she would think they could be related.

The group took off down the tunnel, leading the way for Scorpia to follow, which she did. Her heart felt lighter than it had in ages.

“So, I’m Orkin, the leader of the Secret Scorpions.” Orkin said proudly, hitting his chest with his claw. “Over here we got Daryll, ignore him he’s dumb anyway. That’s Violet, and this doofus is my brother Chuck. What was your name?”

“Scorpia.”

They all laughed at that, stopping their march for a moment as they patted Scorpia on the back at the good joke.

“Very funny.” Chuck, the bald man said. “No but come on seriously, what should we call you?”

“Huh? No, I’m serious, my name is Scorpia.”

“You’re serious? Dead ass?” Violet asked in a raspy voice. Scorpia just shrugged.

“I didn’t pick it.”

“Fair enough, bro.”

*****

“Swifty, I think you’re approaching this all wrong. No offense, Glimmer.” Adora let her steed know, having regrouped for a new strategy to win over the heart of the mare who held his affections.

“Romance is one thing, but you have to remember that your consciousness is an extension of my own.”

“Yeah, you’re like my mom!” Swiftwind smiled.

“I thought we agreed to never say it like that again.” Glimmer protested, raising her hand. “Also that that was *not* the nature of their relationship, it doesn’t work like that.”

“It totally works like that.” Swift wind insisted.

“Jury’s still out.” Adora corrected. “ *Anyway.* The point is, if you are anything like me, then romance and subtle clues are not the way to go. You have to be more obvious, and just be yourself.”

“That’s… actually not bad advice, Adora.” Glimmer smiled at her girlfriend.

“If you be yourself, and show off how superior of an option you are and how athletically superior you would be able to protect her, then surely she will see your value and allow you the validation of proving the worth in your existence.” Adora continued proudly.

“Aaaand there it is.” Glimmer sighed in defeat. “Adora, you know I love you right? Like, for who you are?”

“Love you too Glimmer-- now Swifty the key here is going to be proving athletic prowess, and should be easy for you. For one thing, you got wings, that’s like, two legs up on any competition. You’re way better than an average horse. And second, you are the sacred steed of She-Ra.”

“Okay but Adora, you really do *not* have to prove your worth to anyone, least of all me, or Catra for that matter.” Glimmer tried to get between her girlfriend and her beloved horse. “Like, She-Ra or no She-Ra, you’re Adora and I love you, no matter what, you don’t have to prove anything.”

“Now, we know that she has a lot of fear. She’s an anxious mare, probably related to how she was treated before. So all you have to do is prove to her that you can protect her from stuff like that, so she feels safe.”

“Adora that makes *so much* sense!” The unicorn agreed, eyes wide. “Smart, smart, I like it. But what am I supposed to protect her from?”

“Again Adora, you do not have to prove *anything* to *anyone,* like romantic or otherwise.”

“Well Swiftwind, I’m not sure if you’ve noticed this, but I have a magic sword that makes me big. It shoots lasers.” Adora pointed out, a wicked gleam in her eye. Glimmer’s palm quickly met her forehead, able to foresee how this project would go. The same way they usually went when it was just Adora and Swift Wind.

She only ever had one brain cell, and she used it to give it to a horse, and now that horse was a reckless communist.

Two hours later and a hole in the barn loft wall would prove her right. Swift Wind's hind legs dangling out of the splintering wood would remind him once again of the feeling of regret. And Adora, wearing the transformation of She-ra, looked on blankly for a moment, before detransforming before Duchess saw her and associated She-Ra with some kind of threat. The beating of hooves in the distance was enough warning, the startled mare ready to trample anyone that might threaten her foal.

It took Glimmer and Adora most of the afternoon to maneuver She-Ra's mighty steed out of the rafters without twisting his wings off, but they somehow managed.

"Okay I don't think that physical attributes were the way to go on that one, Adora." Swift Wind grumbled, preening his bent feathers once he was safely in the barn.

"Yeah well to be fair…. Okay I got nothing." Adora sighed.

****

Scorpia had been expecting to find a grand burrow of scorpion people, a yawning cavern filled with people like the valley above. But instead, it was merely a big series of interconnected tunnels, almost like the hallways in the Fright Zone, that connected everything.

She was still in shock seeing other Scorpion people, of which there were few, but she got the sense there were more where she couldn't see them. They wore plain desert clothes, and their carapace came in a variety of textures and colors, ranging from pale yellow to solid black.

"And that over there, leads to the gym." Orkin excitedly pointed out to her. "This tunnel over here actually takes you over to The Howling Winds Ravine! And over here we got a game room, and over there is a ladder that takes you deeper to the residential quarters, and over to the left here there's the food storage."

By now Scorpia was certain that she could never find her way out of the labyrinthian lair of these people, there were constant crossroads and split paths, tunnels wide enough to fit tanks all around her converging and winding through what she had no doubt was the entirety of the Crimson Waste.

"Woooow! This is incredible!" She gawked with her mouth open like a tourist. "I had no idea there were any other people like me

in the world, let alone a whole secret society!" Orkin chuckled proudly.

"Heck yeah. Secret for now, but one day we'll return to our old kingdom and take it back! We're just waiting for the right moment, you know? In the meantime, it's taken decades to find all the misplaced Scorpioni people that were displaced by the war. The more the merrier!" He celebrated with his pincers in the air. "Go Secret Scorpions, *Whoooo* !"

"Hell yeah!" Chuck agreed, and they slammed their chests together like a high five.

"Is there any way that I could convince you to come live with us?" Orkin continued. "A big tough dame like you would totally help out our numbers!"

Scorpia had to sigh sadly.

"I'm sorry guys, you've been super nice ever since the whole accidental-double-sting thing, but I can't, I've got this important mission. I promise I can come back anytime after that though! Oh! Or maybe you guys could come with me back to Safety!"

"Safety? We're plenty safe here." Chuck said, confused.

“Huh? Oh, yeah I see the confusion, yeah they did warn me about that when I tried to name the town that. No, Safety is the name of a really big town over in Bright Moon! I’m like, their leader there, it’s all a bunch of horde defectors from the Immigration.”

“Woah, Horde?!” Orkin suddenly got defensive, a flash of distrust passing over his face. “You aren’t horde, are you? Man, we hate those guys!”

“No--Well, I guess technically I used to be, but then I defected ages ago!” Scorpia was quick to explain. “They took me from my family when I was a baby and raised me to be a soldier. They even took my family’s runestone and gave it to Shadow Weaver. I’ve been working with Catra on the inside for years---”

“Wait!” Orkin stopped her short, rushing up into her space to grab her shirt with his claws and pull her face closer to his, and she suddenly realized that his face was struck with shock and disbelief.

“Are you telling me that your family was the royal princess family?! The ones that fought against Hordak?”

“I guess so? Hordak always told me that my family willingly let him and his army stay-- you know, always being hospitable-- but I never knew any of them. Why, do you know them?”

“Do I know them?!” He sputtered, releasing her shirt in favor of holding his own head as though it were going to explode. “Uuuh more like do I know *you* ! You’re the rightful Princess of our people!”

“Hey everybody, we found the lost princess!” Chuck announced to the other Scorpions, only about four in that hallway at the time, pointing to Scorpia as she blushed furiously at the sudden attention. Suddenly the word was spreading as more people poked their heads out of hallways and doors all around them, repeating the information as it spread.

“The lost Princess?”

“Is it true?”

“Is it really her?”

“She’s alive?”

“Of course, she’s the spitting image of the Queen!”

“How can it be?”

“The lost princess!”

Before she knew what was happening, she was in a bullseye of excited stingers and pincers trying to get up to her, most of them excitedly worshiping her and asking questions. Scorpia panicked, grabbing her tail and hugging it close so she didn't accidentally sting anyone on self-defense instincts.

"Woah hey everybody, back up, give her some space!" Orkin pushed his way in front of her, spreading out his arms until the crowd calmed down a little. "Don't make me sting any of you suckers! Let her breath!"

"Geez, I had no idea you guys were looking for me!" Scorpia said a little loudly with her nervousness. "I mean, not that I could have known, or even found you if I did know, like I had no idea there were other people like me at all."

"Princess Scorpia," Orkin bowed his head respectfully, giving an extra bit of formality in his voice. "We are beyond relieved that we happened to discover the rightful leader of our people at long last! Anything you need, we will aid you in. Seriously, just ask, and you got it." He said with a friendly smile towards the end that made Scorpia feel a little calmer.

"Uh okay. I mean there's no need for all that. But if you are able to help me with this one thing," She said, remembering Catra's assignment. "I kind of need a ride?"

“What, like a hovership?” Orkin asked, a spark in his eye. Scorpia nodded, thinking he meant like a skiff or similar type of vehicle, perhaps a colloquial term for the same technology that powered the skiffs.

“Oh bro, you are gonna love this. I think we have *just* the thing you need!”

She was pulled by the claw down the winding paths again, more lost than ever as her guide could hardly contain his excitement.

“You’re going to love this!” He said over his shoulder. “It’s like, totally made for you and everything!”

Scorpia had never met a single leader in her years that was anything like Orkin. In the short time she had been in charge of Safety and all the recruits from the Immigration, she had met with many a princess as well as public officials of all strokes. And they were as widely varying as the expansive lands of Etheria itself, but none were like this. None were like *her* .

They were dignified and quiet. They were shy and anxious. They were bold and hearty. They could be bookworms, or masters of the arts, or have high degrees in math and science. They knew who they were and the position they held, and the power over the people. They knew that people looked up to them, and that for that they had to be their very best at all times.

Nothing at all like Scorpia.

She was messy and loud and clumsy. Her body was noticeably different in a way that was impossible to conceal, and she had tried a few times after seeing how she would frighten small children at first glance. She wasn't as witty and intelligent as Catra, she didn't have powers like the other princesses, she wasn't especially good at anything. She didn't know a life outside the horde, and could hardly excel at such a life when she was thrown in to it so suddenly.

But she made up for it. She worked hard every day to be the kind of commander that her people deserved, someone that could help her people join the alliance rather than be pushed out. She opened her heart up to love, and took care of people. And she might not know how to act like a princess, but she knew how to act as one of her own citizens, and she was always a person of the people. Her home was indistinguishable from any other on the block.

And then she found these people. Her people? They were clumsy and relaxed and eager to be friends, they wanted to look out for the ones that they loved, they talked like normal people you would meet on the street. It was like they spoke her language. Scorpia would find it difficult to leave these people, knowing that she would never again find someone so much like her.

"Here we are!" Orkin finally stopped in front of a metal bay door, the kind used in the Fright Zone in between freight loading areas, vehicle bays, and other transport needs. The difference, however, was that instead of small buttons on the side panel, there was a

claw-friendly, easy to use lever. He pulled it and the doors opened with a swish.

When they stepped through, they were on a second level balcony overlooking some sort of machine shop floor. More scorpions hurried around in excitement, carrying tools and crates, but mainly observing the latest vehicle: The Scorpion Jet. The same vehicle she thought she would never see again after riding it into the Crimson Waste and leaving it unattended.

Scorpia’s jaw dropped as she gripped the railing in front of her.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” Orkin beamed, oblivious. “We found it at an auction in the whitestone valley. They were gonna bid it for parts! Cost me a fortune to secure this baby.” He clacked his pincer on Scorpia’s shoulder as he walked down the aluminum stairs to the main shop floor.

“Now I know that you were raised in the horde and all, but what you are looking at is actually a piece of Scorpioni history! This jet belonged to the royal family, and can only be operated by someone with pincers! Nobody knows where it's been all these years, but we think it still works. I want you to have it.” He continued, totally blind to Scorpia’s look behind him. “Yep, it's rare that we find such a precious thing as this. And hey, we might have to eat more bugs and less rice for a while, but it's worth it to preserve our noble history as the coolest kingdom on Etheria. Honestly I have been getting some flack from the guys about wasting all our money, but it cost way more just to get it in one piece instead of splitting it up at the auction; then I would have to go track down each bit! Surely, you must be in shock, seeing for the first time such a majestic machine that so resembles such a

handsome species!” He winked, noticing Scorpia’s look of disbelief. “That’s right, its all yours, no questions asked. No need to thank me, I’m just happy to help our princess in her hour of need. Go Scorpions!” He high-fived another mechanic wandering by with a manly grunt.

*****

Catra was relieved to see that the tents of the surface above the valley had been largely undisturbed by the earthquake. Gemma had brought her back up to the rim, where they walked until they found this traveling caravan of plain colored tarps strung up over bones and rocks, wood being hard to find in the desert. There were only about a dozen or so, a bit spread out over the sands as more people of various species wandered around, all looking just as untrusting and dangerous as those in the valley.

Just as they started to approach, Gemma paused and asked Catra to hold her hands behind her back while they were still obstructed from the view of the camp behind a jagged stone that came out of the ground at a sharp angle.

“What? Why?” Catra spat in distrust of being bound. Her patience was wearing thin after the long day she was having, she just wanted to be home in Bright Moon again and leave this awful place behind her.

“My contact is in that camp. But in order to get you there, I need them to think that you’re my prisoner, or else they’ll all draw weapons on you.” Gemma explained, just as tired. Even though she was used to this harsh weather and arduous climbing, even she had had enough of this bad day. “The only way they’ll trust you to walk through is if you’re bound.”

Catra pulled back her teeth in a display of discomfort and frustration. This day would not stop kicking her in the tail.

“Come on, there *has* to be some other way.” She begged.

“We already came all this way, you want to give up now?” Gemma snapped. “I’m putting my tail on the line for you, I didn’t have to go this far out of my way just to help an outsider!” She pointed out again, making Catra roll her eyes.

“Can’t you have your contact come out here to meet us?”

“Listen, are you in or not? Don’t be such a kitten. I thought a horde soldier would be able to take a little handcuffing.” She teased.

“Ugh, fine! Let’s just get this over with.” Catra agreed, letting her wrists be expertly tied behind her by the climbing rope that Gemma carried with her. After all, Catra was trying to work on

trusting people lately, and she needed Gemma to trust her in return. Gemma had done nothing to harm her since she got to the godforsaken desert, and everyone else was more willing to turn her into a piñata after what she did in the horde. She wouldn't find anyone else this helpful. Besides, the sun was going down, and she didn't want to waste any more time going back to square one just to find a guide.

She kept her head low as she was marched in by Gemma, a few looking at her with curiosity but none with violent hostility. Gemma got into the act, and shoved her a bit from behind with a knife that previously strapped to her leg, forcing her into the center of camp.

There, they found a large dome shaped tent with a guard outside of it. Catra tossed her head in order to get the curls of hair out of her face to get a good look at the skinny blue lizard with the spear that blocked their path.

"Tony." Gemma said plainly in a way of greeting. Tony in response just huffed through his nose. "I've got someone that I think she'll want to meet."

Tony squinted at Catra, trying to place her and why she looked familiar. His tongue flicked out in the air once.

"I'm taking her to see that purple bitch." Gemma clarified in a more hushed tone. Catra's blood boiled when once again she referred to Entrapta in such a way.

“She has a name.” She spat, which earned her an immediate knife to the throat as warning.

“Do you want to see her or not?” Gemma threatened. Catra swallowed dryly-- stars she was so thirsty-- and nodded.

At last the guard stood aside, allowing the two magicats entry into the tent.

She pushed past the flap and forced Catra inside with a hard shove, causing her to land on her knees.

She was confused. From their conversation, it sounded like Entrapta would be in here. Or at least, the key to finding her would be. But clearly, there was no sign of the engineer.

Instead, there was an enormous, muscly woman that would have given Adora a heart attack, with long white hair tied in a ponytail. She had purple skin, and wore simple desert clothes similar to Gemma, but more robust. Everything about her was tough as nails and fierce and she eyed Catra like a piece of meat from her seat at a table with maps.

“Gemma.” She said in a low, husky voice, and Catra could see that she had tusks. “Tell me what mongrel you just dropped on my

new rug.” She demanded in a monotone, disinterested voice. Clearly, unimpressed.

“Gemma can’t you let me out of this yet?” Catra asked out of turn as she tugged on the restraints, letting this buff warrior lady know that she was as equally unimpressed with her as she was with her.

“Huntara.” Gemma greeted with respect. “This is Catra, the second in command of the Horde.”

“Previous,” Catra emphasized with annoyance. Huntara’s eyes twinkled in recognition. She leaned forward in her seat and looked at Catra more carefully. “Look, I’m just trying to find my friend. Can you help me or not?”

Huntara snorted grossly in a short laugh. She stood up and circled the kneeling magicat.

“Damn, the horde training must be going soft these days if she let *you* catch her.” She told Gemma, still looking over Catra. “How much you want for her?”

“No it’s not like that, I’m--”

“I won’t do less than six figures.” Gemma cut Catra’s protests off.

Catra whipped her head up to Gemma in shock. She could feel her heart stop for a moment.

She was so stupid….

How could she let this happen? The betrayal and rage boiled in her gut as her mind went haywire at how stupid she had been to trust this stranger, this criminal. She had literally walked right into their trap. She should have known better!

Gemma had betrayed her. That's why she was so upset about Scorpia leaving. That's why she was so sure that Catra would choose to chase Entrapta rather than save her. The only reason she was ever helping her to escape those bounty hunters at all was just so that she could collect her own bounty.

Suddenly Huntara's rough hand was grabbing Catra's jaw and forcing her to look at her, as she smirked villainously.

"You drive a hard bargain. But you got yourself a deal." She told Gemma without breaking eye contact from Catra. She knew that this was the genuine commander of the horde from those split eyes, now wide with fear over what her future held.

With one simple movement, she shoved Catra further to the ground as she counted out the money for her bounty. Catra's senses started to return to her from the sting of betrayal in her blood.

“You set me up!” Catra squirmed against the bindings on her arms. “I trusted you!” She yelled at her captors. Huntara threw her head back and laughed as she handed over the money for Gemma to count herself to double check.

“Oh, kitty.” Huntara said condescendingly. “Has nobody told you the only two rules of the Crimson Waste?”

Catra knew about what Gemma had told her about honor amongst thieves, to ensure that nobody got caught, but she was still cursing herself for not knowing better. She should have seen this coming.

“One, the strong make the rules.” Huntara explained, flexing her arms with muscles bigger than Catra’s head.

“And two,” Gemma took over, pocketing the money. “Don’t. Trust. Anyone.” She smiled pitifully at Catra.

Before Catra could resist any further or try to escape, Huntara’s massive hand came at her from the side, curled into an iron-hard fist, and struck her across the cheek, knocking her out. She felt herself hit the floor once again as her vision faded, her bad day only getting worse.

No ride. No backup. No communication. No hope.

She was on her own.

Chapter End Notes

Orkin has the voice of John DiMaggio. Listen, all the scorpion people are frat bros, okay?
Please comment what you think to water my crops and clear my skin!
Also check out The Beast You Made Me for another update hopefully soon!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

CHAOS

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had seen better days. She had seen bitter ends and desperate measures, she had been alone and starving and cold, she had been chased and tormented all over creation. She had grown up in the Fright Zone, and that was bad enough to give her enough of an edge that she could always say she's had worse days. But then she also had Shadow Weaver raising her with constant torment just to give her an extra leg up. Nowadays, when her life was good in Brightmoon, she rarely ever had a bad day. And if she did, she could brush it off and say that she had had worse.

But today, today was some sort of divine intervention to really challenge her. Cause today was a really bad fuckin day.

Walking in the desert for hours proved to test her patience for all that she believed was good in the world, turning her feet pads rough and her mouth sour. Only to find that the Crimson Waste was not only well occupied, but had a population of entirely criminals and outlaws. And if that wasn't dangerous enough, it seemed as though they each had a vendetta against Catra for her time as the Horde's second in command. She was harshly and

cruelly reminded of why she couldn't trust people, a lesson she was a bit shocked in herself for ever forgetting in the first place. She couldn't even leave this horrible place because her jet was likely stolen and in parts. Her friends were scattered and she was alone without backup. That with the monstrous earthquakes that rattled the bones of the waste, and only getting worse by the minute. Held captive, weak and wounded, fatigued from desert heat, no radio, no ride, no help. Her mission was turning out to be a hot stinking failure on fire on the porch step.

Could this be the worst day ever?

Unfortunately, the day wasn't over yet. And there were more surprises to come.

A bad day had never kept Catra down before. That's what made her Catra, she kept getting up and going even when it just wasn't in her cards.

Catra pushed her claws out to their limit, but they could still hardly graze against the ropes that held her bound to the pole she was restrained against. It was no wider than a flagpole, but she still couldn't manipulate her fingers around the ropes to cut herself out. Her legs were all bound up from the knee down as well, taking a significant factor out of her flexibility.

Around her, people partied and danced around a fire with drinks, celebrating her capture. Why they would light bonfires when they were in the desert with temperatures high enough to boil an egg escaped her. And how bitterly her mouth cracked dryly for want of

their drink. Just hearing it slosh in their cups as they moved made her head spin.

Focus. Get out of here alive, then suffer later. She had to remind herself. She once again craned her wrists to bend further upward along her arm, pulling a muscle in her desperation to cut herself loose. If she could just sneak away without getting noticed, then she could find Entrapta or Scorpia. The super pal trio could find a way out of this.

Her middle claw on her right hand finally found purchase on the coarse threads of the ropes, and she sighed with relief, trying not to give herself away with a pleased smile. With no time to lose, she began working the claw through the rope, feeling the satisfactory snick of each strand as it cut under her single claw. Still, she had a long way to go before it was loose enough to free herself.

Suddenly, Catra yelled out in alarm as she was grabbed from behind and lifted up, her wrists sliding up the flagpole, and losing her place in the knot. She couldn't see them, but the grip on her upper arm was like iron, and she knew that if they were behind her, they surely saw her attempt to escape. *Shit.* She had assumed that they were all in front of her, as she was at the edge of their base looking in at the fires. Evidently, she was surrounded.

"Looks like we have ourselves some sorta wise guy here!" The gruff, hoarse voice accused her publicly, drawing the attention of the others. "Trying to cut your way out, kitty cat?" Their face came right next to hers, dog-like and smelling of putrid rot as he snarled at her, her arm bruising under his grip.

“I say we declaw her!” Someone in the crowd shouted, which was met with a chorus of agreement. Catra’s heart raced with panic, she couldn’t go without her claws, they were her only tool left, and her most reliable weapon no matter what the circumstances were.

“Cut off her fingertips! Toes too!” Someone else yelled over the rowdy crowd, which was quickly turning into a mob as it inched closer to her, weapons on display. Catra’s claws started flexing in and out of her fingertips in anxiety, unable to escape.

“Hold it!” Huntara’s voice boomed over the crowd, and all her cronies obeyed, although they had that murderous look in their eye and were displeased that she had ruined their fun. Huntara marched forward, towering over her gang as they parted before her.

“I can’t get as much money for her if she’s damaged.” She sneered at them, and despite the circumstances, Catra was almost grateful for the intervention. “People will pay to do that themselves!” Huntara continued. “Now come on, let’s hog tie this Horde scum and get her to the auction, I’ve got the best lot they’ll see all day: a chance to do the honors for tonight’s big public execution.” She growled. With the command given from their leader, the gang sprung into action, packing up their camp and moving Catra along with it.

***

Scorpia was quick to hop in the ship, taking a few of the crowd with her as backup. She operated the jet smoothly as always, and Orkin almost cried with joy when he proclaimed that it HAD to be the natural gift of the true princess, it really WAS her! Etc. She swooped over the orange wasteland beneath her with grace, all the scorpions showing the same amount of thrill that they would if they were on a roller coaster. And to be honest, she couldn't blame them. She was just as giddy, and would have been bouncing and yelling more after finding her people if it weren't for the fact that her closest friends were in danger and counting on her. Call her a sap all you want, but Scorpia was loyal, and always did whatever it took to help her friends.

She and her friends scanned the dunes and cliffs of the Waste. The sun was rising after a brief night; this close to the equator, there was always some amount of light and the nights were as quick as they were hot.

"What's that, over there?" Violet pointed, her claw tapping on the window. Scorpia looked down the right side, where a small convoy, probably a gang, walked from the canyon to a monstrous skeleton that rivaled size to Castle Bright Moon. It must have been another one of the cleverly hidden secret locations for a sprawling city, Scorpia realized. The purple bones were dusty and worn. Partially harvested to sell as construction material that she recognized around the waste, but impossible to remove the entire thing. The fossil was dusty, covered in tarps drawn between the bones, and the undoubted destination of the small convoy.

Scorpia expertly adjusted the engines and swooped in, staying out of sight behind a small collection of buttes as she landed. Orkin again marveled that such skill could only come from the rightful heir to the jet, still not yet realizing that it was hers before they bought it up.

But now, Scorpia was going soldier mode, just as she was raised and trained. She instructed two scorpiani to stay with the jet to prevent it from getting stolen. The other six, she took with her. She climbed the butte and held her claws up to her eyes wishing that they were binoculars. She could just barely make out enough details.

"Looks like Huntara's gang." Orkin said beside her.

"You know her?"

"She's the leader of the single biggest gang in the Waste. She's strong, so she makes all the rules. She gets what she wants and uses force to get it."

"So not a friend then."

"No, not a friend." Orkin crossed his arms, pouting. She nodded, and looked back at the traveling group.

"They're carrying something. I can hardly see with them blocking it…. Looks like someone hog tied."

“They take prisoners sometimes. Oh shit, you don’t think its your friend, do you?” Orkin asked with worry.

“Even if it isn’t, I don’t like bullies taking hostages. Let’s roll out, team!”

“GO SCORPIONS!” Orkin yelled, and chest slammed a guy as the others high fived.

****

Swiftwind lay in soft grasses, and sighed forlornly, too heartbroken to even eat the deliciously moist grass beneath him. Adora leaned against his side, watching Duchess and Duke graze.

“I’m sorry again, about the roof. We’ll get it fixed.” Adora promised, beating herself up while her friend was down.

Swiftwind sighed.

“I mean she doesn’t hate you, right? There’s still a chance.”

He sighed again.

"Maybe the situation isn't that bad?"

He sighed again, louder and more emphasis. What wasn't Adora getting about this? Adora looked down.

Glimmer poofed in front of them all of a sudden. "Okay, my mom said that someone is on their way to fix the barn. Also we are grounded."

Adora and Swiftwind both sighed, causing Glimmer to roll her eyes.

"Come on guys. We're doing our best."

"Yeah, and my best ended up scaring her away." Swiftwind pouted.

"Well maybe we've been approaching this all wrong." Glimmer shrugged, trying to find a bright side. "You're trying to be like us. Maybe you should try and be yourself."

“That’s…. Not a terrible idea.” Adora nodded.

“Well how do I do that?” Swiftwind asked. “I don’t remember much of my life before I grew wings and a horn. What even am I?”

“A good boy.” Adora smiled and scratched under his chin. Which did elicit a smile and happy wiggle at the praise, but he shook his head.

“Really though, how does a horse make friends?”

“You’re asking *us* ?” Glimmer asked with a look of annoyed sarcasm. Swifty rolled his eyes and made a *phrhrhrhhr* horse sound of disapproval.

“Honestly, we couldn’t tell you.” Adora shrugged. “We’re just here to help you.”

“You’re right… if I want to do something nice, it has to come from me, not from the princesses that are executing my ideas.” He stood up suddenly, letting Adora fall back with an *oomph!* And his head held high. “I’m not just a horse. I’m a hero! The mighty steed to the valiant She-Ra, savior of Etheria!”

“That’s the spirit!”

“I need to save her to show that I am a hero!”

“Yeah!”

“Wait, what?!”

****

Catra was used to fighting tooth and nail. But here, she had no choice. She would have dragged her feet, clawed, snarled. But her hands and feet were bound to the stupid flagpole, she was gagged. They had taken away that most base and animal instinct from her which was always at her disposal, to use her teeth and claws when she was backed into a corner. It had a way of blowing the dust off of an old dark hole that she thought she had been able to ignore, the one of how Shadow Weaver had made her feel.

Stop that. She’s dead and gone. You know this. Catra tried to shake her head free of the thought as much as she was able with the restraints. But dangling like a hog on a spit, she had little range.

Everything in her body ached. From the walking, the heat, the landslide. Her mind, often claimed by others of Etheria to be the greatest strategist of her time, raced to find ways to get her out of this situation.

The convoy carrying her came to a sudden halt, which jolted her and caused her to swing on the pole, stressing her tired joints. She grumbled around the gag in muffled annoyance, looking around at what could have stopped them. The gang members looked to the sky, over to the East. She craned her neck to see but even with her flexibility it was a challenge. But no matter, for she soon heard the four engines of the Scorp Jet whooshing in. Her heart raced and she struggled against the restraints more.

She prayed that luck would favor her and that it was Scorpia coming to her rescue and not some hoodlum that had stolen or pawned the ship. She heard the engines roar, kicking up a whirlwind of sand that she closed her eyes against, as it landed directly ahead in their path, and the door slid open. Then, the voice of what may as well have been an angel.

“Unhand her!” Scorpia demanded in an authoritative way, her Force Captain training coming to use again. With her intimidating frame and massive claws, she made a convincing threat. Catra of course knew that it was a bluff, that Scorpia could lay them all down but would rather be at home making tea. All Scorpia had to do was keep up the act long enough for Catra to make a break for it.

Huntara forced her way to the front of her posse with a grunt of disapproval.

“The scorpion losers? What do you punks want with our bounty?” She drew her weapon in a fierce twirl, slamming it into the sand, clearly ready to throw down.

“It’s SCORPIONI!” A man beside Scorpia yelled defensively. “And the only thing that we’re losers at, is being super un cool!”

Huntara broke her vicious snarl for only long enough to look thoroughly unimpressed with his verbal repertoire skills, rolling her eyes. Scorpia stepped in front of the man again, squaring her shoulders and raising her claws like a boxer, light on her feet.

“She’s my friend. You can untie her now, or we can do it the hard way.”

“You must be new to the Crimson Waste.” Huntara glared hotter than the sun beating on their backs in blistering rays. “But she ain’t going nowhere with you bugs.”

“Last chance.” Scorpia warned, her voice lowering. “Surrender her.”

“Bite me.”

An eagle cawed overhead, circling in wait to scavenge the bloodbath that followed two intimidating groups. The air between the two parties was filled with static, ready to crack under the

building pressure. Nobody moved a muscle. When they did, all hell would break loose–but who would be the one to break it?

The pressure built for several minutes of glaring, the unspoken language of sizing the other side up and weighing the options passing between the parties. Catra held her breath, waiting for an opportunity, any opening she could use to her advantage. Scorpia kept her eyes darting around all the thugs that surrounded Catra, counting in her head the quickest route through them. And Huntara looked at the assembled Scorpioni people, the length of their stingers and their size in numbers, doing the math of how many would fall on either side before one claimed it was against them and retreated.

Then, something finally broke the tense silence between the glare down. A distant screaming sound, faint as it echoed faraway over the dunes. But it grew closer, to the point where everyone had to look around in confusion: what was that scream, a warning? An ambush?

The answer was revealed to be someone yelling a long " *ruuuuuuuuuuuuuuuun!* " As they came running over the hills themselves. As the figure drew closer, it became more familiar: a short frame, thick lensed goggles, and large violet eyes usually open to observe the world in awe, but now in (almost delighted?) fear as she raced towards the group. One thing that was unfamiliar, her hair was gone, messily chopped off perhaps as some sort of punishment.

Scorpia and Catra's hearts soared at the sight of their friend, at the same time sinking for her woe, and racing in fear at what she could be warning them about. Likewise, the Scorpioni and

Huntara's gang tensed up and drew their weapons, knowing to expect trouble wherever the mad scientist showed up.

Entrapta ran right towards the group, straight into the middle as though oblivious to the cross fire that was moments away.

The princess slid to a halt and bent over holding her knees to catch her breath, panting heavily.

"Um, Entrapta?" Scorpia said hesitantly, unsure where the standoff stood. "What's–"

"WE NEED TO CLEAR THE AREA!" Entrapta yelled in response before Scorpia could finish.

Then, the ground started to shake.

****

"Okay, this is a bad idea." Glimmer said, arms crossed. "Like I won't even entertain the possibility of asking that as a question, this is straight up a bad idea. Statement of fact."

“I mean, we already know she isn’t a fan of She-Ra, what’s the worst that could happen?” Swiftwind rolled his eyes.

“Give me some credit, Glim.” She-Ra smiled from his back. In her transformed appearance, her injuries were gone and healed. They knew it would reappear when she transformed back, but it made things easier for now. “I’ve faced armies, robots, and Hordak himself. I think I can handle one horse.”

“It’s not that I don’t believe in you. Either of you. It’s that I don’t know if you two have thought this out at all. Don’t you think it could make things worse?”

“Psh. Commander Glimmer, asking us to wait and think things through? That doesn’t sound right.” Swift wind chuckled. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“I will remind you both that our shared braincell is out of the office for the forseeable future. So when Catra gets back from her fun in the sun and sees you got more hurt, I want it on the record that I *did* try to warn you.”

Adora looked a bit hurt, but then just responded by leaning down to kiss her girlfriend.

“I love you too.”

While it did bring a slight smile to Glimmer's face, she still shook her head in disapproval as the two went towards the field where Duchess and her foal were lounging.

****

The sand around the assembled parties exploded, erupting around everyone in a spray of hot dust. Nobody could see a thing between their watering eyes and the dust cloud that obscured the ground shattering beneath them, larger chunks of earth flying upwards seemingly out of nowhere to crash in all directions. The gangs were both thrown in all directions, screaming in shock before hitting the ground violently and having to protect themselves from debris as the massive explosion subsided, their ears ringing.

Catra took no time to waste, and started chewing at the ropes on her hands with her sharp teeth, slicing through the bonds before the dust had even settled. Scorpia lunged at Entrapta and tackled her to the ground, protecting the smaller princess with her large frame and tough exoskeleton as the hot debris rained down.

The ground continued to shake and rumble, a huge chasm soon opening up between the two gangs in the earth, growing wider. The dark chasm swallowed all the sand around it like a waterfall, to the sound of grinding stones as it widened, before something massive portruded out the hole.

A massive metal creature, dark and caked in earth and moss from decades of neglect, shot from the chasm, pulling upward on the rocks with shovel like claws as big as a house. It reared its pointed, narrow head this way and that in confusion and anger, groaning in metallic grunts that resembled a behemoth roaring. As its huge claws tore the earth apart to move itself around, the ground continued to shake and tremble violently, making it impossible for anyone to stand.

Catra succeeded in freeing her wrists, and used her tired claws to tear at the ones at her ankles, eager to get out. As far as she could see: she had Scorpia, she had Entrapta, they had the jet to escape, it was high time for them to *leave* this cursed place.

The mole creature crawled from its cave, violently shattering the earth with its huge claws. It was bigger than the scorp get, no doubt a First Ones guardian of some kind. The widened with every movement, and two of Huntara's gang slipped on the flooding sand and were swept away into the chasm, their screams echoing down the deep hole in the earth.

The sands of the desert poured into the hole like a whirlpool, sucking everything else into it. The creature roared and sniffed the air, hunched over in the dirt. And it stood directly between Catra and the Scorp jet.

Her feet started to get pulled closer slowly as the radius widened, and she leapt backwards, grabbing onto an ancient purple rib bone that was firmly in the ground to keep from getting sucked in. She looked around desperately.

Scorpia was on her feet, and pulled Entrapta up to sit on her shoulders. Entrapta, poor thing, kept flailing her arms and legs desperately for balance, so used to using her hair to climb. It was easy to see how unstable she was with movement without her primary appendage of hair. Catra silently thanked Scorpia for protecting Entrapta.

Around the chaos, the dust was settling from the initial explosion and she could see Huntara's gang retreating, running for the hills. The scorpions quickyl locked claws, making a chain to protect anyone from falling in the quicksand, fastened at the other end to the Scorp Jet. She had no idea where these guys came from, but for now, she was glad that they seemed to be allies, and more that they didn't need her saving. But who would save Catra, cut off from the scorp jet by this mole monster and its quicksand chasm?

She desperately gripped the bone in the earth with all her strength to keep from being swept away in the strong tide of sand. She groaned in pain, her tired body being pulled to its limit at this point after everything she had been through in the desert. A figure swept slowly past her, Huntara desperately swimming in handfuls of sand to try and fight against the current as she was pulled downwards, the weight of the sand making it harder for her to move against as she quickly became tired, even with her massive size and experience. Without thinking, Catra reached out a hand.

Huntara looked up, shocked, almost distrustful. She herself had told Catra the second rule of the Crimson Waste. But caught

between the claws and the pit, she grabbed Catra's wrist, holding on tight.

Catra felt like she was being ripped in half, pulling Huntara up to her safe zone and fighting against the sand. The beast put its nose to the ground, and poked the ground with its claws. For the monster, it was a mere prod, but for the smaller creatures, it rattled the earth and sent up another dust cloud. The bone she clung to shuddered with the earth, and tilted dangerously inward as though becoming loose but holding.

Catra yelled with effort, her body burning inside and out with every bit of strength she had left as the force tried to rip her in half by each arm. She slowly pulled Huntara up to her safe bone in the earth until Huntara could grip the protruding figure with her arms, pulling herself higher up on it, to pull her body out of the rushing sand beneath them. Catra climbed higher to its peak, about ten feet up, to make room for her on the bone. Catra and Huntara shared a brief moment's tense eye contact, both of them hiding their fear, and both seeing the fear in the other anyway. If one of them wanted to throw the other off to be taken by the pit sand, they could. Huntara could easily toss Catra like a ragdoll straight to the hole. But they both nodded, in a silent agreement. There was enough chaos around them to put off a grudge for another day.

The mole pawed at the earth, making more earthquakes. Catra looked over and saw the Scorp jet itself tremble, moments away from starting to move towards the pit. The scorpions were all inside, and she was able to just catch Scorpia pushing Entrapta in as well, and look around for Catra, hesitating before climbing up the chute herself to take control of the jet.

Catra stood precariously on the bone, balancing with her cat like instinct that nobody else could pull off. Scorpia quickly saw her.

"Go! Take off!" She ordered, shouting over the sound of grinding rocks between them. "I'm going to stop that thing!" Scorpia nodded, accepting her teammate's orders, and climbed aboard to rev up the engines.

"You're going after that thing?!" Huntara shouted below her. "Are you crazy?!"

"You want to let it keep rampaging, destroying this place and its people?" Catra retorted, keeping her eyes on the beast. It turned back to its hole, and started to sink its head in, crawling back to safety. The large construct moved slowly, and Catra kept her eyes on it, waiting for just the right moment.

When the time was right, she ran the three steps off the bone, leaping into the air to fly through the dust cloud and land on the mole's back, her claws digging into the foreign metal that was not of this world. Definitely First One's tech.

Okay, focus Catra. She thought to herself, blinking against the sand it kicked up from its movements, and climbing up its back to the head. *It's been a while since we fought an elemental. They usually protect something. If not, just go for the head and pull out its power crystal before it takes you underground so you can get the hell out of here!*

The mole clawed at its entry hole, making it wider to go back in comfortably. The ground shook and rattled, but the mole itself took the shock rather well, making Catr relatively safe from falling off so long as she held firm. She didn't have much time. It would soon dive back beneath the earth, and that was one ride she did not want to go on. She leapt upwards along its back, claws on all her hands and feet sinking into the hard metal. She noted that it was more firm than usual elementals, probably to protect it from rocks underground if that's what it was made for. What *was* it made for?

"Catra!" Scorpia called desperately, full of worry from the Jet, now hovering in a holding pattern, close enough for Catra to leap to the arms of the scorpion that the jet was modeled after as soon as she disabled it. She raced to the head of the mole as fast as she could, desperate to tear its wires out like she had the spiders at Adora's death temple as Scorpia carefully maneuvered nearby. She raced against time along the back of the hulking behemoth.

When the hole was satisfactory, the mole slithered into the comfort of the cool earth just as Catra reached the eye. And that's when she realized that it was no mere crystal to shatter, but a window.

The mole crawled back to the hole it had come through, quickly borrowing out new tunnels along the unstable shafts it had already carved out with its terrifying claws. Metal screeched against deep stones, carving out a new path. To everyone's dismay, it moved much faster through the earth than it did on the surface, almost swimming along until it vanished from sight again, the earth shaking in its wake, and took Catra with it.

Chapter End Notes

I'm so sorry that this took over a year to do, PLEASE FORGIVE ME. I moved to a much more demanding job downtown, but hopefully as things settle I will have more time. Its also hard when I am flying by the seat of my pants here with little outline to go off of. But that will change later! Again so sorry.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

I'M ALIVE

By the time the dust had settled and the chasm had filled with enough sand to stop the flow inwards, Scorpia had landed the jet at a safe distance and left Violet in charge of guarding it while she and the others went to go check for anyone that needed help.

She coughed at the dust cloud that assaulted her as soon as she exited the jet, but hesitantly stepped forward, surveying the scene.

"What the hell was that?!" Huntara climbed down from her post, looking around at the ravaged earth. She bent down to hesitantly test the sand, and Scorpia could have sworn she saw the warrior bring a bit to her mouth to taste.

"Excellent question!!" Entrapta bounced up, waving some sort of crude device around. Not her usual tracker pad, but something new, made of very old parts.

"Wha– Entrapta! I told you to stay in the Jet!" Scorpia said with worry for her missing friend.

“You!” Huntara raised her weapon at Entrapta. “You always show up when this happens!” In classic Entrapta form, the princess was choosing to ignore the danger in favor of collecting her data, which confused the desert warrior. “You– what are you doing?”

“Tracking!” Entrapta replied.

Huntara looked around at the ruined desert, a once familiar landscape. She snarled.

“If my gang hadn’t ran like cowards I would show you what you deserve for tearing apart the wastes…. This place used to be a safe zone!”

“A safe zone?” Scorpia asked. “We’ve been attacked by ruffians at nearly every turn!”

“Yeah, but nobody got arrested! A place where criminals were safe from the law, safe from that stupid never ending war!”

“Okay you guys have been out of the loop for a while, but the war is actually over–” Scorpia defended.

“All of you, SHUSH!” Entrapta snapped, still spinning around with her device, some sort of small dish hooked to an old radio, making strange humming sounds. Her demand was effective enough that both the other two stopped and waited for her to finish.

“I’ve been tracking that mole since I GOT here!” She stares at the device. Both women shrank back at the annoyance in her voice.

“Traps, I’m so glad to see you.” Scorpia smiled, nervously relieved. “Catra and I, we came– WAIT– where’s Catra?!” She searched the sand.

“That horde scum? She went down with the ship!” Huntara pointed her thumb at the massive chasm.

“What?! No!” Scorpia ran to the edge of the new cliff face, only to find it filled with debris, boulders, and sand. “Is she….” Her knees shook.

“Like I’ve been saying…” Entrapta repeated, never taking her eyes from the pad’s readings “If you give me a *moment* I would like to find that out!”

****

Catra woke up to darkness. She shook her head and adjusted quickly, her feline instincts kicking in. She had woken up in

darkness many times before. The Fright Zone. The whispering woods. All the dangerous missions she had been on, with the horde and the rebellion alike. At this point, waking up to darkness was par for the course of her life. Fortunately feline eyes could scan the darkness better than the standard Etherian.

She blinked the dust out of her eyes to look around in the darkness, her mismatched feline eyes shining in the darkness.

She was underground, some sort of dark cavern. Despite all the danger, the cool of the deep earth was a welcoming relief to her from the blistering heat of the surface. She tried to get up, and her muscles shook with the effort. Everything in her ached, screaming in her mind to lie down and rest after the day she had been through.

But she couldn’t rest now. Her knees wobbled and she steadied herself on the wall of the cave as she held her aching head, her skull throbbing painfully. She groaned weakly, the sound echoing on the cavern walls around her as she took a shaky step forward.

The cavern was immense, hundreds of feet tall. To her dismay, she was quite high up on a natural shelf in the layered sandstone, which meant some climbing was in order. Usually something she excelled at, it would be a challenge in her current condition. Stalactites hung from the ceiling ranging in size, some making pillars connected to the cavern floor, some were as big as a castle. There were giant tunnels all around her, tall and wide, leading in multiple different directions to who knew where, probably all over the desert at least.

Her ears twitched and turned to pick up the faint sound of trickling water, echoing around the cavern. She looked down, and saw pools of water. Some was flowing from underground streams into waterfalls that pooled at the bottom before swirling onwards. Her eyes widened, her mouth instantly feeling more dry and chapped.

She had never been more thirsty in her life.

Catra quickly looked around for the easiest route down to the floor of the cave. Luckily there were many shelves like the one she was on along all the cave walls, making almost natural jagged stairs protruding at varying levels that were as tall as her in the sedimentary layers of stone. She just had to be careful maneuvering them.

She peered carefully over the ledge to look for a safe landing. And while there was one about 10 feet down, she gasped and her ears pulled back when she saw what lay at the floor.

The mole beast. It seemed to be in some sort of dormant state, the lights along its body only faintly lit as it lay still, curled in on itself to be more compact even in the sprawling cavern. No noise echoed from its metallic chambers. Could it be safe?

Catra climbed down carefully, her bruised body aching in protest with every movement. She vaguely remembered trying to shut the elemental off before it could get away and / or hurt anyone else, but couldn’t find its power crystal. There was a dark tunnel, then

she got fuzzy. She must have hit her head on a rock as it dug a new tunnel and fallen off its back at some point.

All she knew was what she had known earlier which was only stronger now: Everything. *Hurt.*

Her torn paw pads worked quietly on the sandstone and whatever other minerals she tread on as she carefully climbed down. Her lips were so chapped that they might crack and bleed if she dared try and speak. She faintly wondered how things might have gone differently if Adora or Glimmer were here. What she would give right now to be able to teleport to safety. She dreaded to imagine how Adora could find some idiotic way to be self sacrificing in the name of helping, even with the injuries she had from Hordak. She missed her girls. She wanted nothing more than their soft bed, their warm assurances.

But she shook her head to clear the thought. Mission first. Then she could see them.

She slowly lowered down to almost be on the ground. But the Mole was in the way. She couldn't go to either side around it, there were massive holes to other tunnels there. Can't climb empty air. She furrowed her brow and weighed her options.

She was stealthy, and light on her feet. Perhaps she could sneak over the behemoth?

She kicked some sand at the back of the creature, testing. It slid across the smooth metal surface, but still the mole did not stir. She hesitantly held her breath and reached a foot towards the metal back. It was cool, a relief after the grating, burning hot sand. She slowly tested her weight as she carefully put more of herself onto its back until she was crouching on it, on all fours.

Catra couldn't help but run her blistered hand over the surface of the slumbering creature, thinking. She looked over it more carefully now that it wasn't attacking.

Its surface was thick and sturdy, meant to endure the harsh elements that it dug through. Her claw marks from before hadn't fully pierced the material, which she could usually succeed in with the horde bots and on occasion even tanks. Why would the first ones make a giant digging mole though?

"What are you?" She whispered, as though careful not to wake its slumber, as she investigated further.

****

"What was that thing?" Huntara demanded of Entrapta. Scorpia stood protectively between the two.

“That thing was a First Ones machine.” Entrapta answered flatly, adjusting a dial on her device that changed the frequencies she was picking up. “They usually only appear around First Ones temples or strongholds, it's very peculiar to find one this far out in the waste! Are there any old ruins out here?”

“No?” Huntara was now not exactly intrigued, but caught up in the mayhem of whatever was happening in her home, and felt that any threats or refusal would get her nowhere with this strange short princess.

“ *Fascinating…..”* Entrapta said, and it was unclear if it was in response to Huntara or the readings she was picking up.

“Catra has faced elementals, she would know what to do.” Scorpia recalled. “She tried to stop it. Any idea where it took her?”

“That’s what I’m *trying* to figure out!” Entrapta growled and smacked her machine until the readings were satisfactory. “I’ve been attempting to follow its movements ever since I learned of its existence. But it spends most of its time under a thick layer of bedrock that blocks most signals. Not only that, but without my standard equipment I’m LEAGUES behind!”

“But why is it attacking?” Scorpia followed Entrapta’s erratic movements as she struggled to find a signal.

“That’s where it gets interesting!” Entrapta finally looked up, eyes glowing with curiosity and excitement.

****

Catra crept carefully in measured steps along the beast, sliding to the floor along its sloped body the opposite side. She walked along it, her own curiosity getting the better of her as the saying might imply. She traced a claw along a line of glowing crystal like tech, sending slow pulses of light from one end to another of the glowing yet flexible line.

“Definitely First One tech…” She theorized out loud, whispering as she walked closer to the head. “But we’ve never seen one this big before… What’s so valuable that it needs *you* to protect it?”

She remembered a flash of the battle, back when she tackled it on the surface. It’s eye…

Catra ran silently on her burnt feet to the face to check. It wasn’t just a crystal or a light.

“A window… but that means….”

****

"It's a SHIP!" Entrapta squealed in delight. Scorpia's eyes widened.

"An active First One's ship?!"

Huntara, having lost interest in the science of the beast, crossed her arms gruffly and waited to find how any of this meant it was *her* problem.

"Yes and no!" Entrapta bounced on her feet, delighted at Scorpia's interest in her latest field of study. "It is not, as I originally hypothesized, *new* to Etheria. Which can only mean…"

****

“You were just reactivated…” Catra peered inside the thick, dirt coated window at the head of the Mole. “You haven’t been awake in a long time.”

It was hard to make out the details, but she could make out the basic shape of the room to be some sort of cockpit, with several control chairs and panels, none of which could have been active. There were no lights on, no active panels, only thick dust. “No sign of the crew, either.” By now she was more confident in her ability to explore it without waking, as she crouched on its pointed snout to check the interior. The crystal-like seat inside lay empty. “So what’s running you? Why are you acting out?”

She stood up and looked for some sort of access hatch. She wished that Adora were here to read the First One engravings along the sides, running lengthwise along its body. It was definitely meant to be manned, so how did people get in? She searched along the top of its head for some sort of door like the horde tanks.

“You were fine for so long down here. Why wake up now?” She strutted along the creature’s back as it lay dormant, her own pain throbbing in her mind. She had to prioritize making sure that this thing didn’t hurt anyone. Who knows how many of the Crimson Waste had already died from the earthquakes? Her friends were still up there. She had to shut it down.

She searched for cracks, but there were hardly any wide enough to get a claw in. It was sealed *tight* . Catra racked her brain for something that could help her, something she picked up from Adora in their time fighting elementals.

“Eternia.” She spoke, her dry voice echoing on the walls. She shrunk in on herself nervously, hoping it wouldn’t disturb the mole. A moment passed…..

Then there was a hiss and a clank, a doorway opening, right ahead. A cylinder rose up, big enough for several people. It was hollow, the circle of the surface supported by four pillars that connected to the floor of what must have been the interior. Catra’s ears pulled back distrustfully.

“If I die doing this, my girlfriends are gonna kill me…” She grumbled, cautiously stepping closer. She stepped inside, and saw a lever inside one of the pillars. She pulled it, and the cylinder lowered, bringing her inside.

Her sharp senses were more muted when inside the long abandoned halls of the dormant ship. It was dark, darker than the cavern before. She could smell old dusty rot and rust in every direction. Slowly, a light flickered overhead. Then another down the hall, flicking in and out. More and more came on from her starting point, blinking light in the darkness, spreading out from where she stood, some broken or flickering instead of staying on like others.

Definitely dated, she thought to herself. Hopefully, not hostile like certain other temples they had encountered. She walked down the corridor towards where she believed the head should be, or the cockpit.

The smooth, glass like walls were like that of the other First Ones ruins she had been to: faintly glowing, and etched with First Ones writing she could not decipher. The odd geometric patterns continued throughout the ship. She was careful not to touch anything, unsure what sensors lay hidden in the crumbling crystalline walls.

Several doors lined the hallway. Most were just fragments, pulled away to rubble by time. It must have been a thousand years that it lay here in the ground, since the last known First Ones were on Etheria. Only instead of being overgrown with vines and weeds, this one was buried in the earth.

“What are you protecting if not one of the ruins?”

****

“So it's been here under the waste all this time?” Huntara scoffed, crossing her arms. “No way. Scavengers would have dug it up *ages* ago and scrapped it.”

Entrapta rolled her eyes “The technology of the First Ones far surpasses our own modern tools, despite being from over a thousand years ago. This thing can dig deeper than any Etherian has ever set foot, and has the durability to withstand elemental factors we are still exploring like extreme pressure or even magma.”

Scorpia nodded, getting most of what Entrapta said.

"We've seen elementals before, but never this big, and they're usually protecting something. What is this one protecting? And why is it *huge* ? And why not come up out of the earth until now?"

"EXCELLENT questions!" Entrapta's eyes sparkled, proud that they were now thinking like scientists. "I hypothesize that its return to the surface, erratic destruction, AND its original function are all tied together with why the First Ones made it!"

****

Catra came up to the cockpit and looked around. There were five chairs. One in the center of everything, probably a captain. Four others in symmetrical support locations of each other, each with their own series of panels and controls, probably some for sort of technicians. But all were vacant now.

She curled her nose at the smell of old rot in the room, all the dust and cobwebs here were as thick as sand. She went to the captain's chair and swept some away with her hand, hoping for some sort of clues. Alas, it only had more First Ones writing she

was unable to translate. She sighed and sat down, resting her aching feet for a moment. If only she could see what they saw, whoever they were….

She leaned back and rested her hands on the arm rests. Her ears flicked forward alert when a small light flicked on under her palm.

"Shit," She tensed for whatever was about to happen, hoping the mole wouldn't wake up again and cause more destruction while she was inside it for another rough ride. The light began blinking, and a low hum started.

"Hello." An image appeared of a woman before Catra. She jumped and her fur stood on edge. "What is your query?"

Catra could tell that the image was a hologram, one that couldn't hurt her. But she knew that this lady with such a vacant looking expression was also hooked up to the computers, and didn't want to risk incurring her wrath like she had that time she had followed Adora before the Battle of Brightmoon. The image flickered weakly, barely enough power to keep on. She cleared her dry throat of dust and sand and spoke carefully.

"Log."

The woman hesitated, as though thinking. Pulling up old files.

“Query: log: accepted. Start new, or access saved?”

Catra’s eyebrows went up happily, this could actually work.

“Access saved.”

“Query: log: access: granted. Select entry.”

Beside the robotic woman, a list appeared. She imagined they must have had dates or perhaps signatures of the one logging the ship info, but again she couldn’t read it. She leaned forward and scrolled through them up to the topmost one, hopefully the oldest, with recent at the bottom, and selected it.

When her pad pressed the image of it, the woman vanished and the room went dark again. Catra’s heart sank, until a new light came on, one of a blurry figure standing next to her, leaning on the chair.

“Ca**ain’s lo*.” a voice ruined by static and time garbled out, in a foreign accent. “Da**e, 1* 81 42 *3.” Catra leaned forward, struggling to hear the words of what she thought was a masculine voice. The sound quality was in better shape than the image, which was just a twitching blur of moving pixels hung suspended in midair. “Our ma***n v*y*ge. L** us h*pe we ne*er n*ed to **sort to it lon* term.”

The blur moved forward over the cockpit and Catra sat still, listening carefully. It seemed to turn its shape although looking out the window thoughtfully, and Catra remained silent, almost as though she didn't want this captain to spot her.

She listened to all the brief list of patchy recordings.

****

"Okay, so just to summarize." Scorpia paced in front of Entrapta. Huntara searched the debris for anything salvageable. "This giant mole has been on Etheria for hundreds or thousands of years, and was only recently activated. It causes earthquakes. You're trying to track it, which makes people assume you cause it. And now it's down there, *with* Catra?"

"Give or take a few details and hypotheses, yes!" Entrapta beamed a wide grin like it was christmas.

"Do you still want to hurt her?" Scorpia called over to Huntara. She grumbled and crossed her arms.

"I'm still not convinced! Call me when you've actually STOPPED the thing!"

“Do you wanna maybe help with that?” Scorpia shrugged. “Sort of an all-hands-on-deck situation here! Catra is down there!”

“And?”

Scorpia grabbed Huntara by the collar and gave her a good shake. Huntara was not used to anyone her size or bigger that could successfully pull that off, even out in the wastes, and her eyeballs rattled around with the throttle of the other woman’s pincers.

“She’s important okay! We’re best friends and if I don’t get her back to Brightmoon in one piece her girlfriends are going to murder me and dance on my grave!” Scorpia yelled. But of course, it wasn’t like her to use her force over others when she could avoid it, so she released Huntara and took a deep breath, trying to calm herself. Huntara shook her head, a bit dizzy.

“Also the more people that we add to our pool of available resources and information will statistically increase the likelihood of success, which would be beneficial to the entire Crimson Waste ecosystem and society.” Entrapta added in a slightly bored tone, still watching her pad readings.

“Fine! Holy SHIT you two are annoying!” Huntara rolled her eyes. “I don’t understand what the hell you’re on but if it gets you out of MY wasteland, then fine!”

****

The files seemed to be more corrupted as time went on. Catra cursed under her breath that for all the almost mythical levels of technological advancements that the First Ones had made, that they hadn't found a secure way to preserve their wealth of information or data on their crystals without it wearing down from sand.

She had learned that the captain was a First One, a man who was alive back when the First Ones had originally settled the planet. Though she only had broken phrases and words, he spoke of the rich natural beauty and ample magic in the area waiting to be explored, and his tone was hopeful.

She knew that this vessel was made *after* coming to Etheria. It wasn't one for traveling in space. It was some sort of precaution.

But against what?

She went back down the halls, exploring the crumbling ruins with apprehension. Was it some sort of weapon? Were they concerned about war? If so, she could find key features with the trained eye

of a soldier that would alert her to what threats they were facing here on Etheria. She had to find out if it was still a threat today.

Part of her wanted to pack it in, try and find help, get the hell out of this hole. She knew that's what Glimmer and Adora would want her to prioritize, if they knew her safety was at risk. And she knew she would get an ear full about it later. Especially so soon after Adora was injured by Hordak's torture. But she wouldn't walk away from something that was a threat to their home, and all the hard work they had poured into making their lives over the years. This was for their protection, even if it put herself at risk.

She went down the first corridor that split off from the main hallway along the spine of the mole. There was a door with a pad next to it, but Catra found that simply pulling on the door made it slide easily into the wall, the locks no longer active. Inside, it was darker, but her glowing mismatched eyes helped lead her in without incident.

A bed, a mini kitchen, a private restroom…. The appliances and tools were all strange and foreign to the design of Etherian counterparts, but she could still recognize the function. It was almost like a small apartment. The items had been tossed around in a mess by the mole's movements, but it still held its original purpose. Catra decided this vessel must have a permanent crew, who would live here on deck. She moved on.

She passed by the same column that had lowered her into the structure from the back on her way down the hall as she moved on, assuming that most of the rooms closest to this area would also be crew's quarters. She went down a level and continued exploring. She ignored the ache in her joints and the weariness in

her muscles, the dry dusty feeling in her mouth. This mission had taken over her mind, made her broken bones a mere dull ache in the back of her mind compared to the loud thoughts at the front which told her to find the threat. Investigate further. Find the truth.

She learned that the hull was thicker than she realized when she found a round port window. The distance from one end of the glass to the exterior must have been at least two feet. No wonder her claws couldn't pierce it like the metal shells of Horde robots and tanks. This thing was clearly made for durability. A peek out the window showed the small pool of natural spring water she had seen earlier, at the side of the slumbering mole beast. Good, it was still inactive for now.

She moved to another room. She paused, quizzical as she looked around. Another small living unit? Surely something of this size didn't need more than perhaps a dozen at most to man it. She crouched down, looking closer. She picked up a small piece of fabric, with stuffing inside and decorations on the outside. Perhaps a doll? Yes, long ago this looked like a doll of a person. Why would children's toys be on such a defended weapon?

****

"Here's what we know!" Entrapta said at the head of the table. Around her, Scorpia and the scorpiani people, as well as Huntara

looking gruff with her arms crossed. Entrapta pulled a retractable wire from her pad and plugged it into the table, which then displayed a topographic map of the waste.

"Holy shit dude, this thing has tech?" Orkin gasped. He pushed aside the mechanic's tools and leftover breakfast that were on the table previously. Huntara rolled her eyes. Entrapta cleared her throat for attention again.

"Marked here, are the various locations where earthquakes have been logged as well as their rough richter estimate in strength." Several icons appeared on the map. "Pinpointing the exact origin point of the quakes has been a challenge, however using an intra-terranian reverberator, I can measure the seismic strength of tremors until we hone in on a rough locality *and* understand how they spread."

"In English, please?" Huntara glared.

Entrapta rolled her eyes and held up a long bent wire

"I stick a wire in the ground to see where it started when an earthquake starts." She explained less enthusiastically.

Huntara growled, not enjoying being talked down to. Then again, there wasn't much she could do about it surrounded by all the gear head frat boys with pincers. Other than pout about it, of course. And pout she did.

“As far as I can tell,” Entrapta continued, adding the most recent quake to her model scale, “The movement is erratic, BUT does trend in a certain north-north-east fan!” She connected the dots, making a line that zigzagged across the waste and echoed out like a wave.

“These dates are really weird.” Scorpia noted, squinting at the small print on the data display. “It goes two days without one, then a week and half, then just five days, then almost three weeks. So random.”

“That’s what I thought!” Entrapta leaned on the table in more excitement. “But look closer!” She tapped on the board, and it started making little shockwaves from the original point, the first quake. The lines of the path of destruction fanning out matched up with it perfectly, almost like a shockwave. Scorpia gasped and the others leaned in to watch.

“It’s moving towards something it cannot find.” Entrapta said, her eyes still searching for *what* it could be.

****

Catra left the fifth room she checked, shaking her head "No no no…." She didn't want to think it was possible. Not because of the risk it posed to Etheria, which if true would be null, but because of the grim ghost story that it told her while on her archaeological search.

Every floor of the beast was just living quarters. There were no weapons. There was a hefty storage in its belly, and a medical bay, and a cafeteria. All alien to her Etherian eye, but its function was still clear when she imagined the futuristic people that had made this place.

Those people…. Long gone. But they had built it with *hope* . That tone of the captain in his logs. The living spaces for not just a person, but *families.* With children.

She cracked open another storage crate, one after another, and found nothing but food and basic living tools. She shook her head.

"This isn't a tank…." She looked around at the dark walls. "It's a bunker…."

*****

"But what is it moving towards?" Scorpia asked, leaning in on the table to follow the shock waves. Entrapta actually grimaced at

that, which could only mean bad news.

"It was impossible to make out the general indication of its trajectory until I understood the waves it apparently followed. I traced out potential courses leading all over Etheria, but only one of them led anywhere that made sense." She zoomed out the map further to show the wider continent. The neighboring kingdoms, each labeled, and a red line with corresponding shock wave patterns following it, straight up to the Fright Zone. Specifically, Hordak's lair. Scorpia gasped. Not only was it drawn to something out there, where she was almost too timid to tread again, but the growing seismic waves that it created on its path there while blindly searching for the signal would decimate half of Etheria and bring multiple kingdoms to ruin. Worried murmurs broke out amongst the Scorpiani and company as they all realized the path of destruction was only just beginning.

"We have to stop it." Scorpia stated, determination turning her usually upbeat countenance more dour. Entrapta nodded in agreement with her eyes glued to the readings, an unusually apprehensive look on her face. It was rare that her findings would ever disappoint her, everything was an opportunity to learn. But with the growing strength of the earthquakes, the devastation that it had wrought would soon kill thousands, level cities, and even the eccentric scientist had to take pause and realize that this was the worst case scenario that she *had* to work to avoid. Even Huntara realized that if this continued, there would hardly be any Crimson Waste left, and looked at the numbers soberly.

"How long until it breaches outside of the Crimson Waste?" Scorpia asked, looking back to the confirmed readings of past earthquakes in the corner.

“It’s difficult to theorize.” Entrapta looked back to her pad for more specific recordings to pull up. “It’s been trapped so long that it's low on energy. It moves slowly. However lately, it has been increasing its pace and strength. I’ve hypothesized that it comes to the surface for more energy–I’m not sure what source it is, if its the day moon or the magic, or something else entirely– but that’s why it appears so close to the surface at all and causes these landslides.”

“Like the one that demolished half of the Valley of the Lost…” Huntara growled, growing more tense as she glared at the hologram of her home cliffs and dunes.

****

Catra stalked swiftly back up the rusted hallways, haunted by her new perspective. This place was full of ghosts to her now. People who had hoped to outlive a disaster and raise their families. Children who didn’t see the sky again….

But she pushed the twist in her stomach down, as she was well trained to do as a hardened soldier, and kept going. Because if this was a bunker, then they must have been hiding from *something.* Some sort of cataclysm that they would know to prepare for in order to make this. Why?

She came back to the cockpit in the head, only slightly winded from the jog up from the bottom.

“Log” She demanded, her voice echoing on the metal around her. Nothing happened. She grumbled and looked around. She sat in the chair at the center again.

“What is y–”

“Log” She cut off.

“Query: log: accepted. Start new, or access saved?”

“Access saved.”

“Query: log: access: granted. Select entry.”

This time she ran her finger over the selection to quickly scroll to the opposite end from the bottom where she had started. She pressed the most recent file, one that was still ancient, and strained to listen to the grainy static of the captain’s voice. Instantly, she could tell it was a different captain. Perhaps this vessel was manned for generations, for all she knew. One retires or dies, and a new young officer takes up the helm. She leaned forward to hear what this new captain might say.

****

"One thing I don't understand…." Scorpia said more softly, now in the privacy of the cockpit of her own ship to fly the team to the next anticipated destination. Beside her in the passenger seat, Entrapta was modifying any info she could get from the control panels into her new pad.

"Hordak, he…." Scorpia sighed. Catra had filled her in on all the details that led to her dangerous mission into the Fright Zone to rescue Adora. "You were trying to stop him from building the portal."

"That is accurate, yes." Entrapta said, half listening. "When I was discovered, I was instantly banished to here."

Scorpia nodded, looking out the tinted windows as she swooped over the yellow sandy wastes.

"But…. he succeeded."

That caused Entrapta's ever moving hands to pause, and she looked up.

"What?"

"He built a portal. Well, something similar to it. It was…. A weird effect like all these different things happening. Things that could have been. Fake memories. Trapped, while the world fell apart. You didn't notice? I thought it had happened to everyone."

Entrapta slumped down in her seat in disappointment. Scorpia could imagine that if she still had her long hair, it would be wrapped around her protectively at the moment. The young scientist seemed deep in thought, as though for once she were choosing her words more carefully.

"It did. I thought it must have been a dream. An after effect of the anesthesia that was used to knock me out before dumping me here, surely. If it truly was the portal, then…" She looked down sadly. Then in a snap, her eyes lit up and she jolted upright with a gasp "THAT'S IT!"

****

Catra rubbed over her face tiredly. The room had gone silent and dark once again after the recording. It was just as grainy and patchy in audio and visual as the originals from the maiden voyage. But one phrase was repeated.

"Portal"

Catra's head throbbed with heat from her exhaustion. She held her temples and sighed, trying to calm her racing heartbeat to keep it from getting worse. After everything that had just happened with Adora and Glimmer in the portal, she thought they were done with that cursed world, if it could even be called that.

She knew of course that the First Ones had this portal technology. It was the same thing that Entrapta had warned her about. The same thing that had allegedly brought Adora to this world all those years ago.

And now, it kept being repeated by the logs. In bits and pieces of static, of course. It took several times of hearing "-tal" and "Po-" and some "-orta-" to put together that it was all the same thing.

She rubbed over her closed eyes once again, praying that the light pressure would relieve her long enough to satiate two days of no sleep in the desert. Her new least favorite place in the universe.

The logs were exhausted, having listened to small tidbits from what could only span years.

“Computer?” She said to the empty room. No response. “Query?” Again, no dice. “Eternia?”

“What is your query?”

She sighed heavily.

“Report ship damage.”

“Query: ship status: accepted. The ship is at 30 percent power.”

“What is the power source?”

“Query: ship maintenance: accepted. The ship runs on original Eternian crystals after a refinement process. Log note from mechanical bay: Etherian magic possible substitute with research. End note.”

Catra leaned forward in interest. If the First Ones had used this ship as a bunker, then it would need power. If they ended up camping out on Etheria longer than they had originally anticipated, of course they would need to find more power in order to sustain themselves.

"Search: magic experimentation." Catra stated.

The hologram paused, as though thinking.

"Query not recognized. What is your Query?"

She sighed and leaned back again. *Think, Catra…. That's the thing you're good at. What happened here….*

At that moment, a sensor blipped to life, displaying a colorful reading of something Catra could not comprehend for its First Ones writing or its fancy mathematical meaning. She wished Entrapta were here as her ears pointed towards it, on alert.

"Spatial vulnerability detected. Moving life support system towards potential gateway launchpoint." The computer explained, and Catra had little time to react before the mole awakened. Metal groaned and machines hummed to life not only in the cockpit in which she sat, but she could hear it all through the entire ship.

She leapt to her feet, fur standing on end. She held on for dear life at the frontal console, looking out the main window of the eye though it was obscured with dust and rust, as the giant metal beast lifted up on its paws, shaking the room, and barrelled nose first into the wall of sandstone in the giant cavern.

“Shit!” She cursed as the view went dark, the thunderous sound of collapsing rocks and sand surrounding her while safe within the dense metal frame.

“Query not recognized” The computer added unhelpfully after her expletive. Catra glared at the vacant expression of the glitchy hologram

“Where are we going?!” She had to scream over the sound of rubble and drilling as the claws of the mole tore through layers of foundational stone, the act violently stinging her parched throat.

“Destination: echolocation of spatial laceration. Bearing: North East.”

North East? But all that was there was…..

“The Fright Zone?!” Catra’s already pounding heart threatened to hammer it’s way out of her chest in panic.

“Query not recognized.”

She scowled and looked to the cobweb covered console ahead of her. One of these controls had to do something, right?? She swiped her hands over the screens, and started pressing shapes and lines randomly.

“System: offline. Only life support remains.” The computer chided, as though trying to advise her against it.

“Cancel excavation!”

“Query: canceled. Life support systems online.”

“Fuck!”

“Query not recognized.”

“UUUGGGGGHHHHHHH–”

*****

“Traps, what are you doing!” Scorpia tried to keep one eye on the sky while also getting the once again manic engineer off from climbing on the steering equipment.

“There’s no time to explain! We need to get to the Basin!” Entrapta yelled, desperately punching in data to the system while simultaneously operating controls that were within the co-pilot position of reach, which made it harder to Scorpia to steer.

“Slow down, what is the basin!” Scorpia flicked switches to stabilize as much as she could while the ship took sloppy turns and jolts through the air while both princesses were pulling it in different directions.

“I can’t explain, we need to hurry!” Entrapta yelled, this time more shrill with desperation. It scared Scorpia to hear it.

“The Basin?” Scorpia turned around in her chair to see Huntara in the doorway that lead to the rest of the ship aside from the small cabin. Huntara stepped forward to lean over Scorpia’s chair and look at the landscape, one hand leaning on the console. “We’ll never make it to the Basin from here. Let me drive.”

She pushed Scorpia from the seat and took the wheel.

“Hey!”

“Move it or lose it, princess.”

“But it’s designed for pincers!”

“It’s got a *wheel* don’t it?” Huntara spat back, patience wearing thin.

Entrapta paid the exchange no mind, interested solely in the data she pulled from her crude device and the scorp-ship’s readings. She did notice as the ship veered to the right, speeding over the dunes towards more cliffs and skeletons rather than to the Valley of the Lost, where they were hoping to find an entryway to the tunnels which they could extract Catra from. She relaxed slightly, but still on edge as she raced to crunch the numbers.

*****

Catra slammed desperately at the arms of the captain’s chair, wishing there was some sort of direct command override to the course. She knew that with every meter that the mole dug underground, the more of the desert would be upturned by the heaving earth around her, and who knew where there might be more civilians in danger. Even if they were outlaws to whom she owed nothing.

“Halt course! Cease action! Turn off auto regulation!” She kept yelling, but the computer refused her command.

“Query: denied. Life support systems on self sustain mode. No authorization capable of override.”

Catra growled and sat in the captain’s chair, her claws piercing the metal as her tense body tried to stabilize for the bumpy ride through pitch black.

“Explain life support systems!”

“Query: ship operation: accepted. Life support systems will keep the vessel operational as long as it takes to find an alternative way back through functioning portal source power back to home planet Eternia.”

Catra’s ears folded back, her own version of going pale in the face if it weren’t for her coppery fur.

“Alternative portal?” She repeated hoarsely

“Affirmative. Vessel will conceal any sign of Eternian life underground a safe distance from uncharted and dangerous magical effects. Emerging only to find working portal to transport vessel safely to Eternia.”

Catra raked her claws through her frazzled hair. The fucking portal. Of course it came back to that somehow. Hordak opens a half working portal system for a few hours, and the huge energy

that it gave off in making that fake world was enough to wake up this thing which was asleep.

The bunker must have been an emergency plan, in case the wild magic of Etheria became too dangerous and endangered the colonists here. They wanted to understand it, perhaps even use it as a battery. But it was risky.

Mara once banished all the First Ones from the planet and hid Etheria in a safe place without stars hundreds of years ago. Some of them must have escaped to the bunker instead of retreating to the home world, hoping it would all blow over, only for their home to be stranded in another dimension across the universe. They had died hoping that they could find a way home, hiding underground forever if they had to.

The mole was protecting its people. It went into a stasis state but was always scanning for signs of a way to get back. The portal goes off centuries later, and it has hope that it can find a way to engage the portal again. Even though nobody was left to return to Eternia. Even though its running on fumes of energy, barely restocked by any residual energy leaking from the Fright Zone. Even though it failed to protect its people long enough.

Catra felt sick. The jolting movements of the mole drilling through the Crimson Waste at an alarming rate only thrashed her empty stomach even more.

She felt her back press into the seat more as the mole tilted up, the drills and gears chuffing away at the stone as it made its way

for the surface. Catra had no choice but to hold on tight, and pray to everything she held dear that there were no civilians nearby when they would soon breach the surface in search for the faint portal energy.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

I forgot I had this tab open whoops

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora twisted the knob wrapping around her binoculars, and the image zoomed in more. She hummed thoughtfully scanning over the green pastures of Bright Moon castle.

"Target acquired." She confirmed in a low whisper.

The lens blurred for a moment while the foreground came up, then focused on the image of a white horse with rainbow wings. She adjusted to zoom out slightly while he walked towards her more without ever losing sight of the target.

"Is he alone?" Glimmer whispered back. Adora's partner was lying down on her belly taking notes from the balcony while Adora herself did the spying, both of them in sync as they watched Swift wind's movements.

Adora made another hum in thought, her scope broadening to scan the area.

"He's coming within range of her now."

Swift wind had tried so hard to give up on his love for Duchess, he really had after so much wounded pride with past attempts. But the poor stallion was simply inconsolable with heartbreak, and since Adora was empathetically connected with him, it ached deep in her heart.

Glimmer had always been a commander of action, of course. And this, Adora being all sad and heartbroken, would not stand.

She was a bit surprised at how easy it had been to convince Adora to come out and spy the pasture, though she really shouldn't have been surprised. The ex-soldier easily grew restless. Especially with Catra far away and out of touch, and still unable to figure out her own healing abilities to mend her broken bones from the events that led up to the portal. Glimmer would have liked to leave the horses alone, but if it was going to help Adora feel better, then she was going to help spy on the castle pasture to pass the time waiting for their third to return.

Adora made a slight sound then, a tiny gasp as something happened that Glimmer could not see.

"What is it? Did he say something?"

"He picked a flower. But he isn't eating it?" Adora mused and watched Swift wind move across the grassy pasture with the flower in his teeth. But she paused to look away from the lens and towards her girlfriend "But you know I can't hear him if he talks down there, right? It's just a visual."

"Oh shush, tell me where he's going with the flower!"

"Right!" She looked back through the binoculars.

On a nice day like today, Swift wind's silky soft coat was really shining. Especially after the wash Adora had given him, hoping a spa day would cheer him up. She grinned a bit watching him now, clean and smooth as he walked in the shimmering light of the day and the nearby Moonstone. Still he protected the stem of his little blue flower as he approached Duchess, the filly of his affection.

Adora smiled. Surely, he must be making his move! Now more smooth and subtle. Perhaps it wasn't meant to be a grand gesture like what got the war hero with her girlfriends, but rather a soft little token of appreciation that would help the nervous mare to come around.

"He's approaching Duchess now." Adora reported in a whisper, even though it was certain that the horses in the field wouldn't be

able to hear her.

“From what angle? She gets startled from behind.” Glimmer asked. Adora nodded, recalling how the mare would jump if someone came up from behind.

“He’s on her 2 o'clock.” She confirmed. Glimmer squinted at the bright sunny field to try and figure out their orientation from that, trying to see the distant figures in better detail. Swift wind was easy enough to spot even without much detail, thanks to his bright white coat and multicolored mane and wings.

“It looks like he’s talking to her. What’s he saying?” Glimmer nudged Adora impatiently. Adora again had to put down the binoculars.

“Glim, it lets me see what’s far away, not hear.”

“UGH this is taking too long.” The princess grabbed her girlfriend and shimmered with energy. Adora blinked and quickly steadied herself on a tree branch that was half the distance away from her steed. The soldier was always quick on her feet, and by the time the sparkles had faded from her vision she was ready for more recon. She was quick to raise the binoculars again and spy on Swiftwind.

“Yup, he’s definitely talking to her.” She confirmed.

“Is she responding?”

Again, Adora lowered the binoculars with a sigh “If you know of any other talking horses in Etheria who were awakened by the Sword of Power I would love to hear about it.” Of course, it wasn’t in Adora’s nature to sass her girlfriend. She valued her life too much. But Glimmer is after all, Adora’s commanding officer, and that should demand a bit of decorum when it comes to common sense.

Adora wasn’t sure why Glimmer was egging on this horse date so much. It seemed like ever since Catra had left on the mission,

Glimmer wanted to plot with Adora to do something, anything. And right now, with Adora recovering a few cracked ribs, there wasn't much that Angella would allow them to go do.

Adora knew that Catra would kill her if she got back from a mission in the desert to find that Adora had stupidly gotten hurt again. Not only that, but Adora was tired. She had been tired before, been worked to the bone and still powered through it like the soldier she was. But this was different. To put it in Glimmer's own vernacular, she was completely out of fucks to give.

She had seen horrible things of what was and what could have been. Haunted by visions of what was out of reach and couldn't possibly exist. Her deepest desires, and worst fears. And it all faded like ashes in a breeze in front of her.

It was outside her normal behavior. But Adora just wanted to sit and contemplate what had happened, to digest what her own subconscious– if her own subconscious had even had any input in it or not– had tried to lure her in with. She wanted to stop moving, for once in her life, and let herself catch up with where she found herself now. Perhaps with some of Angella's tea, somewhere quiet in the palace garden.

The only problem with that was that Glimmer, one of many people who usually try to convince Adora to slow down, was raring to go. It was easy to understand Glimmer's eagerness to move on from the portal event they had narrowly escaped. Adora might even understand Glimmer trying to keep up with Adora in her more active lifestyle.

All day, the two princesses devoted a bit more energy than they typically would–or should–to the romantic life…. Of a horse.

Adora smiled at that. It was certainly a change of pace from life threatening crises that might have filled her schedule weeks or months earlier. Through the lens, she had a good view of Swift wind proudly showing off his agile, athletic form with a trot around Duchess, head held high like a show pony.

“I think she likes it” Glimmer nudged Adora encouragingly as she watched them both. Adora nodded with a look of amusement.

It was strange, how easily she would always let Glimmer suck her into these antics and shenanigans. As a combined force they were unstoppable at times. But why invest herself so wholly into getting Swiftwind a date?

Adora looked away from the binoculars for a moment to look at Glimmer at her side. The princess had one hand supporting Adora at her back so they could balance together on the thick bough of the tree. But her smile was more focused on the field below rather than the true object of her affection. Adora wanted to kiss her. Her sparkling freckles like glitter, her supporting hand on her, her grinning lips.

It made Adora think of Catra. As much as she needed to catch her breath after the whirlwind events of the portal, she needed her girls with her just as badly as she needed air. Even with Catra away for a short time, probably even a vacation for her, it made a hollow feeling in Adora’s chest.

Catra… so long out of her reach. So much work to gain her back in Adora’s life. At the very least, this whole romance for Swiftwind provided Adora not only with entertainment, but a distraction from–

Oh. Oh, of course. Adora looked back at Glimmer again with a new appreciation. She understood now the meaning behind her victorious smile.

It wasn’t about Swift Wind. It was about taking care of Adora in her own Adora needs in a very Glimmer way.

Adora smiled full of love and leaned into Glimmer’s shoulder.

“Hey. I love you.” She repeated for the 112th time that very day. Glimmer smiled with more warmth and pride at the recognition.

“Love you too, babe. What are the horses doing?” She nudged Adora’s elbow.

Adora chuckled and raised the binoculars again. “I think he’s going to turn out just fine.”

***

“You’re HURTING it, let me!” Scorpia screeched, her large body draped over the back of the pilot's chair.

“Get your claws off me!” Huntara held one hand on the steering wheel and used the other to try and shove Scorpia up and off the chair, a failed attempt to clear her line of vision as she attempted to land the Scorp-jet in a giant bowl of wide, natural purple stones covered in dust.

“You don’t know the landing protocols, let me or you’ll crash all of us!” Scorpia’s pincer tip just barely reached enough controls, just enough to scrape by half of the landing sequence that she and she alone was trained to do in the Horde. The wheels popped out but the engines hardly had time to adjust and stabilize before they kicked up a dust storm around the ship.

“Get off my back or I will MAKE you sit down, princess!” Huntara growled and pulled at the wheel so the ship leveled with the ground moments before making rough contact. Meanwhile Entrapta sat in the copilot seat completely tuning out everything that the two were yelling, as she desperately looked around the panels and her pad for solutions to problems that only she could see. The rough acceleration and jerking around was nothing to her.

She had to think fast. She was only running at a fraction of her normal operational speed ever since the loss of her hair, something that weighed heavily in her chest not just for the loss

of what could be described as her primary source of mobility and problem solving, but due to the casualties that this equation had presented which may have been preventable had she solved the problem faster.

The jolt of the jet bouncing slightly as the wheels skid to a halt in the dry basin halted that dark train of thought before Entrapta could see it through. And for the better, too. To an outsider, her time in the Crimson Waste may look like the regular chaos and scatter brained high speed adventure that she normally tries to keep contained in her labs. But she knew what this meant. Her banishment, what the mole was looking for, all of it. Swirling in her head alongside strings of numbers and variables that she had the sole responsibility of solving before anyone else could die.

Before waiting for the enormous dust cloud to settle outside, Entrapta had the side door open and was leaping straight into the vicious storm of sand. That was fine. She knew where the engines were and how they would work, which vents to avoid and where the air would propel most of the sand and other harsh micro-debris. She could vaguely hear Scorpia yelling with worry for her as she ran in a calculated path to avoid the swirling tornadoes of the sandstorm. She tuned it out, as was a bit too easy to do over the roar of the scorp-jet. This was no time to explain her methods or desperation even to as close a friend as Scorpia. Not when Catra's life could be on the line.

Scorpia at the same time found a face full of metal when she ran out to find Entrapta, only to be forced to a stop when Huntara yanked the door shut again.

"You crazy, claws? There's a full blown dust devil out there!"

"Entrapta is out there!"

"Getting yourself lost now that the winds have picked it up won't help her!" She shoved Scorpia back into the cockpit.

“What’s going on?!” Orkin came through while bracing himself on the doorframe to the cockpit. Scorpia was content to forget all about the party animals she had lugged along into her ship, but perhaps they could be of use now.

“Orkin! How many people do we have?” Scorpia stretched her neck up to see over his shoulder to the back cargo area. It was rare that she would meet someone who could meet her at eye level, but her own lost people seemed to tower over even her. It made more sense now why they would hide in the tunnels below the wasteland from the clutches of the horde. Hordak would have been too eager to put this massive workforce to thorough use.

“Uh, aside from you there’s me and like almost 10 altogether back there.” He did some quick math tallying up the names in his head. “8 scorpions, then you so 9. Why?”

Scorpia turned back to Huntara with the harsh look of a determined soldier.

“I might get lost in a dust storm, but we can survive it with our scales. ” Turning back to Orkin she gave quick instructions. “Get everyone lined up, we’re making a chain. Someone grab the door and on my mark, send out one at a time feeling along the chain. Stretch your tails if you have to.”

“You’re insane!” Huntara yelled again at the princess.

“I’m not leaving anyone behind!” Scorpia corrected. “I’m not losing Catra. I’m not going to lose Entrapta again. And we are stopping that mole. That’s my promise! Stay and watch the ship.” As she said the last sentence, Huntara felt the familiar click of handcuffs around her wrist. Her eyes widened. These damn claws moved differently than the pick-pocketing hands she had made her enemies and allies with here in the desert these past few years.

“You can’t lock me here!”

“Not risking you taking my ship. Now!”

With her signal, the first scorpiani opened the hatch and was instantly battered by wind and sand. She held onto the door frame with a vice-like grip in her powerful claw, not even making a dent in the hull of the ship built to withstand this type of pressure. Then she stepped out, and extended her tail backwards. The next scorpiani closed their eyes against the buffeting sand which blew through the open door, and felt their way along their comrade to the tip of the tail, careful of the poison point, and held onto the hook of her tail with his claw, and extended his tail back. The next scorpiani followed the same pattern, and another, making a long chain of people from the door out into the storm. Blinded by flying sand, the scorpiani handled the rest of the storm effortlessly with their tough carapace and thick skin. So long as they kept their eyes closed they would be safe, and would rely on feeling their way across the chain for direction.

Meanwhile, Entrapta followed the slope of the land to the lower rim of the basin. She didn’t know its full scope, could hardly see her own pad in front of her thanks to the strong winds and harsh sand in her eyes. But she knew the topographical data she collected and prayed that it had stayed mainly constant without being disturbed by the seismic activity of the mole.

There was little time. Based on the current trajectory, she had only seconds to attempt at diverting the mole and still had no plan on how to rescue Catra. She had to have faith in Catra being able to save herself, as Catra often had proved before.

Was it ideal? No, never. Entrapta had taken many risks to avoid putting her friends in harm. She had stayed in the horde even when all others fled so that she could continue to ensure the safety of her research and her planet. She could only hope that Catra would be able to deduce, wherever she was, that this time help would not be able to get to her in time.

She ran a gloved hand through the rough buzz of her hair. The screams of pain of the artificial limbs being hastily chopped off

would have to haunt her later. For now, she needed to replicate the portal.

"Entraptaaaaa!" Scorpia's voice cut through the whirling sand, but the engineer's mind was filled with equations and she had to rake through for just the right one.

"Entrapta, what are you doing?!" Scorpia soon trudged through the basin even closer.

"I'm recreating a portal-like experience!" She yelled, blinking heavily to make sure she input the correct variables.

"Are you crazy?! We've been working together on preventing the portal for years, then we saw how devastating it was to reality. You want to bring it back?! It could kill someone!"

A loud blast of sound reverberated from the handmade tablet that Entrapta wielded. Scorpia covered her ears and Entrapta merely flinched, partially expecting the boom of concussive sound and partially from an instinct to use her hair to do the job, which was unable to respond as she anticipated. She twisted a knob after her initial shock and the blast of sound dulled in volume until she could get the pitch and frequency she needed. Now quieter, she could play with the soundwaves like a child in a sandbox.

Scorpia shook her head from the shock and focused. "Wait a minute, that sound, it sounds like–!"

"Like the power up sound of the portal that Hordak made, yes I'm aware!" Entrapta didn't move her eyes from the soundwave, but her fingers were a blur across the screen and dials. "The same sound that everyone in the portal heard when the portal failed its power supply and set us all free. I know, I need to remake it!"

The sound became more trill like a repeating beat, one that had its own heartbeat and her eyes lit up. "Haha, yes!"

"Entrapta, I can't let you open another portal!" Scorpia pleaded.

“I won’t. I promise! Just look up there!” She pointed to the towering wall of stone that darkened the desert sand that swirled around them. Scorpia squinted to see, stretching her tail linked with the last scorpioni behind her in the line, but all she saw was a monolith of barren cliff, for hundreds of feet.

“I don’t see–” Then the ground started to shake.

****

The dark room that Catra was trapped in (she tried not to add “like a tomb” in her mind) rumbled and shook as the mole dug through more thick layers of impossibly thick sediment of the desert. She could hardly see anything other than the dimly lit panels of Eternian symbols and controls, none of which she could read.

The situation looked dire and while it seemed that there was no way out of this mess at the moment, her instincts refused to allow her to sit still. Despite the throbbing of her head, the dry smacking of her lips, the bleeding blisters on her paw pads, the spots of darkness swirling in her vision, the heaviness of her head, she would not let this place be her doom.

Ping! Ping! Ping! Portal activity detected.

“No… no there can’t be another portal!” Catra’s ears folded back in fear. “We shut it down. And it needs the sword!” Then again Hordak did get away…

“Affirmative” The voice of the holographic woman grated on Catra from the dark depths, invisible with the low power the ship was forced to run on. “Alternative portal confirmed via subterranean vibrational frequencies. Directing course towards source.”

Catra blinked, trying to remember what any of these words meant. Normally she would pride herself on keeping up with Entrapta's work, but with her body running on fumes and fighting off exhaustion she had to think hard just to concentrate on the words the computer was telling her.

"Show location, main screen!"

"…..Query: topographical indication, accepted." The computer, it seemed, was running on fumes as well, with barely any dredges of a battery left, it wanted only to focus on its mission of moving the mole rather than to adhere to whoever was in the captain's seat.

In a few seconds, the screen lit up dimly, with lots of flickering static. Catra pounded a fist on the console in frustration.

"Come on, stupid thing!"

The image flickered and made a radio static sound, then made a crude outline of topographical map lines of the Crimson Waste. She could easily tell that the blinking beacon at the center must be the mole she was trapped in. She panned the view ahead, focusing solely on the glitching images that lit up the darkness around her, and saw the terrain sweep down in a huge empty bowl. Perhaps an ancient lake? There was something in the center of it, sending out waves that were picked up on the sonar through the ground.

"SHIT" Catra's eyes widened "Avert course! Cancel destination!"

"Query: denied."

"Eternia!"

"Query: denied. Ship override protocols initiated."

"Screw you!"

"Query: denied"

“AAAAAGGGGH” Catra leapt for the open doorway back to the main hallway. With the rumbling of the ship around her through solid bedrock and limestone, it was bumpy enough that even she lost her balance and slammed a shoulder against the doorframe. Her mind was spinning as soon as she got to her feet, desperate to rest but dying to get out of here.

“I will NOT die here!” She stumbled through the hallway, unsure if the computer could still hear her this far out or if it was everywhere in the mainframe. “Your mission is over. Your people are gone!” The lights flickered on and off around her, barely humming to life when she walked by clutching her aching side. “The war is over! And I won’t let you make me a victim of it!”

She looked over her shoulder back to the main control room and the darkness of rock around it. She had to time this perfectly, or she was as good as gravel. She stood in position, vision fading but forcing herself to stay upright between the smooth pillars. Her claws dug into the chipping tile beneath her feet and she panted with exertion. She could almost feel the moment getting closer with how the mole tried to shake her free, or perhaps it was simply different enough geologically to make the beast work harder at it. Her vision almost went entirely black when she heard a long, low metallic groan which could only be from the mole struggling to pull itself through one last heave, and yet at the same time sounded too much like a defiant and stubborn growl from a living creature. She peeled her eyes open at the harsh sound and saw a crack of bright light on desert sand, a break in the dark earth around them that shone brightly through the eye-windows of the mole and that her keen eye could see from here, down the hall, ready and waiting to jump free.

“ETERNIA!” She pounded a fist on the panel which had first brought her down into these cursed depths, and it whirred weakly, gears grinding to pull her back up. The blinding light ahead widened to fill her view and the capsule rushed into the hot air above as soon as the mole was free of the bedrock.

She had less than half a second to grab onto something sturdy. In the time it took the platform to rise up from the mole’s back, most of it was free of the cliff already, and would soon tumble down into the sandstorm below in its search for the portal signal. The obsessed beast would sooner run itself out of a hundred story drop in a cliff to find power than give up on its mission.

The light blinded Catra, and she could again feel the searing heat in her fur of the sand that whirled around from the dust storm below. She didn’t think twice about her next action, and as soon as she could fit her body through the gap of the rising platform’s ceiling, she made a break for it, racing down its metal spine towards the cliff.

It was an uphill struggle, battered by rocks and dust that the body pushed free of the cliff and right into her, pulling her down with the mole that would soon crash like a meteor to the surface. She could see the red cliff face just a few feet away, and yelled in agonizing struggle to get closer, to close that gap and grab onto something, anything!

The G-force of the loss of smooth metal beneath her feet slid away and her stomach dropped. Her arms reached out, bracing her against a boulder twice her size and leaping off of it into midair. She floated through the air in slow motion as her mind sped up to every detail around her, could this be the end? Flying through the air hundreds of feet above a deadly desert, moments from just barely making it or finally racing to her own end, either way she wished she were not alone for it.

Chapter End Notes

A cliff hanger? In MY fic? It's more likely than you think

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

> Catra has never been more beaten or cornered than she is now, can she still find a way out?

Adora relaxed back into her bed. It was nothing more than a hard cot with a plain pillow and one single blanket, but it was all the comfort she needed. She sighed and stretched out her legs, sore from running around the fields on horse related missions. A soft smile spread over her tired face.

"Do my eyes deceive me?" Glimmer came up behind Adora and gently held her shoulders, circling her thumbs over tight muscles to coax her into relaxing. Adora could hear her amused smirk. "Is Adora relaxing?"

Adora chuckled and shrugged.

"Hey, I'm allowed. Swift wind is happy, which means I can take a break from the anxiety express." She didn't mention that she was on to Glimmer's plot about keeping her busy. Telling Glimmer would only hurt her pride. It was cute seeing Glimmer all smug like this.

"Good. You deserve a break after what Hordak put you through." Glimmer nodded assertively. Adora could tell that Glimmer was still beating herself up for letting Hordak get away. Even with no army, no technology, and a body that would soon rapidly fail him,

he was still a threat. Adora tensed just at the mention of his name. Glimmer could sense that Adora’s relaxation was gone.

“Crap, did I mess it up?”

“No, no it's nothing.” Adora waved it off, but still her mind was quick to remind her that Hordak was still at large somewhere out there. “I don’t know. Do you think Catra’s okay?”

“Of course! Why wouldn’t she be?”

Adora opened her mouth to answer but Glimmer was quick to cut in before Adora’s thoughts could spiral, pressing on.

“Catra is fine. She’s out with her two besties. We have our best friend trio, she has one too. As long as they stick together I’m sure that she’ll come back perfectly fine. Hell, it'll probably be a nice break for her.”

“A break? What,fr om us?”

“You have to admit, she wouldn’t be as excited as we were for getting a horse on a date.” Glimmer smiled affectionately. Adora chuckled and relaxed a bit more.

"No, you're right. She and Swifty don't really get along… Still, I can't help but miss her. And who knows what's out there in the waste? Bow said that explorers don't really come back from there."

"Yeah well the waste is *huge* . Besides, this is Catra we're talking about. She's the best strategist the war has ever seen. Trust me, we have nothing to worry about."

***

Scorpia's mouth hung open in shock as the mole emerged from the wall of cliff, its wide claws tearing apart the earth like it had when it opened the sinkhole which earlier took Catra. Before she could comprehend its magnitude and size, it began to tumble straight down, legs spreading wide in a desperate search for land just seconds too late.

She gasped and quickly shielded Entrapta with her body just as the concussive BOOM shook the ground and rattled her bones. Scorpia cringed and waited for the crash of screeching metal to reach its peak and subside again, her ears screaming for relief. A strong gust of wind rushed out from the collision of the beast on the ground, and she had trouble for a moment staying balanced

as she continued to protect Entrapta, although it did benefit in overpowering the sandstorm enough for the swirling sands to stop.

Scorpia blinked her eyes open hesitantly, her ears ringing from the explosion the mole had created. She looked around and coughed away the remaining sand and soot as she released Entrapta, who merely shook her head from the shock but had little other reaction. The engineer quickly got to her feet and held up her pad, apparently using its scope similarly to a telescope as she immediately observed the wreckage.

"Astounding! Even after an impact of terminal velocity it appears to be mainly intact with only surface level damage."

"It's still okay?!" Scorpia hunched over to look at the pad over Entrapta's shoulder in panic. If that wouldn't finish it off, she wasn't sure what *would* . But as she looked, she could see the light in its eyes fade and eventually the whole body went dark as its limbs appeared to go limp, unable to stabilize itself as the last dredges of power were shaken free and it died at last. She sighed in relief.

"Is everyone okay?" She asked the line of Scorpionis who were still linked up to not lose her way to the jet. She was answered with a monotone chorus of groans and coughs which confirmed they were still standing, just shaken up. "Entrapta, do you see Catra anywhere?" She asked, and Entrapta nodded and instantly started to scope the wreckage in more detail.

“Up there!” She pointed up to the cliff, much higher than Scorpia would have liked to be near anything that Catra should be around, near the yawning cavern that the mole had dug out from.

“The tunnel?!” She squinted to look closer at the distant cliff face, but struggled to make out Catra’s wild brown mane against the red rocks. Entrapta held up the pad and zoomed in more where she was picking up Catra’s movement. Scorpia was then able to see the grainy image of Catra, weak and bleeding, as her arms shakily grasped at old dead roots which protruded from the rocks, her only grasp keeping her from plummeting hundreds of feet as the mole had.

Scorpia gasped again and grabbed Entrapta in her claws.

“She could fall! We need to get her in the–” She turned around to look for the chain of Scorpioni leading back to the jet, and was confused to see that line slowly sliding away.

“Uuuuh boss?!” Revna, the last one on the chain, reached out for her. Scorpia put Entrapta on her shoulder and took Revna’s pincer in her own.

“What’s going on!” Scorpia dug her heels into the sand but could feel the scorpioni all being pulled away.

“It’s the jet!”

Her confusion was replaced quickly with rage as she recognized the sound of her engines revving on in the scorp-jet.

" *Huntara* !"

***

So close. I'm so close. Can't stop now. Just a bit more. Catra thought her mantra to herself, possibly the only thing keeping her going at this point as her shaking limbs hung limply from the root in the cliff. It was mantras like these which had gotten her through her darkest days in the Fright Zone, slinking back into her bunk under the cover of darkness after a punishment from Shadow Weaver. She hadn't found much use for such words of desperate encouragement when she was on her own in the woods, because quite frankly at that chaotic point in her life there was no guarantee that safety would be around the corner.

Her sweating palms slid further down the rough surface of the root, tearing at her skin and lowering her even closer to slipping off into the giant chasm below. Catra panted and gripped tighter, her claws digging into her own skin slightly. *I can't stay like this long. Think, Catra. Just a little while longer, but then what?* She could hope and pray all she wanted that Scorpia and or Entrapta would be coming to her rescue, but she couldn't put all her faith in that and risk falling to her death while she waited.

Sweat coursed down her back, her whole body stretched out from reaching for this root while gravity pulled her aching body down. She wished that she had Glimmer's ability to teleport at a moment like this.

The earth surrounding the root began to crumble away from the force she exerted on it. Dust floated down to her face annoyingly as more of the root came loose, it was only a matter of time before Catra would be in freefall. Her heart pounded loudly in her ears, head throbbing, and thought of her options. None of her acrobatics training in the horde had quite prepared her for a moment suspended in midair like this. She squinted to look at the rocks above the cave entrance the mole had made, if only she could reach them they might hold her longer. She could try and swing her body on the root and leap up, but if she missed her one shot, she was as good as dead. She swallowed the dryness of her throat and, seeing no other options, began to force her stiff legs and tail to start swinging.

***

Dust kicked up around the jet turbines as Huntara engaged the vertical take off. It sure wasn't the average smuggled skiff that could be scrapped for a dime a dozen here, but a vehicle is a vehicle, and any Etherian could figure out an engine after enough experience in the field.

Now, she just had to get rid of these pesky Scorpions on her heels.

Huntara revved up and hoped that she could shake them, but their pincers had a vice-like grip even as she tried to pull up they didn't give up.

"HUNTARA" The big one yelled in fury. Huntara rolled her eyes.

"Buzz off, princess!"

"How did you–"

"You think I can't pick your lousy horde locks?!" Huntara yelled, offended, and revved the engine again. More sand swooped around the open jet and she could feel a few inches, maybe even a foot of takeoff before the weight dragged her down again. "Get your bug people off my ride!"

"We are NOT bugs!" The guy hanging onto the door yelled back. "Ain't no way you're taking the princess' chariot!" He even blew a raspberry at Huntara. She rolled her eyes. How old were these idiots?

"I didn't come this far on a charity trip. Time you suckers learned the rules of the Crimson waste." Huntara growled and strapped into the pilot seat fully.

Maneuvering the airship was a breeze, it was figuring out which toggles would get her more power that she needed some trial and error with. But hell if she wasn't determined to come out on top of this whole crisis that threw the rest of the waste into chaos; she was number one around here for a *reason* and panicking over the earthquakes wasn't it.

With a lead foot on the gas and using all her strength to pull up on the throttle, Huntara heaved the ship from the ground again in a much more powerful burst of wind and sound from the six turbines. This time the ship took off up into the sky, but she could still feel the deadweight on the port side dragging her down; she had to throttle that side just to balance it out.

"Don't you people quit?!" Huntara screamed over the engines, pulling the ship out of the larger basin until she could see more of the cliffs and barren dunes that she called home for the last few decades, still dragging a line of people behind her. At this point if they let go, it could be fatal, even with their thick exoskeleton.

"NEVER!" Scorpia, their ring leader and the craziest of them all, climbed up the line of people towards the hull in the hopes of taking over her command in the cockpit. The ship rocked violently in the air from the opposing forces of Scorpia and her people clinging on for their lives, and Huntara getting increasingly desperate to shake them. Huntara had to keep one eye on the controls, one eye on the sky, and one eye on the open hatch before she risked careening straight into the cliff.

Meanwhile, the scorpioni people were as determined as they were sturdy, and clung to each other around the waist or legs with vigor, shouting messages from the cockpit down to Scorpia at the bottom, clinging onto Revna and relaying messages up to Orkin at the top hatch, his claws digging into the hull of her ship stubbornly. Scorpia clung to the last person in the chain of course, but also wrapped her knees under Entrapta's armpits so that the engineer could keep tracking with her pad while swinging at the bottom.

"Higher, to the left!" Entrapta yelled, eyes still fixated on her makeshift pad. Revna relayed the message higher up the line, only for Orkin to yell it at Huntara with a glare which she gruffly ignored.

The sound of Catra's claws scraping against sandstone was harsh on her sensitive ears, but soon drowned out to the familiar sounds of the scorp-jet whirring up closer from the basin. Catra grunted with effort of trying to concentrate her balance on the precipice her hands desperately clung to, legs still kicking the air to find a way to heave her up and finding nothing. Only when her claws stopped sliding down the dusty cliff could she risk looking over her shoulder and seeing if Scorpia had come to the rescue, only to find an odd scene: the jet she recognized, but the half dozen people hanging off it's open hatch she did not, save for Scorpia and Entrapta at the tail of the chain.

Couldn't be a coincidence that they were here, of all the places in this barren wasteland, where she was hanging for her life from a cliffside. She was able to note quickly that Scorpia's attention was directly–and furiously, which was a new look for Scorpia–on the cockpit and whoever the hell was driving, while Entrapta was her usual self and glued to her pad.

I can work with this Catra nodded with resolve. She took a risk and shifted her weight more on her left arm, the right shakily coming down to her side.

"Here!" Her voice cracked hoarsely and she flailed her arm to catch Entrapta's attention.

The ship rocked recklessly in the air, bobbing like a buoy on its uneven weight or possibly a novice pilot. It was still far too low for Catra to reach even if she had the strength for a full leap. She tried to wave them up, but she couldn't see the pilot through the shaded visor. She hissed at the full strain of her body weight against her five claws in the sandstone, grating on her forearm with the heat of an oven after baking in the full daymoon light all day. It was impossible to tell if the pilot was reacting to Catra's motion or not, as the ship lifted ever higher at a crawling pace against the deadweight.

"Graaaab ooooooonnnnn!" Entrapta yelled to Catra as she came closer to view, extending her legs for reach. Technology be damned, the woman had great core strength from swinging around her lab on her prehensile hair.

Catra still had to take half a second to balk in disbelief. There had to be a better way to do this; hell she had jumped off an ice palace into the open windshield of the ship before in the old days, why use a chain of people now?

But as her numb fingers in the stone overhead reminded her, she had no time to debate safety when she was seconds away from falling to her death. She judged the distance between herself and Entrapta skeptically, it would be a miracle for her to stick this landing even if her head wasn't spinning already.

She shook her head and tried to force her vision to focus on Entrapta. With a deep breath to steele her nerves, and took a leap of faith.

Catra wished it was a moment that felt as though it went in slow motion. She wished that she could see the fleeting moment of her freedom hanging in the balance as her extended arms lunged towards one of her closest friends. Catra would have loved to see the precision of movement and the details of her brief flight so she could micro-correct midair, and adjust herself to absorb the impact of the collision with Entrapta's torso.

The sad reality of the fact was that it was over in an instant, throwing her body off the cliff and diving towards Entrapta with every limb flailing, instantly colliding into her chest, arms and legs wrapping around and claws digging into the dusty overalls, the impact sending Entrapta and thereby the whole chain of people spinning beneath the jet.

Catra's brain rattled in her skull from shock and impact, her entire field of vision going black for a moment.

"CATRA!" Scorpia yelled overhead and while she was relieved to hear her voice, the panic of her scream did nothing for Catra's

racing heart.

She looked up the chain with difficulty to see the jet still struggling to take off out of the basin, and she and Entrapta at the bottom were at risk of hitting the cliff wall like bugs on a windshield.

"Who's driving this thing?!" Catra yelled up, and pulled her knees up to her chest as much as she could afford around Entrapta in the process to avoid losing them against a crag.

"Huntara!" Scorpia answered with a glare upwards. In that one look, Catra instantly understood the situation and its chaos, and had a new set of objectives.

It never fucking ends Catra grumbled internally.

"Sorry, goggles!" Catra began to maneuver her limbs in order to do less clinging and more climbing, easier on the grip of a person than it was on solid stone.

"No worries, do your thing!" Entrapta arched her back so that Catra would have more surface to push off of on her ascent, and Catra did just that.

That was the great thing about the super pal trio. Catra loved the best friend squad, but these people here understood a *clear*

objective and no need to make dramatic speeches or sacrifice oneself to danger; Catra's crew understood that even though everything sucked and they could die any second, they had a role they could play in helping, and they fulfilled it without even being asked. Catra thanked her lucky stars to no longer be alone with the mole but with her two closest friends, even in the face of danger. Especially in the face of danger.

Catra was at the end of the chain, not holding anyone else up, and was the most dextrous and agile of all the group. She was not only the obvious but the *only* choice to stop this madness, despite her condition. Before she could rationalize her climb, she was already halfway up Scorpia, then whoever the next person was after that. Fortunately, their build was not so different from Scorpia that Catra felt out of her depth, for she was well used to climbing the rough exoskeleton of her friend for a height advantage, and found this a similar climb.

"Pardon me. Sorry. Shit, watch the tail!" Catra clambered up the line of half a dozen people closer to the violently rocking ship. By now the jet had climbed up higher above the level of the basin and was coasting over the sandy dunes of the desert that Catra had seen when they arrived at the Waste. But Catra could pay no mind to that now, only set on getting to the open hatch which would lead her to the cockpit if she wanted to save everyone.

The hardest part was avoiding the dangerous stinger tails of the scorpion people, but to their credit, Catra knew well that they were trying their best just to hang on for their lives and didn't mean to lash, just as her own tail was doing as she struggled to keep balanced. But with one more adjustment to cling to the bulky guy on top as the balance shifted under her, the hatch was

within her sights. With both pincer claws clamped down like a vice, the metal was visibly distressed.

Just a bit further. Just a bit longer, then we can rest. Catra panted and tried to focus on her task. One more lunge, one more grapple, one more bad guy.

She collapsed on the floor of the jet panting and shaking. Under any other circumstances she would have passed out. But she stubbornly repeated her mantra, forcing herself to her feet again to stand on broken bones, glaring at the pilot who would threaten innocent people in a stolen vehicle.

The jet lurched again as Huntara spun the wheel to try and shake the chain off yet again and Catra nearly lost her balance, using her arm against the wall. Huntara still hadn't noticed her here over the noise of the wind and the engines through the open hatch. Could it be easy for once?

She snuck up as much as she was able to in her broken, exhausted condition, which was the least sneaky thing she had ever done in her life. Coming up behind Huntara, she balled up a fist, and swung with all her remaining strength only to meet air as Huntara ducked forward at the last second, and reached up to grab Catra's wrist.

Now was the moment that Catra felt in slow motion, her strength failing her, when everything went in slow motion.

It was such a stupid ruse to fall for. How could she have ever possibly thought that Huntara wouldn't know Catra was stumbling up behind her? She could feel her heart sink to her stomach with dread as the realization informed her moments too late of her error and how utterly fucked she was right now. Huntara's calculating eyes turned to meet her own panicked look in slow motion, letting Catra notice every detail in the warrior's face and absorbing it to memory. Her smug expression, the deep hatred in her eyes, even the light sweat that glinted from her brow. Catra felt alone all over again and wished she had the power of she-ra to fight back.

But it was too late, Huntara yanked Catra's forearm to clock their skulls together, stunning Catra. She fumbled back two steps and fell on her ass with a groan. Huntara set the controls on auto for a moment–which at least should spare the scorpioni from the shaking for a moment– and stood up, marching towards Catra and cracking her knuckles.

"You really want to fight this fight, pussycat?" Huntara glared down at Catra with a cruel grin.

Catra backed away as much as she could on her elbows and heels, looking up at the shadow of the giant woman approaching her. Her head blocked out the glaring light from the windshield, and Catra had never felt this small or hopeless in a fight as now.

Her eyes blinked and looked around the ship interior for something, anything, that she could use to her advantage – a weapon, a shield, something!

“I didn’t come this far… to give up now!” Catra croaked weakly, glaring in defiance. Huntara laughed and shook her head.

“Give up? That’s something people choose when they’re cornered. You lost a *long* time ago, kid. That option isn’t open right now. You’re mine.”

“Eat shit.” Catra crawled backwards with her one arm that felt slightly less broken, forcing her legs to push her back until she felt a wall behind her.

Huntara came one step in front of Catra and kneeled down with a pitying smile to mock her one last time. “You’re lucky, commander Catra. At this height, it will barely hurt. Your guts will spread for miles when you hit the surface.”

“Oh yeah?” Catra held up a bit of rescue rope. Huntara looked at it, then back to Catra. After a moment she laughed hard enough to wipe a tear from her eye.

“You think this will save you?” Huntara took the rope from her shaking hands, waving it around in a sarcastic manner. “You can’t even hold onto a rope right now, much less to save your life!” She laughed.

Catra smiled. “No. But you can.” Then she pulled a small handle on the wall behind her, knowing exactly what it did. Huntara on the other hand did not know the purpose of this, but didn’t have

time to guess before the floor panel beneath her swung open, and Huntara found herself falling fast.

The rope unravelled quickly, then snapped tighter than a piano wire when it reached its length. One end fastened to jet interior, the other end now desperately wrapped around Huntara's desperate hands, she swung through the air just like the scorpioni people she had tried to thrash off the same ship as they laughed and mocked her for ending up in the same situation as them.

Catra quickly looked down the open hatch and confirmed that neither Huntara nor the Scorpioni people were going anywhere. Relief flooded her, and her vision doubled for a moment as she wanted nothing more than to faint and wake up safely in Brightmoon again. But she wasn't done yet.

Her empty stomach heaved, and her hands shook violently as she crawled, unable to walk for lack of strength, back to the pilot chair. *Just a few buttons and we can all go home….* She thought to herself, unable to even speak now. The desert beneath the ship blurred and swirled, threatening to go dark as she struggled through the full protocols for flying and landing.

Red: solid ground. She gently steered the wheel in a long curve to head for it, and lowered the engine power incrementally. So close. So close.

She had to be careful landing, making a slow descent so as not to crush any of the people, friend or foe, who were swinging wildly from the bottom. As they were about 10 feet from ground, the

lowest on each chain began to jump free and land with relief, then run to clear the way for more to jump off. First Entrapta, then Scorpia, then working up the chain. About half way, Huntara jumped off, but was blocked off from escaping by those who were already landed around her. If Scorpia had knuckles, she would be cracking them intimidatingly right now as she glared at Huntara for double crossing them and putting all their lives at stake. Huntara seethed and tried to find an opening out.

Eventually, the jet made contact with the red sandstone, and the engines powered off, finally a relief to their ears. The scorpiani all cheered and high-clawed and chest bumped in victory that they all made it out of the stunt alive!

"Watch her, don't let her leave!" Scorpia ordered Orkin, while she and Entrapta ran for the open side hatch into the jet.

Catra could faintly hear the cheers of survival, could faintly feel the heat of the day beating down through the visor, could faintly feel the wind push through the open hatches. But her senses quickly went numb as the adrenaline wore off.

She slumped back in the seat. *We did it….* She thought to herself, the anxiety melting away from her aching muscles. *We survived…. We can go home….* She smiled faintly and finally, at long last, gave in to the oppressive darkness that was creeping in along her vision. The pain faded from her mind as she passed out at the wheel, the only sensation remaining was the ache of longing deep in her chest to be free of this place and the mess that it turned out to be.

Scorpia and Entrapta rushed inside as quick as they could, but Catra was already passed out hard, unresponsive to their onslaught of questions about her wellbeing.

Chapter 9

Catra dreamt of searing heat. It was the last thing that she wanted to experience after the past few days in the desert. Even in the numbness of her mind, she could feel the stinging tendrils of fire crawling under her skin.

Ah, she realized. *Not heat from the desert. The stupid lightning.*

Shadow Weaver was known to use spells to scare many cadets. But very few got the real taste when they had failed her orders. And none had known them more than Catra, who could never live up to her impossible standards. The lightning spells were a personal favorite of Shadow Weaver to use on Catra in particular, as she knew how the static filled air would make all of Catra's fur stand on end and make her uncomfortable for the rest of the day even after the punishment was done. Catra often left Shadow Weaver's chambers limping, choking back sobs of pain, her muscles stiff and spasming. Their whole squad knew what had happened. Adora was the only one Catra allowed near her afterwards to help brush the fur back in place smoothly, with no need to say words.

In her nightmares, Catra saw red arcs of lightning. Heard the loud crack of static when it flashed on metal surfaces. In an ironic way, Catra had to realize that compared to the reality of her many burns from her Horde years, the desert had been a walk in the park now.

Sure, she broke several bones. And yes, maybe went delirious with dehydration and starvation. And yeah, she was back-stabbed

multiple times and held captive far more than usual times per mission. And yes, she had sand everywhere that would take days to wash out – which would mean more baths, which she hated – but in the end, that ended up being for something. She found Entrapta. The Super Pal Trio was back on. The torture at the hands of the red bitch had been for nothing but show. But this? She had done something good.

The dreams went darker as she pushed the bad thoughts further away from her. The pain was more numb, the sounds less agonizing. It was fuzzy and distant as she remembered that things would be okay now. She breathed deep, and her lungs were clear and free. The air was cooler than she remembered.

She blinked her eyes open weakly, feeling crusty and stiff all over. She inhaled again. Her vision went from blurry patches of light and color to slowly sharpen. There were soft lilac lights hanging overhead, and smooth arches of slate blue making a wide, almost cavernous space. Her ears flicked as she blinked and looked around more. Could it be possible? Was this Brightmoon?

Catra coughed horsley, realizing there was a tube around her face that let air to her nose. She pulled it off without a second thought – she was a commander, she didn't need help breathing. It was harder than it looked to peel it off when one of her arms was in a sling, her forearm aching distantly. Her tail was also broken, it would appear from the splint. Really, there was no shortage to the bandages that now covered at least a third of her body if not more. She rolled her eyes. These Brightmoon medics seemed to have nothing but an excessive amount of bandage and free time on their hands, did they? Back in the horde, she could walk most of this off.

She sat up and looked around. The room was empty, but she heard voices. One she could immediately pin as Scorpia's excited tone, rambling off what sounded like a hundred words a minute. Catra cracked a small smile at that reassuring sound as she pulled the IV out of her arm. She and Adora were both well known for getting on the medical staff's collective nerves for always doing that after they were hurt, but they knew what they were doing.

Next to her bed was a tall pitcher of water, and an already filled cup. Her eyes widened, waking her up right away as she lit up at it – never before had she been so happy to receive such a wonderful gift as this. Her hands were no longer shaking so hard, but were still weak, as she reached a hand to hold the cup to her chapped lips and sucked it down quickly, then refilling it and doing so again. Cool, clean water washed through her insides and she sighed in relief to have something in her gut again, feeling the cascade of relaxation ease through her beaten system.

After that, she breathed much easier. Catra smiled as she heard Adora ask an urgent question to Scorpia about what had happened, and Scorpia described what happened next.

Catra took a deep breath and realized it was time for her to make her entrance. Sitting in hospital beds never did her much good. She weakly got to her feet and tried to maintain her balance with her tail in this ridiculous splint, and had to settle on using the IV drip stand as a sort of support as she went towards the door.

"And then suddenly the cliff EXPLODED, and rocks were falling everywhere!" Scorpia went on. "But then before the boulders even

finished falling, the mole monster appeared! It dug its way out, but there was nothing to stand on and it started –”

“CATRA!” Glimmer immediately poofed to her side. “Did you pull out the IV *again?!* ” she chuckled and checked her over. Adora was quick to join her side, stroking Catra’s cheek with her thumb, relief washing over her to see Catra on her feet again.

Catra smiled softly but still had to maintain her cool tough guy look around Scorpia and Entrapta.

“What, like a tiny rubber tube is going to make or break me? Come on Princess, give me some credit.”

“We were shocked when the scorpjet came back and we heard what happened.” Adora said. “We had no idea the Wastes were so dangerous. If only I had gone with you –”

“Oh don’t do that,” Catra cut her off. “Not everything has to fall on you, Adora.”

“That goes for you too, dumbass!” Glimmer nudged Catra’s good arm a bit roughly, and they all chuckled and embraced in a hug.

“Aw, the reunion!” Scorpia sniffled, holding her tail like it was a stuffed animal.

“Where’s Entrapta?” Catra asked once she parted from her two princesses.

“Catching up with Angella.” Scorpia answered.

“I can’t believe Hordak chopped off her hair like that….” Glimmer seethed, her fists clenching. Catra could tell that there was boiling hot rage in her blood, but at the same time, she looked like an agitated puff of cotton candy and it was cute.

The door opened, and Angella came in standing tall and regal as she always did. She smiled to see Catra on her feet again.

“Ignoring medical orders again, Commander?” She teased. Catra smirked, glad to be able to have a CO who knew there was no point in punishing someone as stubborn as Catra.

“I suppose Entrapta gave you her full assessment of the Crimson Waste?” Catra assumed, noting that the engineer was not with the queen. Angella nodded.

“A bit more than I needed to know, as is her way. Very astute, that one. In fact, she is eager to head a salvage mission back to the Waste once more recovered in order to study the bunker that was destroyed.”

Catra shook her head with a sigh. She probably should have guessed as much. Of course personally, Catra never wanted to see that ugly hulking mole again.

"I left her some time alone in the war room." Angella continued. "She seemed to have something on her mind. And for once, I believe it didn't have to do with technology."

Catra and Scorpia exchanged a worried look. A certain knowing of how Entrapta's priorities worked in the machinations of that wild mind seemed to illuminate the two of them on what might be bothering her. Catra nodded in understanding and took a deep breath.

"I'll go talk to her. I'm sure you guys want to hear the rest of Scorpia's story."

Catra limped her way through the palace halls, the familiarity of polished tile and marble soothing to her after the scorching sands at her feet. She found Entrapta in the war room going over maps and schematics, right where Angella had left her. Catra shut the door with enough sound so her approach would not startle her in her work as she mumbled to herself.

"Hey, goggles. We made it back alright, eh?" She came up and nudged Entrapta's elbow.

“Mhmm” Entrapta responded simply, more of a sound to notify that she acknowledged that Catra was talking than actually listening.

Catra looked at the file that Entrapta had open at the moment. It was a thick one: everything the Alliance knew about Hordak since he first formed the Horde. Catra’s heart sank as it confirmed the suspicion that she and Scorpia were worried about.

“You’re worried about where he went, aren’t you?” Catra sat down and picked up one of the pages of reports from one of Renee’s spies, trying to theorize which race he might be, but finding no evidence to land him in any category, despite Etheria having dozens of known humanoid races.

Entrapta glanced at the page in Catra’s hand briefly then back to her screens, combing through data. “It’s not just that.” She confessed. “We’ve learned *a lot* about the Crimson Waste without even really trying to. This is a total system overhaul. Turns out Adora was not the first deserter to abandon her post in the Horde army–”

“This isn’t about your data on the Waste.” Catra cut in with a gentle tone, knowing there was more.

“I’m getting there!” Entrapta said, taking a break to drink deeply from a water bottle that was attached to her hip. “Sorry, I know the strings of what’s connected can be difficult to follow. Let me try this again.”

Catra smiled slightly as Entrapta slowed down, closing her eyes to choose the right words to make her noisy mind make sense.

"Hordak sent me to the desert." She began again. "Most exiles are sent to Beast Island. Both have always been thought of as totally inhospitable points of no return."

Catra nodded, following.

"I was at his right hand spying on him when he banished one commander after another to Beast Island, fearing their inevitable betrayal. But then when I betrayed him, a pain deeper than any other since I was his most trusted associate, why send me somewhere so much more *local* instead of Beast Island?"

Catra leaned forward with concern.

"Are you saying that he gave you special treatment? Why?"

She looked back to the data, her native language. "I don't know. Based on all evidence, this form of deep betrayal of trust at such a critical time in his military career *should* have been a death sentence. But I was exiled. To an unexplored habitat on the mainland rather than a distant, isolated death. I've ruled out all logical conclusions, all that remains is…."

"....emotional…." Catra filled in, realizing where this was going. Her heart broke to see Entrapta this desperate with her remaining shred of hope. Entrapta nodded.

"He must have had faith that I would survive in this alternative exile, right? Which means he still–"

"Entrapta…" Catra reached for the other's arm to soothe her, to take her mind away from the maps and statistics for a moment. The touch startled her and she looked to Catra with the saddest eyes that Catra had ever seen the madwoman wear. Catra had always known that Entrapta's emotions ran deeper than most, she just had a strange way of showing it to others. But now, she had never looked more vulnerable, her eyebrows turned upwards with confusion and sadness.

"He must still know that there is *some* chance of redemption if he sent me there, right?" Her voice cracked. Catra sighed.

"I don't know." Catra confessed softly. "I only ever knew him as a dictator. But you're older than I am, you remember more of the war before it came to your shores. You certainly knew him better through working with him. I know that you show people how you feel in strange ways, hell maybe he does too. But look at your hair. Do you think his actions are showing you that he cares?"

Entrapta felt a hand through her buzzed purple fluff somberly, trying to feel for the missing phantom limb. She would need to rebuild it right away to feel anything like her old self again. But

after years as the closest spy in the horde to the center of power, it was hard to remember how to be herself.

"Traps, you want to see the best in him. That's not a bad thing!" Catra continued. "You have a good heart. And maybe you're right, and he needs time before he can come around to help us rebuild. But I don't think that what he did to you is any indication that he could turn over a new leaf after what he did to vast swathes of the planet. Everyone on Etheria has lost something to him… now you have too."

There was a moment of pause as the words sunk in and Entrapta's frown grew larger. The flicker of hope in her chest that she had found a like minded individual, someone who could finally keep up with her and match her enthusiasm for discovery and engineering, was getting further out of her reach.

For the first time that Catra had ever seen, tears welled in Entrapta's eyes. She closed her eyes to hide it, but Catra knew the look well enough.

"I see….." Entrapta said much softer. She took a deep breath. "I need a moment."

Catra stood. "Of course. I… I'm sorry." She began to leave the war room. Entrapta shook her head with a sad smile.

“No, thank you Catra. You didn’t do anything wrong…. I owe you a lot for coming to save me.”

Catra nodded, and left the room again.

She made her way back to the lower medical levels of the castle to rejoin the group. Perhaps later tonight after Entrapta had taken enough time to mull over all that had happened in the past week, she would send Scorpia to check on her with some more aggressive affection. For now, the war was finally over, but they still had much work to do.

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Everyone is safe and sound, but what to do with Huntara?

Huntara crossed her arms and leaned back in the small holding area, spreading her legs to take up room on the bench while she waited for this so-called princess to show up and process her. It was all bullshit. She was the ruler of the wastes, and now one of those dumb jock bug people was going to hold her accountable for just doing business? It wasn't right. She almost growled.

Then the door opened, and the woman herself came in. Huntara scoffed at how someone with such a good height and build, with armor and all, could be such a clutz. Scorpia went through files but clearly had trouble with them in her big claws, as a few papers spilled. Huntara didn't move to grab them either.

"Well thanks for waiting!" Scorpia smiled as though everything in the world were a-okay. "I know, the trip to Safety is pretty long. But you gotta admit, those views, right?"

Huntara sneered, keeping her arms crossed. Her muscles were tense, eager to lash out at the first opportunity. It took every ounce of self restraint to keep from tearing into this stupid place.

"So, can I get you anything? Some water?"

“Cut the crap, princess. What do you want from me?” Huntara glared. “Prison? Join your army?”

“No, no we aren’t like that.” Scorpia waved away the suggestion. “We believe in second chances here. That’s what the New Scorpiani kingdom is all about.”

Huntara rolled her eyes.

“It’s true! That’s why I have an offer for you.” Scorpia sat down at the table across from Huntara.

“What, some sort of plea deal where I rat out my own gang? You can forget it.”

“No actually, not like that.” Scorpia smiled. “I’m in need of a bounty hunter.”

“Oh please. A big softie like you, with an enemy? I wasn’t born yesterday, kid.”

“I can pay you. You would have free range to search so long as you follow any local laws, and I will give your weapons back.”

Huntara squinted suspiciously. “Even if I did take a stupid deal to work for a sissy like you, why should I? I could just take your money and fuck off to where you would never find me.”

“I have a feeling this bounty will intrigue your interests.” Scorpia smiled knowingly. “You are one of the first wave of defectors from the Horde army, yes?”

“How the hell did you know that?”

“Your standard issue boots.”

Huntara growled “Well what does that matter? I still don’t want to be a stupid bounty hunter for the likes of you!”

“What if the bounty was Hordak himself?”

Huntara paused in shock. She leaned in to try and read Scorpia for any minor signs of deceit but found none.

“....bullshit.”

“He’s on the run. But he’s still got dangerous ideas. I figured an ex soldier like yourself would have plenty of reason to find him

when he's weak. I need you to bring him to the Princess council…. *Alive* ." She emphasized.

Huntara raised an eyebrow. The ruthless leader of the evil Horde, with no armor suit, no army, no home base? There are a few choice words that she wanted to share with him for what he put them all through, for the people she lost because the army saw them as disposable.

She folded her hands on the table. "Go on…"

Scorpia smiled.

End Notes

Spoiler: Things gonna go wrong

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